Media Watch

Volume 4 Number 1 ISSN 0976 0911 January 2013

2 Editorial

ARTICLES

4 MICHELANGELO PAGANOPOULOS
The Changing World of Satyajit Ray: Reflections on Anthropology and History

28 SAAYAN CHATTOPADHYAY
Mythology, Masculinity and Indian Cinema: Representation of "Angry Young Man" in Popular Hindi Films of 1970s

40 MAUMITA CHAUDHURI
Vision of Tagore through Applicability in the Spectrum of Ray and Ghosh: Reflection of Feminine Approach in two Bengali Movies

52 MIRA K DESAI
Globalization of Bollywood: Gain of Markets or Loss of Audiences ?

67 ARCHANA R SINGH
Depiction of Contemporary Media: Thematic Analysis of *Pipili Live*

74 VAN ROBERTS & MARK GOODMAN
Dirty Harry as Pornography: Revealing the Unrevealed

84 SANTOSH K. PATRA, RAHUL GADEKAR & PRADEEP KRISHNATRAY
Users' Gratification, Self-Schema and Facebook Behaviour: A Study of Selective Young Facebook Users

95 N. V. PRASAD & SHANTHI BALRAJ
Developing Media Literacy Practice among Secondary School Students in Malaysia: Case Studies of Video Making on Environmental Issues

106 JYOTI RAGHAVAN
Narratives on Metropolitan Cities in Newspaper Supplements: A Case Study of two Leading News Publications of India

117 ROMESH CHATURVEDI & SHRUTI MEHROTRA
Embedded Health Messages in Entertainment-Education Television Programs

127 G K SAHU & SAMEERA KHAN REHMANI
Women as a Maker of Meaning in *No One Killed Jessica*

Editorial

Indian cinema, now synonymous to a unique genre of films, has acquired the academic attention worldwide in the past few decades. When Lumiere Brothers exhibited their silent movie clips in Mumbai Watson's Hotel in 7 July 7 1896, with newspapers quoting it as the 'Miracle of the century', it kindled the imagination of many Indians who are already familiar with the concept of moving images on the screen with the traditional folk plays like shadow or puppet plays. Film industry in India can be hardly put into a general category of Indian film industry as it represent an array of language and style of film making. Even though known as Bollywood for the rest of the world, the 100 years that the industry enviously celebrates is not that of Bollywood, but the Indian film industry in general which took off with the envious venture of Dadasaheb Torne with his first film, *Pundalik* in 12 May 1912 at the Coronation Cinematograph, Bombay. Though it is still a matter of controversy that whether this film or Dadasaheb Phalke's *Raja Harishchandra* should be adorned as the first Indian film, the credit always goes to Marathi film industry (in which language the films belong to)whose legacy is shadowed by the thronging Bollywood.

As with any other film industry, changing societal and political setup always reflected upon Indian cinema perhaps more intensively obvious when compared with its contemporaries. With the introduction of sound, the films slowly shifted from the mythological themes like the noted films of Dadasaheb Phalke, to include more critical social issues like women empowerment, social taboos and humanity best exemplified by films like *Achoot Kanya* and *Amar Jyoti*. As the industry moved ahead, discussion about Indian film industry narrowed down to Hindi film industry, which later began to known as Bollywood.

Bollywood gradually began to look forward to enlarge its audience boundaries that made it global. As such with *Dilwale Dulhaniya LeJayenge*, Bollywood evolved with a fresh outlook capturing the interest of cross border audiences. Perhaps, this global outlook with its unique mix of song, dance, sentiments, western locations and English dialogues made Bollywood or precisely India films, the major entertainment preference for many.

This special edition of *Media Watch* gives film academicians an opportunity and platform to explore and comment on the incessant ideas and ideologies displayed by Indian films and its stand as a global entertainer as it celebrates its centenary jubilee. The articles in this issue ranges from the representation of gender and other social groups to the globalization of Indian film industry.

In the introductory paper, The Changing World of Satyajit Ray: Reflections on Anthropology and History, by Dr Michelangelo Paganopoulous, goes into historical golden era of Satyajit Ray, who adorned the Indian film industry with his unique aesthetics of film making. This essay focuses on the works of this legendary film maker in reflecting upon the complementary relationship between the charismatic *auteur* and the role of the amateur anthropology in an ever-changing world.

It is worth mentioning that 1970s was the golden period of action-oriented popular Indian Hindi cinema. Saayan Chattopadhyay in his paper, Mythology, Masculinity and Indian Cinema: Representation of "Angry Young Man" has traced the antecedents of Indian masculine subjectivity in colonial discourse, and constituted a framework that identifies vestiges of mythological narratives alongside the politico-historical factors, to explain the formation of the belligerent male in the post-independence popular Hindi films.

Mamutia Chaudhuri's paper, Vision of Tagore through Applicability in the Spectrum of Ray and Ghosh: Reflection of Feminine Approach in two Bengali Movies is an analysis of Gurudev Rabindranath Tagore's stories that specifically outlined the

Bengali female characters, identity and situation in movies *Charulata* and *Chokher Bali* directed by world famous directors Satyajit Ray and Rituparno Ghosh.

Mira Desai in her paper, Globalization of Bollywood: Gain of Markets or Loss of Audiences? rejected the general opinion that globalization of Bollywood led to the expansion of market as well as audience. Through audience survey and Box office collection review, she proves that crossover Bollywood business neither created any gain in business nor increased the audience.

Pipli Live, a 2010 movie of Amir Khan Productions evoked exceptional response both from the audience and the critics. The author in this paper, Depiction of Contemporary Media: Thematic Analysis of *Pipili Live* has explored how media conveniently ignored the media. She also focoused certain aspects of media in light of the popular perception in the minds of the common man.

This issue also includes a special invited paper '*Darty Harry* as Pornography: Revealing the Unrevealed' by Van Roberts and Mark Goodman. The paper analyzes how the film makers of *Darty Harry* used the signifiers and ideology of the porn film to reveal the dirty side of society.

****

Though being a special issue on Indian cinema, this special issue is including a few non-film articles from a wide area of media framework due to an increase in queuing of articles for publication. However, these articles deal with some contemporary and critical issues prevailing in the media world.

The impact of the social networking sites has been the most critical issue amidst the harrowing new media revolution. Santhosh and others in Users' gratification, self-schema and Facebook behaviour: A Study of Selective Young Facebook Users' look at the behavioural traits of Facebook users and the ways in which this new media platform gratify user's need and expectation.

Shanthi Balraj and N. V Prasad in Developing Quality Media Literacy Practice among Secondary School Students in Malaysia: Case Studies of Media Making on Environmental Issues aims at a serious issue of media literacy practice among Malaysian students regarding environmental issues. As the world is tormented with climate change and environmental degradation, the authors comment that there is a need for the active participation of students in raising thier concern through various new media platforms, for which they need to understand how to critically assess media content.

Jyoti Raghavan's paper, Narratives on Metropolitan Cities in Newspaper Supplements: Case Study of two leading News Publications of India deals with the news and narratives in newspaper suppliments on major metropolitan cities. Suppliments are more or less a medium to capture the niched advertisements and hence this article tries to show that the issues that these papers deal with a particular city have no relevance for the public.

Health communication is a widely evolving and researched area of communication as it expects the most genuine response from the audience. Romesh Chaturvedi and Shruti Mehrotra in Study on Embedded Health Messages in Entertainment-Education (EE) Based TV Programs have a case studied of a television series *'Sanjivani'*, and found that EE programs were the most cost effective way of health communication.

Besides, this issue also includes a review paper of G. K. Sahu and Sameera Khan Rehmani. Through a case study of *No One Killed Jessica,* the authors identify the evolving new trend of female representation in Bollywood films as not bearer but as a marker of meaning.

Dr. Sony Jalarajan Raj
SPECIAL ISSUE EDITOR
St. Thomas University, Florida, USA
sonyjraj@gmail.com

© *Media Watch* 4 (1) 4- 27, 2013
ISSN 0976-0911 e-ISSN 2249-8818

The Changing World of Satyajit Ray: Reflections on Anthropology and History

MICHELANGELO PAGANOPOULOS
University of London, UK

The visionary Satyajit Ray (1921-1992) is India's most famous director. His visual style fused the aesthetics of European realism with evocative symbolic realism, which was based on classic Indian iconography, the aesthetic and narrative principles of rasa, the energies of shakti and shakta, the principles of dharma, and the practice of darsha dena/ darsha lena, all of which he incorporated in a self-reflective way as the means of observing and recording the human condition in a rapidly changing world. This unique amalgam of self-expression expanded over four decades that cover three periods of Bengali history, offering a fictional ethnography of a nation in transition from agricultural, feudal societies to a capitalist economy. His films show the emotional impact of the social, economic, and political changes, on the personal lives of his characters. They expand from the Indian declaration of Independence (1947) and the period of industrialization and secularization of the 1950s and 1960s, to the rise of nationalism and Marxism in the 1970s, followed by the rapid transformation of India in the 1980s. Ray's films reflect upon the changes in the conscious collective of the society and the time they were produced, while offering a historical record of this transformation of his imagined India, the 'India' that I got to know while watching his films; an 'India' that I can relate to. The paper highlights an affinity between Ray's method of film-making with ethnography and amateur anthropology. For this, it returns to the notion of the charismatic auteur as a narrator of his time, working within the liminal space in-between fiction and reality, subjectivity and objectivity, culture and history respectively, in order to reflect upon the complementary relationship between the charismatic auteur and the role of the amateur anthropologist in an ever-changing world.

Keywords: Indian cinema, Bengali movies, modernity, secularism, cultural identity

This essay focuses on the authorship of the visionary Satyajit Ray (1921-1992) reflecting upon the complementary relationship between the charismatic *auteur* and the role of the amateur anthropology in an ever-changing world. Ray's unique amalgam of film-making fused the

---

As part of the centennial celebration for the 100 years of Indian cinema, this paper returns to the life and work of the visionary Satyajit Ray (1921-1992). It highlights Ray's realist cinema and world vision, in order to reflect upon the complementary relationship between the charismatic auteur and the role of the amateur anthropologist in an ever-changing world.

Correspondence to: Dr. Michelangelo Paganopoulos, 223 Brockley Rise, Forest Hill, SE 23 1 NL, London, United Kingdom. E-mail: paganopoulos@hotmail.com. All rights reserved with *Media Watch*. For permissions and reprint, please e-mail: *mediawatchjournal@gmail.com*

aesthetics of European realism with evocative symbolic realism, which he based on classic Indian iconography, the aesthetic and narrative principles of *rasa*, the energies of *shakti* and *shakta*, the principles of *dharma*, and the practice of *darsha dena/ darsha lena*, all of which he incorporated in a self-reflective way as the means of observing and recording the human condition in a rapidly changing world. Ray's humanism offers a direct critique of a 'western' concept of 'modernity', associated exclusively with the European Enlightenment. By 'a 'western' concept of 'modernity', I will be generally referring to the historical process of the transition from agricultural and feudal economies which were based on collective types of 'mechanical solidarity', to nation states which were based on types of capitalist economies on the basis of 'organic solidarity' (Durkheim [1893]). The transition from agricultural to industrialized societies was parallel to the processes of ocular-centrism (Levin 1993: 1-29), 'disenchantment' (Weber [1904, 1920]), nationalization, industrialization and urbanization, and 're-enchantment' towards a new kind of 'dream world of mass culture' (Walter Benjamin in Buck-Morss 1991: 253-4, and Comaroffs 1993). Arendt (1958) defined this transition as a way of thinking, on the basis of three events: the discovery of America (the collective vision to satisfy the *wanderlust*); the Reformation as the means of morally understanding and categorizing the 'self'; and 'the invention of the telescope and development of a new science that considers [...] the universe' (1998: 248) as the means of morally understanding and categorizing the 'world'.

Amartya Sen (1996/1998: 121-138) argued that Ray's sense of humanitarianism challenges such pre-conceived ideals of a European humanitarianism in the form of a 'progressive' modernity. He pointed out that Ray's films: '[...] share, to varying extends, a well-articulated "anti-modernism", rejecting, in particular, "Western" forms of modernization... [i.e.] "our modernism"'. Ray's film-making, set on the margins in-between his Bengali identity, European education, and Indian culture, opens the channels of communication between presumably 'opposite' cultures, questioning the Orientalist distinction between 'East' and 'West'. For Sen: '[…] the issue can be discussed only in *dialectical* terms. The characterization of an idea as "purely Western" or "purely Indian" can be very illusory. The origin of ideas is not the kind of thing which "purity" happens easily' (*Ibid*). The rigid opposition between 'East' and 'West' in terms of the European Enlightenment echoes anthropology's legacy as its by-product, with morally ethnocentric dichotomies such as 'primitive' and 'civilized', 'authentic' and 'hybrid', 'modernity' and 'tradition', 'history' and 'myth', and so on[1] . In this polarised context, modernity, with its humanistic ideals, professional practice, and political correctness, is misconceived as *exclusively* European (i.e. 'western'), i.e. defined in terms of '"civilization", "social progress", "economic development", "conversion", and the like' (Comaroffs 1993: xxx). Yet, as early as 1919, Weber's discussion of post-war European society questioned 'progress': '[…] because death is meaningless, civilized life as such in meaningless […] "progressiveness"' (1968: 299). In Ray's films 'modernity' is not visualized as a static condition that separates 'Us' from 'Them' in terms of 'progress'; 'progress', scientific or otherwise, without a collective appropriation of humanist values, is simply *not* progress.

This essay pays a tribute to Ray's film-making by critically examining modernity as an impersonal, alienating, fast-moving, process of rapid change. It examines particular aspects of modernity in relation to Ray's films: ocular-centrism (*Pather Panchali* 1955), disenchantment (*Devi* 1960), private alienation (*Charulata* 1964) and social alienation (*Pratiwandi* 1970-1), through his symbolic use of objects of modernity: the train, the binoculars, the book, the mirror, the forbidden love *prem*, tourism, imported cigarettes and Mercedes cars, among other objects of science and desire. In this way, the essay will be reflecting on the historical predicament of

anthropology as a colonial by-product of European modernity, focusing on Ray's caricature of the 'anthropologist' in *Agantuk* (1992): the lost, long-forgotten uncle returning to a 'home' that does not belong to him anymore.

The Stranger

Agantuk (translated as 'The Stranger' or 'The Visitor') was Satyajit Ray's last feature, produced in 1991 and 1992, the year of the director's death. The film was based on Ray's short story entitled *Atithi* ('The Guest'). It completes his life and working cycle, stretching over four decades: from the declaration of Independence (1947) and the period of industrialization and secularization of India in the 1950s and 1960s, to the rise of nationalism and Marxism in the 1970s, followed by the rapid transformation of India in the 1980s. *Agantuk*'s opening sequence depicts the arrival of the protagonist of the film, Manomohan Mitra (played by Utpal Dutt), a lost uncle, returning to Kolkata on a train after thirty-five years of absence. He is an experienced, clean-shaved gentleman, who confidently places his feet on the wagon seat. He is wearing polished shoes, but has no etiquette manners. At 'home' nobody remembers or recognizes him, and he is treated suspiciously even by his own family. Following the constant interrogation by his niece Anila (played by Mamata Shankar), and her suspicious husband Sudhindra (Deepankar Dey), the uncle explains his long absence by portraying his outcast condition as that of an 'anthropologist'. He disappeared for four decades because he wanted to satisfy his curiosity about the world: first, in terms of understanding what is thought to be 'primitive' and 'civilized'; and second, to satisfy his '*wanderlust'*, the urge to travel, to learn, and to question. He is the caricature of the lost 'anthropologist', a modern Odysseus returning to his long-forgotten and unrecognizable Ithaca. This caricature is never confirmed or renounced, but throughout the film the Stranger remains an ambiguous, *liminoid* persona, in-between the unrecognizable 'home' and the 'world'. Only in the end of the film, he finally rests in the back garden, the only space that survived the rapid changes that took place during his absence. Just like a Buddha, the Stranger finally finds rest under the tree of knowledge and wisdom.

This anthropological calling in many ways also refers to the *auteur* himself. The four decades of the uncle's absence echo the four decades of the director's work. For those familiar with Ray's films, the opening sequence of *Agantuk* feels as if the boy-trickster Apu, from the director's world-famous debut *Pather Panchali* ('Song of the Little Road' 1955), grew up into an 'anthropologist'. Ray's unique authority is aesthetically expressed with the observant realist style of his camera, the Apu's Eye (as I will call it), which he first introduced in his debut *Pather Panchali* in 1955. The Apu's Eye refers to a particular way of positioning the camera from the point of view of a child (famously adopted in Steven Spielberg's *ET)*. Cooper (2000) exclaimed that the use of the Apu's Eye illustrates the aesthetic value of the epiphany of wonderment (*camatkara*) according to the classical Hindu aesthetical form of *rasa* ('flavours/ moods/ modes of affect'). These moods refer to the emotional 'comprehension of the directly experienced "inward life" that all art conveys', as 'a guiding principle behind the creation' (2000: 16-17, 26-31)[2] . The curiosity of the child is illustrated in *Pather Panchali*'s train sequence (*see* Table 1 with 'Train Sequence' in Appendix), in which while the arrival of the train scares Apu's older sister Durga (Runki Banerjee), Apu's curious eyes are wide open in wonderment, embracing the marvels of this fast-moving machine, whose metallic sounds rip the peaceful countryside apart. His curiosity is accompanied by an innocent, emotional detachment, as illustrated in the end of the film by his playful realization of his sister death.

In *Agantuk,* the Apu's Eye point of view is given to Satyaki (Bikram Bhattacharaya), the Stranger's nephew, who remains indifferent to his parents' worries about his uncle's sudden

appearance to a 'home' that is not his anymore. This old uncle and the young nephew share a paradoxical alienation from, as the means of engaging with, the world. This self-alienating condition is affine to the alienation of the ethnographer in the field. Similarly to the ethnographic eye, Apu's Eye has to remain distant and detached, amoral and creative at the same time, *distanciated*, in order to function as a higher (a)moral force that allows the viewer to enter this world from an insider's perspective. It is distant, ethnographic, neo-romantic, 'innocent eye' of a visionary fieldworker; the observant 'seer' (as in Grimshaw 2001: 45), filled with childlike curiosity, and playful indifference. Ray's detached, realist point of view allowed him to critically reflect upon the world in his respective historical time. His 'Strange', paradoxical condition, being part of the same world (i.e. 'Calcutta') from which he is alienated, echoes discussions of the artist as an ethnographer and vice versa (Clifford and Marcus 1986, Foster 1996, Gell 1999, and Grimshaw 2001, among others).

In *Pather Panchali*, Apu's detached perspective exposes the hypocrisy of village life, by juxtaposing dreamy scenes from the life of the two children in the forest, enchanted with the amazing music score of Ravi Shankar, against cruel dialogue in scenes portraying everyday life, gossip, corruption, cruelty, accusation, jealousy, social suffocation, isolation, and desperation. In this dialectical way, Ray highlighted issues of poverty, lack of education, and religious superstition. In front of this misery, human relationships, particularly between Durga and Indira, and Apu and his mother, feel like oasis in a world of suffering, from which, however, Apu's innocent perspective remains detached. In this suffocating world, the appearance of the train in Apu's life is also the means to escape from it. The Train, the most recognizable object of modernity associated with urbanization and rapid industrialization, is used throughout Ray's film-making as a carrier of internal and external changes, both on the personal level of his characters, as well as, in Bengali society. In *Pather Panchali*'s train sequence (*see* Table 1 with 'Train Sequence' in Appendix) the appearance of the train anticipates Apu's move from the countryside to the big city, and his transformation from a curious child to a responsible father. Apu's upbringing is contextualized within the changing *mise-en scene* of the film, from village life of absolute poverty to the crowded apartments of the new Calcutta. In a parallel manner, Ray portrays the internal transformation of the boy to a man, along with the historical transition from an agricultural and religious state, supported by a feudal economy, to the new democratic India. As Ganguly pointed, the trilogy generally reflects positively on Nehru's modernization project, which began following the Indian Independence in 1947. Ray's 'emphasis on English, science, and geography is a vindication of the values of Bengali Renaissance, which are also the values of Nehru's modern India' (2000: 24). The latter was 'characterized by an ethos of citizenly solidarity with the poor, middle-class Indians were cast as the agents and overseers of industrialization and developmental schemes for rural communities, and also as the guardians of the normative morality that preserved the social fabric of the modernizing nation' (McGuire 2011: 120). This collective optimism is illustrated in the final scene of the third film, *Apur Sansar,* in which the middle-aged, bearded Apu holds his son on his shoulder, as they both stare at the future in the bright sunlight.

This optimism was challenged in the second film of the trilogy, *Aparajito* (1956), in which the train becomes a symbol of dislocation, separation, and a vain hope for reunification. In this film, the train contains a new set of problems in family relationships that rose because of the rapid urbanization of India, with the new generation of educated Bengalis leaving behind their families and village poverty for a new life in the big city. Ray's disillusion with Nehru's modernizing project continues in *Nayak* (Hero 1966), in which the train becomes the static mechanical setting, juxtaposed to a rapidly passing landscape seen from the carriage's window, as the

constructed image of the protagonist film star, is gradually exposed until his ultimate alienation is revealed. Similarly, in Ray's adaptations of Tagore's short stories (as in *Charulata* 1964 and in *Ghare-Baire* 1984), the sound of the train off-screen anticipates sudden and often cruel and unpredictable change, becoming a source of anxiety. Finally, in *Agantuk,* the forgotten uncle returns to Kolkata on a train, to an unrecognizable and alienated 'home'. In sum, in Ray's films, the train is a 'gift' of modernity to the world, in the sense of Marcel Mauss's 'gift': 'on the one hand, a gift, and on the other, a poison' (2002/1954: 81): an object of modernity which connects the home to the world, the village to the city, different individuals to each other, their memories, their intentions and expectations, while carrying the collective hopes and painful disillusionment of an entire nation.

Ray's unique artistic authority was the result of his cosmopolitan upbringing. His family was relatively wealthy, with a reputation in the arts and literature, going back to fifteen generations (Banerjee 1996: 6, 7-9). His grandfather Upendra Kishore Raychowdhury, and his father Sukumar Ray were illustrators of children's stories in their magazine *Sandesh*. From an early age, the young Ray came in contact with Indian mythology, as well as, various different forms of narration (epic stories, biographies, and comedy). He was well-educated, with studies in arts and music, as well as, a degree in Economics from the Presidency College in Calcutta, followed by further education and in British and American institutions. In his trips inside and outside India, he came in contact with various intellectuals, including the film director Jean Renoir, son of the famous Impressionist painter, and Jean Luc Goddard, who was a major influence on Ray's political films in the 1970s. His debut 'Apu trilogy' (*Pather Panchali* filmed in 1955, followed by *Aparajito* in 1956, and concluding with *Apur Sansar* in 1959) acknowledged the influence of European neorealist cinema of Jean Renoir and Vittorio de Sica, using amateur actors, long semi-improvised takes, a multi-vocal and multi-layered script shot on location, and using natural light when possible, while also introducing the cinematographer Subrata Mitra's bouncing light: the use of white sheets and mirrors to imitate natural light (Banerjee 1996: 14, Ganguly 2000: 3, among others). The director pointed out in an interview that the realistic depiction of the forest was exclusively imagined in nostalgic ways as a lost Bengali past [*Satyajit Ray*, Channel 4 UK 2/5/1991]. Despite its manufactured realism, *Pather Panchali* won the first prize for the 'Best Human Document' in Cannes in 1956, instigating Ray's 'humanist' reputation for being a 'Bengali Renaissance Man'.

> The trilogy consolidated, very early in his career, the nature of Ray's humanism. Living in an emerging Marxist intellectual ambience in Bengal, Ray held on to his Tagorean beliefs and rejected the methodology of Marxism. The crux of this social philosophy lies in the importance of the growth of the individual mind and the influence idealism exercises, through religion and art to prevent it from extreme self-seeking at the cost of the welfare of others. The goodness of the individual, in this view, is the basis of social growth (Dasgupta 2001: 52)

Ray's humanism shared the aesthetical values found in Rabindranath Tagore's music, paintings, prose and poetry, as acknowledged in his commissioned documentary produced in 1961 in honour of the poet's centennial (1861-1941). Tagore's influence on Ray's films can be felt both aesthetically, in the music and rhythm of his early films, as in *Devi* (Goddess 1960), and in narrative terms, in his adaptation of Tagore's short stories that focus on the emancipation of women in 19th century Bengal, in *Teen Kanya* (Three Daughters 1961), *Charulata* (Lonely

Wife 1964), and *Ghare Baire* (Home and World 1984). Both Tagore and Ray wrote about an imagined melting pot, a fast-changing multicultural 'Calcutta', used as an everyday arena in which heterogeneous cultures communicate with, and/or contest against, each other. They were both travellers, motivated by the *wanderlust:* the internal urge to travel, to question, and to learn, as expressed in *Agantuk* by the caricature of the lost uncle. During his life, Tagore visited more than thirty countries, and came in contact with several intellectuals, including Ezra Pound, Thomas Mann, George Bernard Shaw, H.G. Wells, and Roman Rolland, scientists such as Albert Einstein, the Persian mystic Hafez, and even with the fascist Mussolini (Dutta and Robinson 1995: 315, and 374-376). The experience of travelling for both Tagore and Ray thus, not only engaged them with other peoples, ideas, and habits, but also resulted in keeping a distance from their own Bengali culture, while still living in Calcutta. Their sense of alienation from 'home' enabled them to observe and record the impact of the social, economic, and political changes brought by the Train of modernity on the personal lives of their fictional characters, and to critically reflect upon the historical and sociological issues of their respective times.

A Study of Disenchantment: *Devi* (1960)

Both Ray and Tagore were members of the Brahmo class, which was 'founded by Raja Rammohan Roy, an eminent intellectual of the 19th century, (who) rejected idolatry and caste; the Brahmos were interested in social reform and in changing of existing social systems' (Banerjie 1996:7). In this context, they were eager to express a distaste (and sometimes pity) for the caste system and the inherited inequalities of feudalism. Ray portrayed the disintegration of the *zamindar* system with *Jalsaghar* (Music Room 1958) and *Devi* (Goddess 1960). While *Jalsaghar* takes a rather pitiful view of the delusional *zamindar* Biswambhar Roy, whose music room is an imagined remnant of a nostalgic past, *Devi* is a much more forceful film in exposing the hypocrisy of the old elite through the character of Kalikinkar Roy (Chhabi Biswas), a *zamindar* father-figure of the village, who dreams that his daughter-in-law Doyamoyee (Sharmila Tagore) to be the reincarnation of the goddess Durga. His superstition (*andhvishwas*/ 'blind belief') is materialized by imprisoning her in a temple and making her a public spectacle. *Devi* is based on Mukherjee's story, written in the 1890s. The original story takes place in 1790s, but the film is set in 1870 in Chandipur, rural Bengal, in order to highlight the issues regarding the social reforms of the time the novel was written: 'Uma's pride in his English education, which he calls "new learning" as opposed to his father's "old learning," based on studies of Tantra and Shakti' (Basu 2004).

Doya is the young wife of the open-minded Uma (Soumitra Chatterjee). The film begins with Uma's departure to Calcutta to study, leaving Doya alone in the house with her father-in-law, and her brother-in-law (Purnendu Mukherjee), his wife (Karuna Banerjee) and their young boy Koka. Following Kalikinkar's vision of Doya as *Ma*, the possessive *zamindar* lord displaces her in the village's temple as *his* holy Mother, who will perform miracles and protect *his* village from destitute, illness, and death. However, the death of an ill child on her lap exposes Doya as a symbol of womanhood rather than a 'Goddess'. In the end of the film, Doya tries to escape from the masculine world that imprisoned her, disappearing in a field of wheat that leads to a lake. At first, her act looks as irrational, as she ignores her husband's efforts to move together to the big city; neither has she adopted her uncle's abusive point of view at any point of the film. She might submit to his vision, as she is conventionally meant to, but she never fully identifies with it. Doya's final disappearance forms the central paradox of the film: it is an act of denial, as well as, an act of acceptance, that echoes several myths regarding the Mother Goddess, for

instance in the form of Uma: 'Shiva's gentle wife and the daughter of Menaka and Himalaya, who, standing in for the missed daughters of youth, evokes real longing' (McDermott 2011: 76), and/or in the form of the ascending Parvati, who 'went to the mountain and laid aside her ornaments and put on garments made of the bark of trees' (O'Flaherty 1975: 256).

Furthermore, Doya's final exit is identical with the closing ceremonies of Durga/Kali's celebration, which are depicted in a documentary style in the opening sequence of the film (*see* Table 2.1 in Appendix). The opening credits of *Devi* begin with a close-up of a faceless white statue of *Ma,* evolving into a sacred mask, and finally to a statue of Kali on a tableau, becoming alive in a temple though public worship, songs, and decorations, before it is thrown in the Ganges at the end of the festivities. This ethnographically abstract portrayal of the rite of passage of the persona of the *Ma,* a masculine archetypal symbol of Motherhood, Creation and Destruction, portrays the evolution of the abstract faceless form of the symbol into a ritual mask and then into a social persona becoming alive through ritual. It echoes Mauss's essay on 'the notion of the person' and the 'notion of the self', in which he drew the evolution of the 'persona' from the sacred use of masks in rituals to the legal constitution of the Roman person, and through the Christian moral person to contemporary psychological ideas of the 'self' (1985/1938: 1-25). In similar terms, *Devi* portrays the evolution of the archetypal symbol to the *liminal* mask, and from the mask to the temple, where she becomes a living Goddess, disappearing in the muddy waters of the sacred river.

The evolution of the mask to a social persona anticipates the rite of passage of Doya from a young innocent girl to a living goddess, adorned and worshipped by a male crowd. In the film, she is made to wear the social mask of *Ma*, unwillingly transforming herself into a material manifestation of her father-in-law's vision; thus, becoming a living extension of the mask. Similarly to the opening credits, Kalikinkar's dark vision (*see* Table 2.2 in Appendix) begins with a slow zoom-in and close-up on the face of Doya, which gradually transforms into the luminous face of Durga/Kali. A strong white light highlights the face of the archetype of *Ma* contrasting to the black background of Kalikinkar's vision. For both Jung and Durkheim ritual life was above all a matter of personal *experience,* opening the way to connect to the wider collective (i.e. 'society'), both in the form of consciousness or in respect to the unconscious, through the luminous experiential concept of 'numinous' (Otto 1958: 5-11, and Paganopoulos 2010: par.1, 3). Kalikinkar's vision idealizes Doya's face, visualized as a luminous *Imago Dei* in Jung's terms, or in Hindu philosophy, a mirror of the illusion of the 'inner self' (*Jiva*), which is 'only revealed by intuition, by revelation, when it is understood to be one with the universal spirit (*atman*, *purusa*)' (Morris 1994: 78). By contrast, the dark Shadow of Kalikinkar carries: 'an emotional nature, a kind of autonomy, and accordingly an obsessive or, better, possessive quality' (*CW Vol. 9 Part II*, 1968: 8-11). Gradually, this luminous image of the sacred ideal of *Ma*, dissolves into the sad face of Doya. A zoom-out reveals her positioning, sitting in the centre of the village's temple at daylight, and being the focus of attention by her devoted and desperate spectators. A series of juxtapositions of gazes further reveals the extent of the collective devotion attributed to her alleged healing, protective, and forgiving powers. A reverse angle then reveals Doya's/Durga's gaze, facing this collectively irrational situation from which she is alienated as a result of being the sacred focus of attention. Her higher position in the frame, looking down at those worshipping her, illustrates the intimacy of the visual exchange between goddess and worshippers.

Bhatti and Pinney defined the exchange of looks in the context of *puja* (worship) as *darshan dena* and *darshan lena* ('giving and taking' *darshan*, 2011: 226). In a Durkheimian, moral sense, the good 'energy' of *darshan* is seen as collective. On this moral basis, it is

opposed to self-interest, envy, greed, and egoism, which are the sources of *nazar lagjani* ('evil eye'). This moral opposition of *darshan* and *nazar* echoes Durkheim's contrast of 'religion' to 'magic', the former defined in terms of common good (collective), the latter in terms of self-interest (*Ibid*.: 238). However, although Kalikinkar's paternal gaze superficially takes the form of *darshan,* this is accompanied by his envy (i.e. *nazar)* towards his incompetent son. In the sense, *Devi* offers a dynamic moral reverse of the Durkheimian model of the sacred community, as Ray does approach 'religion' as then unifying, external, and *a priori* 'sacred' force (1912) but as an arena of contestation, change, and competition between individual actors. This competition takes place through the juxtaposition of gazes, which illustrates Bhatti and Pinney's concept of 'opti-clash': giving and taking *darshan* is understood in terms of reciprocity, a kind of a 'gift' in Mauss's terms, referring simultaneously to cure and poison (from the Greek *pharmakon, Ibid*.: 228, 238).

In this context, Kalikinkar' vision is a false one; it is not a divine revelation, but rather a symptom of his own Freuidian sexual frustrations (Cooper 2000: 108, 164-6). These are manifested in the antagonism towards his son, and the way he gazes at his daughter-in-law, accompanied by several sexual innuendos throughout the film. These details constantly reveal his selfishness as sexual obsession. Yet, the film is about female *Shakti*: 'within herself (every) woman contains *Shakti*, the tension between cohesion and disintegration, often translated as "energy"' (Caplan 1996: 280). It is because of the sexual oppression and selfishness of her father-in-law that her *Shakti* is repressed, and leads her to the tragic end, as she disappears into the river. Doya does not act in her husband's rational terms and move with him to the big city, but disappears in a dream-world, liberating her imprisoned gaze in the dark waters of the abyss of the soul. This kind of suicide allows her *Shakti* to find full and total expression in a world that has been repressing it. In this dynamic context, Doya's disappearance is not a passive act of suicide, but an intentional break that results to the social marginalization of Kalikinkar and to his public exposure for his greed and envy.

In his much later film about male *Shakti*, entitled *Sadgati* (Deliverance 1981), which was a re-adoption of a Hindu novel by Premchand for the TV, Ray further attacked the inequalities inherited within the feudal system, in the face of another hypocrite and self-indulgent priest-landlord, who like a blackmailer uses his traditional status to exploit his servant. The servant's name is Dukhi, meaning 'the one who is always in pain', and who belongs to the lowest caste strata of *Sudra* (the servant farmer/ cultivator). This late TV film production was a return to Ray's early neorealist aesthetic, and negotiated the caste system through the concepts of *Shakti* and the inert *shakta*, the lowest state of human existence (Cooper 2000: 189-197). As in *Devi*, *Shakta* refers to the blocking of the channels that allow *Shakti* to be expressed, to the point of death. Similar to Kalikinkar's self-piety in *Devi*, *Sadgati*'s opening sequences portray the landlord's rituals that demonstrate his absolute *bhakti* (devotion), as well as, his high status and authority. But his cruelty and exploitation of Dukhi and his family do not remain unpunished, as Ray reverses the concepts of *dharma* (moral duty) and *karma* (rebirth) in the context of death as *moksha* (transcendence) and *Sadgati* (deliverance): while the landlord is expected to transcend to a higher level of existence because of his 'pure' way of life that forbids contact in terms of food and touch, ironically, he is left with the dead and polluting body of Dukhi which he has to deliver and dispose, thus, wasting his own *Shakti*. In this way, the film anticipated current political discussions, by progressive writers such as Sukhadeo Thorat (2004), focusing on the rights of Dalits in a global context.

In sum, *Devi* and *Sadgati* offer *experiential* understandings of *how* the caste system works, focusing on the inequalities it inherits, with open-ending narratives that allow several interpretations of the content. Further, the two films show a society on change, with historical and political implications projected directly on the life of the characters. This offers a much

more realistic and dynamic picture of the 'caste' system, rather than Louis Dumont (1972) for instance, who famously argued in *Homo Hierarchicus* that: 'equality and hierarchy are not, in fact, opposed to each other' but they are in a complementary relationship in daily life (1972: 306), thus, naturalizing the caste system as a way of social stratification. In his criticism of Dumont's approach to the caste system, Deliege (2011) associated this Durkheimian holistic view of Indian 'society' as 'akin to analyzing European society exclusively through the Bible', which excluded individual agency and historical change through the static 'lenses of hierarchy and purity' (2011: 45-6). By contrast, *Devi* and *Sadgati* challenged the ideal of a sacred village community, based on European stereotypes of purity and pollution as frequently used in anthropology in the 1960s and 1970s, focusing instead on stories of socially oppressed individuals, while exposing the self-interest and motivations of their feudal landlords. By using the openness and symbolic richness of photography, Ray readapted the three evolving Bengali images of the Mother Goddess within a contemporary context, in order to show *how* traditional ideas and concepts can be used and abused for personal interest, offering a modern moral tale of disillusion with the past and re-enchantment with the future.

Objects of Modernity

Ray's adaptation of Tagore's *Nastanirh* ('Broken Nest' written in the 1880s) in *Charulata* ('Lonely Wife' filmed in 1964) offers another critical disillusion with the emancipating promise of modernity. In *Charulata,* this is expressed by the libido of Charu, a bored bourgeois wife played masterfully by Madhabi Mukherjee. *Charulata* is set in Calcutta in the 1880s. Charu is married to Bhupati (played by Sailen Mukherjee), the publisher of the progressive journal *The Sentinel* -similarly to Ray's grandfather-. He smokes a pipe, uses English phrases, and is totally devoted to the publication of his journal. However, he completely ignores her presence, as she is left alone in her golden cage, just like her birds. Instead, he has hired an English teacher to educate Charu in English songs and good manners. But his perfect, bourgeois world is shattered in a kind of Penter-ian way, by the arrival of his younger cousin, the sensitive, carefree, and poetic Amal (Soumitra Chatterjee) with whom Charu falls in love.

The film begins with Charu walking around an empty, but heavily decorated house, surrounded by Victorian furniture, a French mirror, a clock, a romantic painting of Venus, and her closest companion: the binoculars, through which she looks at the world from her half-shut window of her bedroom *(see* Table 3.1 'Opening Sequence' in Appendix). The binoculars offer a new way of constructing knowledge about the world outside her room; a modern (i.e. 'emancipating') way of looking, recording, and understanding the world *from a distance*. They offer her the means of escaping the masculine world that has imprisoned her into this materially decorated -but spiritually empty- house, in which she is placed by her liberal husband. This urge to liberate the female self from the constraints of the masculine, bourgeois world is manifested as *prem*, or the 'forbidden love', which was one of the favourite themes of Tagore's stories. The imported mirror, upon which both Charu prepares for her husband, is a symbol of European adjustment, based on the internal and external world of male desire. The *prem*, seen as imported from the 'West' similarly to binoculars and French mirrors, is expressed as the secret feeling of Charu for Amal, and manifested in her gaze towards him. Ganguly (2000: 66-68) highlighted the power of her 'forbidden gaze' as the means of giving her agency. Charu's playful Eye subverts the norm of the submissive look of Doya in *Devi*. Yet, in the end of the film the promise of emancipation and equality is proved to be an illusion, just like the false promise of the romantic *prem*. It is this moral realization of the destructive powers of sexuality, which associates uncontrolled sexuality with 'animality', and conversely portrays women 'as constantly tempting men away from the path of reason and morality' (as in Seidler 1987: 87). This rationality morally

subordinates women, by placing them in the house, in which they are meant to be controlled[3] .

Spivak discussed Tagore's short stories along with 'the constitution of the feminine subject in colonial vernacular literature', making a parallel connection of Tagore's use of the romantic motif *prem,* to teaching English to Indian students, which makes the use of English feel like a 'burden' (1993: 139-140). Charu's burden is visualized as an entrapment within the false premises of the modern age. Despite Ganguly praising Ray for taking the 'woman's point of view', he highlights Charu's 'precarious privacy': 'we sense how [...] *her space* is invaded constantly' (Ganguly 2000: 66, *my emphasis)*. This emphasis on a woman's precariousness is in essence what stereotypically defines 'women'. In this context, despite the emancipating theme of the film, the 'forbidden gaze' does not give agency to Charu, but rather confirms the stereotypical division of space in terms of 'female', internal, and private spaces, and 'male', external, public spaces. This re-affirms the conventional framing of 'women' as representing 'the privacy of the group' on the cultural basis of sexuality and gender as manifested in terms of private and public spaces (as in Caplan 1987: 15). Ganguly expands on Charu's visual entrapment to the audience gaze:

> In fact, all the ambivalences of Charu's position as gazer and being gazed at are encapsulated by the camera as it spies on her and defines her predicament as a woman –always under surveillance but powerless to retaliate [...] In our privileged position we feel empowered by the mere fact that we can see her –or rather spy on her- while she cannot (Ganguly 2000: 72)

Ray's framing of Charu illustrates the 'voyeuristic scopophillic' point of view in Laura Mulvey's terms, which characterizes the mainstream, dominant, phalo-cratic camera, in the context of pleasure and sexual politics (1975/2009: 18). Charu, as well as, other female characters in Ray's films, such as Doya in *Devi*, Labanya and Monisha in *Kanchanjungha* (1962), Arati in *Mahanagar* (Big City 1963) Sutapa (Siddhartha's sister in *Pratidwand*i 1971), and Bimala in *Ghare-Baire* (Home and the World 1984) are portrayed as entrapped by, and within, a masculine world divided by gender in terms of private and public, 'female' and 'male' spaces respectively. They are forbidden to enter into the public sphere, and instead, they are portrayed as being entrapped in the minds and eyes of their fathers, brothers, husbands, and even, within the scopophillic eye of the audience in itself. The precariousness of Charu and her entrapment in a world dominated by male vision is amplified by the binoculars which bring her close to the forbidden world, which however is not allowed to experience or touch. It is this paradoxical alienation from the world (i.e. a 'modernist' condition) that results to her absolute loneliness. This inner feeling is symbolized by the binoculars, an object of modernity and science, as the means of emancipating herself from the bourgeois world that confines her at home.

Charu's binoculars share an affinity with Malinowski's binoculars: Charu's alienation echoes Malinowski's alienation in the field, as expressed in the post-mortem publication of his diary in 1967. Infamously, Malinowski's diary contradicted his claim for a 'scientific' methodology and 'objective distance' rather revealing his emotional entrapment and social isolation from the Pacific world he studied (Clifford 1986: 7-14, and Paganopoulos 2007, among others). In the same, static way Charu watches the world moving outside from her top window, Malinowski stared at 'them' from the safety of his cabin[4] . Both characters, the real Malinowski and the fictional Charu, are entrapped by, and within, the modernist condition, ideologically misconceived in the exclusive terms of the European Renaissance: Malinowski in his cabin in fear of contact

with the world, 'primitive' or 'civilized' no matter; while Charu in a masculine world divided by gender in terms of private and public, 'female' and 'male' spaces respectively, which she is forbidden to cross. Instead, she is entrapped within the 'scientific' minds and eyes of her husband, and through him, within the scopophillic eye of the audience in itself. Her en-framed social imprisonment further illustrates the impact of modernity as an ocular-centric process: 'increasingly reified, closed, restricted, narrowed, tightened, distorted, and destructively fixated in representations –of self, of others, of knowledge, truth, and reality- that interpret the visible world by imposing confrontations of opposition between subject and object' (as in Levin's reading of Heidegger, 1993: 5-6).

Twenty years after filming *Charulata*, Ray filmed another of Rabindranath Tagore's *prem* stories, *Ghare-Baire* ('Home and the World', 1984). The two films share a common narrative plot and characters, but the historical and social context in which they were filmed is very different. *Ghare-Baire* narrates the life of another alienated young woman, Bimala (played enigmatically by Swatileka Sengupta). She is married to a liberal husband. Nikhil (Victor Banerjee) is more sensitive than Bhupati, as he actively wishes to liberate his wife from the feudal patriarchy, but as in Charulata, his optimism is shattered by the arrival of his older cousin, the passionately patriotic Sandip, who enchants Bimala with his fiery speeches. Significantly, both characters of Amal and Sandip are played by the same actor, Soumitra Chatterjee, however, with a twenty year gap between the two roles. Accordingly, although they are both patriots, the young Amal returns to the Bengali roots through his poetry, while the older Sandip through his rationalized ultra-nationalism as an active member of the Swadeshi movement.

As in other historical films made by Ray in the 1970s, such as Premchand's *Shatranj-ke-Khilari* (Chess Players 1977), Ray directly associates sexuality to politics, often connecting male impotence to political indecision and self-delusion of men who fail to take control of *their* history (Cooper 2000: 152, and Dube 2005: 154). In this context, both *Charulata* and *Ghare-Baire* offer powerful political allegories about the time they were filmed: *Charulata,* filmed in 1964, reflects upon the collective disillusionment with Nehru's project of modernization through the character of Bhubati, who fails by his own expectations. On the other hand, through the character of Sandip, *Ghare-Baire* makes a parallel association of the Swadeshi movement (1905-1908) with the rise of ultra-nationalism in the 1970s, along with the 'emergency state' imposed by Indira Gandhi in 1975. The Swadeshi was the first nationalist movement following the foundation of the Congress in 1885. The movement reacted to the British interference in Indian affairs, particularly regarding the division imposed on the local population in terms of class and religion, which they saw as responsible for the political unrest of the time, as well as, to the issue of poverty, that instigated a general social unrest. The Swadeshi promoted a 'return' to Indian culture, while calling for the massive boycott of all foreign products. Ironically, despite being a by-product of post-colonialism, the Swadeshi movement portrayed itself as anti-modernist. *Ghare-Baire* makes clear, however, that despite the movement's promises, the Indian people, and particularly traders, would not support such a move. They could not be separated from the modernist discourse.

Both Tagore and Ray felt Strangers at 'home'; *entrapped* in-between British colonialism and Indian nationalism; an imprisoned condition of Bengali identity, which Tagore elegantly expressed in his widely appraised essay on 'Nationalism in India' (Tagore and Chakravarty 1961: 182, and Dutta and Robinson 1995: 304). As Sen put it: 'The tragedy, as Tagore saw it, came from the fact that what "was truly best in their [British] own civilization, the upholding of dignity in human relationships, has no place in the British administration of this country" (Tagore cited in Sen 1998: 107). In this context, Ray's last film *Agantuk* is a self-confessional testament

of the director's marginality, set in-between the artistic tradition of his Brahma family and the so-called 'Bengali Renaissance', and on the other, his European education and bourgeois upbringing, which were seen either as contradictory, or as complementary, to his 'Indianess' (Dasgupta 1994: 7, Cooper 2000: 74 and 7-11, and Ganguly 2000: 1-10, among others). However, a rigid dichotomy between 'tradition and modernity as well as Indian and European modernity makes it impossible to take full account of the contestations that animated the creative efforts to fashion a vibrant culture and politics of anti-colonial modernity' (Boise and Jalal 1997: 90). In this sense, Tagore's and Ray's fusion of Indian with European aesthetic values (i.e. the female gaze) and narratives (i.e. *prem*) challenges the misconception of 'authentic', traditional cultures, as opposed to 'hybrid', modern cultures, while strengthening 'the ability to contest Western colonial power in the arena of politics and the state' (*Ibid*.). Seen in its totality, the work of the poet Tagore and the film-director Ray articulates a kind of self-critical historical consciousness as the means of actively raising a collective self-awareness between the past and the future: 'between what is done and what can be done' (Ranciere 2006: 39)[5] . In this context, the study of history, instead of a passive, allegedly 'objective', narrator of the past, rather becomes a political agent of dynamic change; the moral means to think about a better future.

Politics of Inequality

Ray further developed the feeling of entrapment in contemporary social issues, as portrayed in his 'Calcutta trilogy': Sunil Ganguli's *Pratidwand*i ('The Adversary', 1970-1), and Sankar's *Seemabaddha* ('Company Ltd', 1971), and *Jana Aranya* ('The Middle Man', 1975). *Pratidwand*i was produced four years after the Naxalbari uprising in 1967 in West Bengal. It anticipated a decade of political and economic turbulence, the wars with Pakistan and China, and the polarization of India in political extremes, from ultra-nationalists to Maoists. This period of terror culminated with the betrayal and assassination of Indira Gandhi by her Sikh bodyguards, who were fighting for a separate state of Khalistan, in October 1984 (Rashiduzzaman 1989: 128, and in Boise and Jalal 1997: 182, 185, Shah 2011: 333, among others). Ray's films portray these times of collective disillusionment with the unfulfilled promises of Nehru's project, democracy as political oppression, alongside the dismantling of old family structures, the increasing feeling of personal isolation and desperation in overpopulated, alienating, urban settings, and the rise of inequality, unemployment, street violence, and nostalgia for a lost imagined past (i.e. the imagined, magical forest in *Pather Panchali*).

Ray's angriest film, *Pratidwand*i, portrays the journey of Siddhartha, a young, passionate, modern Buddha, walking aimlessly up and down the streets of the new Calcutta in search for a job. Large sections of the film take place in the oppressive *mise-en-scene* of public offices, where slow-panning long-takes portray the desperate faces and tired bodies of silent, unemployed men, pointlessly waiting in the cue for a job. It is a collective form of castration, as their *shakti* is never revitalized, or set free; instead, it is socially and economically entrapped in the impersonal state of massive unemployment. This collective sense of alienation is felt by Siddhartha, who is portrayed as a dislocated wonderer, both from himself and from the world. This sense of dislocation is expressed in the sequence portraying Siddhartha's vision in a temple. As he aimlessly gazes at some American tourists, who are fascinated by a 'holy' cow while smoking weed, next to beggars dying of hunger, Siddhartha's gaze is lost in his own social invisibility. In this *liminal* state of mind, his visionary experience begins with a nightmarish vision of modernity in the form of exoticism: the caricatures of an aboriginal elder, a Hindu priest and an ascetic, an image of a young man wearing make up, dancers, another ascetic in make-up holding a cheap paper reproduction of Shiva's/ Poseidon's triton, other dancers jumping and dancing in exuberance, an

image of a voodoo priest drinking from a bottle, an image of an old lady begging, and more images of exuberant dancers moving without rhythm, without aim, without reason. This is the exact vision, a grotesque stereotype of modernity, that Charu in *Charulata*, and Arati in *Mahanagar* (Big City 1963) also share [*see* Sequence 3.2 'Charu's Vision' in Appendix). The second part of Siddhartha's vision slowly superimposes into the calm and lyrical view of the sea horizon, and then the countryside, the place where Siddhartha (and through him of India) yearns to 'return'; the forest of *Pather Panchali*. As in Ray's previous films *Devi*, *Charulata*, and *Mahanagar*, in *Pratidwand*i, Siddhartha's vision depicts the moment of his self-realization and enlightenment, the moment of 'individuation' in Jung's terms, referring to the process by which one becomes '"an in-dividual", that is, a separate indivisible unity or "whole"' (*CW Vol.9 Part I:* 275). In the end, Siddhartha realizes his dream and abandons the city for the countryside, which is a move that echoes a general feeling of disillusionment that instigated a process of 'decentralization' in India (*see* Brass 1989: 223-264).

'In my recent trip to Kathmandu in April 2012, after I managed to break out of the sacred Hanuman-dkoka Durbar Square, a 'World heritage Site', in which the *Khumari*, an eight year old girl is exhibited to tourists as the 'living goddess' (as in Ray's *Devi*), I saw another Kathmandu burning in anger. Daily protests frequently take place, as in a majority of young people call for a more democratic system, but instead, they are dealt by riot police. Recently, in Kolkata there were protests and demonstrations over the eviction of people living in slums to be rebuild in the name of 'progress' [16/4/2012]. Athens, Cairo, London, Birmingham, Madrid, Paris, Delhi, Kolkata, Kathmandu, Tehran, Los Angeles, Buenos Aires, Johannesburg, and the other melting pots of a world on fire, where youth unemployment, criminalization of immigration, privatization of social services, the military and the health system, discrimination, violence, drug addiction, alienation, and poverty are all global, social deceases. For the youth today, like Siddhartha in *Pratidwandi,* the promises of a new world were broken, despite the enthusiastic celebrations of the 'beautiful world' in TV adverts bombarding them with fake smiles and false degrees.

In *Pratidwand*i, there are also other moments of sudden terror and violent disorder, such as the bombing of a cinema full of spectators. These events accompany long and endless takes of the young unemployed waiting in the cue for a job interview. In this nightmarish world, Siddhartha's visions are the only means of escaping poverty and inequality, set in the context in which life is limited, *Shakti* is blocked, and anger is let loose. There is a scene in the film that shows a mob attacking the owner of a Mercedes car, because the careless and rich driver had just hit a little girl on the street. Siddhartha joins the mob that tries to lynch the driver. But then, as he looks at the back of the car, he sees another little girl in shock and tears. She is the daughter of the driver looking at her father getting beaten up on the pavement. It is this kind of double perspective that makes Ray look as if he is a-political, meaning an *auteur* who never takes a political side, and rather chooses to keep a distance in the form of the detached perspective of the Apu-Eye. However, I would argue that Ray's a-political stand is a fusion of world-politics with the tranquil philosophy of 'Inaction' (Ganguly 2000: 113); a type of Aristoteleian politics that is both *personal and universal*. This personal philosophy is ethically reflected upon practical and social matters, including the importance of access to education (*Pather Panchali*), gender equality (*Mahanagar*), access to jobs (*Pratidwand*i), and public health (as in Ray's adaptation of Ibsen's 'Enemy of People' in *Ganashatru* 1989).

Humanism as a Critique of Modernity

Following Weber's writings on modernity as a process of wealth accumulation, Arendt high-lighted a collective feeling of alienation from the world (as also illustrated by the characters of

Doya in *Devi*, Charu in *Charulata*, and Siddhartha in *Pratiwaldi*). For Arendt, this form of impersonal alienation was the result of the rise of the capitalist economy in which the concepts of 'society' and 'social solidarity' (as in Durkheim 1893), with all its malice, poverty, unemployment, and social indifference, replaced the protective, traditional structures of family and private property (Arendt 1998/1958: 254-257). This sense of alienation and longing is underlying the motives of several characters, from Apu's mother to Charu's loneliness, and from Kalikinkar's sexual frustrations to Siddhartha's social alienation. Their visions and psyches, enriched with archetypal symbolism (Jung), reflect upon the collective consciousness (Durkheim) and the historical consciousness (Dilthey) of the respective time and place of each film. In this sense, the director *auteur* becomes a charismatic historian of a world history (Weber), whose vision consists of a series of juxtapositions of gazes (i.e. 'opti-clash', Bhatti and Pinney 2011: 228) as an epiphany of perspectives: from the childhood curiosity of Apu's eyes, to the sense of imprisonment from the perspective of Charu, or the frustration and disillusionment felt from the perspective of Siddhartha. In this context, Ray's films are similar to the child's play as in Bhaktin's definition of *polyglossia*[6]: they are multi-layered and multi-vocal open arenas, offering a number of subjective point of views, that articulate a paradoxical and heterogeneous history(ies) of change. In this way, Ray allows us to see *his* 'Calcutta', and through it, *his* world. His journeys taking place through the gaze of his characters, allow us to learn more about our political selves, and to relocate our universal emotions within a global, but at the same time, diverse cosmos of 'village(s)'.

This essay highlighted the feeling of *touching* and the pain of its absence as a result of the process of an impersonal modernity (urbanization, dislocation, separation, and alienation). The absence, need to control, and desire for, touching, become underlying motives in Ray's entire work. Nowadays, the Walls of professionalization and 'progress', based on automatic forms of non-communication and separation remain firmer than ever. In the spirit of Jean-Jacques Rousseau, Sen (1992) shows how inherited forms of inequality support further categorizations, on the basis of which more separations (and discriminations) are built: '[...] the importance of the distinction between seeking equality in different spaces relates ultimately to the nature of human diversity. It is because we are so deeply diverse, that equality in one space frequently leads to inequality in other spaces' (1992: 117). New culturally naturalized categories of the mind, based on existing established categorizations, in terms of class, gender, ethnicity, religion, economic status, political party, color, political party, football team, car, house, profile, and style, are relentlessly born, reborn, evolving, revived, forgotten, mixed, fused, and discarded. In a world built on massive debt, the old and hateful ideals of purity are nowadays institutionalized, militarized, professionalized, and air-conditioned; for the entire world becomes increasingly cast-sized.

This homogenization of world society into a gigantic supermarket is accompanied by the image of absolute poverty amongst children living in slums without access to clean water, breathing burning plastic, right next to luxurious temples and shopping-molls -from Delhi to Athens-. This 'Western' way of life is kept separately, protected even by recruiting the military for the indulgence of small elites, as if it is a sacred cow. On the other extreme, counter political ideologies (i.e. neoliberal capitalism, neo-Marxism, nationalism, neo-theocracy, and so on) echoing the two extreme poles as portrayed in Ray's takes on the Swadeshi and the Naxalite movements, equally contribute to a violently homogeneous 'modern world'. But Ray's humanism tells us that this world belongs to us, we are the world. In the mist of burning plastic rubbish, death and happiness walk hand-in hand; for human Touch cannot exist elsewhere but here. The Walls have been raised to protect 'us' from 'them', but the power of a smile tears them down in pieces.

Notes

1. The juxtaposition of the concepts of 'modernity' and 'tradition' has been critically discussed in a variety of studies, including: Durkheim's juxtaposition of 'mechanical', agricultural systems to 'organic' forms of solidarity in industrialized large-scale societies (1991/ 1893: 85, 331; Weber's juxtaposition of 'traditional' to the capitalist economic impulse (2003/1927: 356); Said's juxtaposition of Occidentalism to Orientalism (1978). Criticisms of this rigid opposition are equally diverse, including: Fabien's criticism of the dichotomy between 'our time' and 'their', a-historical time (1983); also in Wolf (1982); Tambiah's re-evaluation of magic and science (1990); Asad's genealogy of 'religion' as the historical product of the discourse of a Christianized European modernity, published the same year with the Comaroffs' writings on modernity in Africa (1993); and writings on the re-invention of 'tradition' as in Hobsbawm and Ranger (1983), and in relation to rise of world-occult movements (Comaroffs 2000), among many others. Finally, in cultural studies, Bhabha's critique of ocular-centrism/ ethnocentrism in terms of 'the visibility of the racial colonial Other' as 'a point of identity' (1994); and Appadurai and Breckenridge's (1995) concept of 'inter-ocularity', referring to the complex relation between what is perceived to be 'local' and what is perceived to be 'global' via 'cross-referencing' are all critical takes of the *homogeneous* (i.e. 'Western') concept of 'modernity', as manifested for instance in popular culture (Breisach 2007/1983: 426, among others).
2. The wonderment as an inner motif in understanding the world is, above all, associated with philosophy. For Plato, 'the beginning of philosophy is "*to thaumazein*" [wonderment, admiration]'. The philosopher morally works 'in-between ignorance and truth, in search for true wisdom'. By contrast, 'the ignorant person is ignorant mainly because of his own ignorance, and that is why he does not feel the need for philosophy' (Kaktos Literature Group 1992: 30, my translation from Greek). In contrast to arrogant ignorance, the curiosity of the child, as well as, his emotional distance, are the means of understanding and adapting in this ever-changing world. On the other hand, Arendt highlighted the sense of wonderment in the Cartesian doubt, associating it with Descartes' *de omnibus dubitandum*, to develop a concept of 'modern doubting' that emphasizes perception and vision (Arendt 1998/1958: 273). Levin (1993) drew an evolutionary perspective of ocular-centrism, referring to the process of developing a particular rationality (i.e. 'science'), that supposedly began with the European Enlightenment on the exclusive basis of vision and perception as the means of understanding the world in terms of objective and subjective forms of knowledge and truth: from Descartes's and Husserl's return to Plato's Cave, to Habermas's 'ethics of communicative processes', and via the epic visionary experiences of Romanticism, to an increasingly nihilistic and en-framed view of humanity (Heidegger) driven by 'the violence of light' (Derrida). *See* also: Levin 1993: 1-29, and Tambiah 1990, Comaroffs 1993, Miller 1995, Bell 1997, among others).
3. 'The Goddess then entered the palace of the god who bears the moon as his diadem. When the three-eye god saw her he said, "Damn women", and she bowed to him and said, "You have spoken truly, and not falsely. This portion of Nature is senseless; women deserve to be reviled. It is the grace of men which brings release from the ocean of existence". Then Hara re-joined and said to her, "Now you are worthy, and I will give you a son […]"' (Extract from *Skanda Purana* translated by O'Flaherty 1975: 260)
4. From Malinowski's diary, on his arrival among the Mailu, New Guinea: 'The Mayos stood on the shore; I watched them a long time through binoculars and waved my handkerchief –I felt I was taking leave of civilization [...] I looked at them through binoculars; they reminded me of the Saturday excursion to Blackall Ranged [...] I went to the cabin and felt asleep after an injection of Alkarsodyl. The next day was spent in my cabin, dozing with a bad headache and general numbness (1967: 5).
5. The concept of a 'historical consciousness' was first coined by Wilhelm Dilthey (1833-1911). It is rooted to Kant's essay on the 'Idea for a Universal History with a Cosmopolitan Purpose' written in 1784. Nietzsche's essay 'The uses and Disadvantages of History in Life' distinguished three categories of historical consciousness: on one extreme, the 'unhistorical' (as in early functionalism and structuralism); on the other, the 'super-historical' (intellectual, 'couch-anthropology' as that of Levi-Strauss); and in-between the two extreme poles Nietzsche positioned the '*historical*' to which: 'The unhistorical and the superhistorical are inextricable aspects of a truly vital, *self-critical historical consciousness*' . This tripod of knowledge is manifested in its totality in the 'impersonal vision of the artist: "the outwardly tranquil but inwardly flashing eye of the artist". Only when conceived as a work of art is history truly impersonal and this involves some superhistorical *detachment'* (Bell citing Nietzsche, 1997: 32- 33, *my emphasis*). In this context, 'history' is a form of art, and vice versa, the historical is an artist: the charismatic prophet (as in Weber) of an entire generation, who reflects upon his time and history through this collective 'fiction'. In Ranciere's terms "History" is only made up of stories that we tell ourselves, but simply that the "logic of stories" and the ability to act as historical agents go together. Politics and art, like forms of knowledge, construct "fictions", that is to say material rearrangements of signs and images, relationships between what

is seen and what is said, between what is done and what can be done' (2006: 39).

6. Bakhtin in the 'Dialogic Imagination and Genre Theory' analyzed the novelization of the novel as a 'process of becoming' and 'coming to self-consciousness' (1992: 5, 11). He incorporated this into open-ended texts, based on different voices, languages, and cultural values (*polyglossia*) contextualized within the novel's *chronotope* (a sphere/ a world of meaning, 'literally "time, space" Bakhtin 1981/1992: 84) seen within a process of *becoming* in-between the familiar and the strange, the past and the future, the local and the global: 'by incorporating extraliterary heteroglossia and the "novelistic" layers of literary language, they become dialogised, permeated with laughter, irony, humour, elements of self-parody and finally –this is the most important thing- the novel inserts into these other genres an indeterminacy, a certain semantic openendedness, a living contact with unfinished, still-evolving contemporary reality [the open ended present]' (Bakhtin 1992: 7). Appadurai and Breckenridge (1995) developed Bakhtin's concepts of 'intertextuality' and 'polyglossia' of the text towards visual culture through the notion of 'inter-ocularity'. The latter refers to the complex relation between what is perceived to be 'local' and what is perceived to be 'global' via 'cross-referencing'. In the same way Bakhtin argues that a language makes sense only in relation to the languages, Appadurai and Breckenridge contextualized 'public culture' in South Asia as a heterogeneous arena (including public spaces such as the museum, the cinema, and TV) in which new ideas are formed and performed outside the modernist (often based on religious beliefs of purity and pollution) presumptions of 'hybridity'.

References

Appadurai, A., and Breckenridge, C. (1995) 'Public modernity in India' in *Consuming Modernity: Public Culture in a South Asian World* (Ed) Carol Breckenridge Minneapolis: University of Minneapolis Press, p.p. 1-20

Arendt, H. (1998/1958) *The Human Condition* Chicago and London: University of Chicago P

Asad, T. (1973) 'Introduction' in *Anthropology and the Colonial Encounter* NJ: Humanity Books, 9-19 (1993) 'Introduction' in *Genealogies of Religion* Baltimore: Johns Hopkins UP, 1-24

Bakhtin, M. (1981/1992) *The Dialogic Imagination: Four Essays* Transl. Caryl Emerson and Michael Holquist Austin: University of Texas

Banerjee, S. (1996) *Satyajit Ray: Beyond the Frame* New Delhi: Allied

Basu, D.K. (2004) 'On Satyajit Ray's Film Adaptation of "The Goddess"' in *Zoetrope: All-story* Volume 8, No3 (Autumn 2004). Online at: http://www.all-story.com/issues.cgi?action=show_story&story_id=246

Bell, M. (1997) *Literature Modernism and Myth: Belief and Responsibility in the Twentieth Century* Cambridge: Cambridge University Press

Benjamin, W. (1955/1999) *Illuminations* Transl. Harry Zorn, London: Pimlico

Bhabha, Homi (1994) *The Location of Culture* London: Routledge

Bhatti S. and Pinney, C. (2011) 'Optic-Clash: Modes of Visuality in India' in *A Companion to the Anthropology of India* (Ed) Isabelle Clark-Deces West Sussex: Wiley-Blackwell, p.p.225-240

Boise, S., and Jalal, A. (1997) *Modern South Asia: History, Culture, Political Economy* NY and London: Routledge

Bourdieu, P. (1977) *Outline of a Theory of Practice* Cambridge UP

Breisach, E. (1983/2007) *Historiography: Ancient, Medieval, and Modern* Chicago: The University of Chicago Press

Buck-Morss, S. (1991) *The Dialectics of Seeing* Cambridge: MIT Press

Caplan, P. (1987) 'Celibacy as a Solution?' in *The Cultural Construction of Sexuality* (ed.) Pat Caplan. London and NY: Routledge, 271-295

Clifford, J., and Marcus, G.E. (1986) *Writing Culture: The Poetics and Politics of Ethnography* Berkeley: University of California Press

Clifford, J. (1988) *The Predicament of Culture: Twentieth Century Ethnography, Literature and Art* Cambridge: Harvard UP

Comarroffs, J. and J. (1993) *Modernity and its Malcontents: Ritual and Power in Postcolonial Africa* (Eds) Chicago: The University of Chicago Press (2000) '"Millennial Capitalism": First thought s on a Second Coming' in *Public Culture* 12(2): 291-343

Cooper, D. (2000) *The Cinema of Satyajit Ray: Between Tradition and Modernity* Cambridge UP

Das, Santi (1998) *Satyajit Ray: an intimate master* New Delhi: Allied

DasGupta, C. (2001) *The Cinema of Satyajit Ray* New Delhi: National Book Trust

Deliege, R. (2011) 'Caste, Class, and Untouchability' Shah, A. (2011) in *A Companion to the Anthropology of India* (Ed) Isabelle Clark-Deces West Sussex: Wiley-Blackwell, p.p.45-61

Dube, R. (2005) *Satyajit Ray's The Chess Players and Postcolonial Theory: Culture, Labour, and the Value of Alterity* NY: Palgrave Macmillan

Dumont, L. (1972) *Homo Hierachicus* London: Paladin

Durkheim, E. (1991/1893/) *The Division of Labour in Society* New York: Free Press (1995/1912) *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* Trans. Karen E. Fields NY: Free Press

Dutta, K., and Robinson (ed.) (1995) *Rabindranath Tagore: The Myriad-Minded Man* Saint Martin's Press

Fabien, J. (1983) *Time and the Other: How Anthropology Makes its Object* NY: Columbia UP

Fisher, J.A., and Potter, J. (1997) 'Technology, Appreciation, and the Historical View of Art' in *The Journal of Aesthetics and Art Criticism* 55: 2, spring 1997: 169-185

Foster, H. (1996) *The Return of the Real: The Avant-Garde at the End of the Century* Cambridge, Massachusetts: MIT Press

Ganguly, S. (2000) *Satyajit Ray: In Search of the Modern* London: Scarecrow Press

Gell, A. (1999) *The Art of Anthropology* Oxford and NY: Berg

Grimshaw, A. (2001) *The Ethnographer's Eye: Ways of seeing in anthropology* Cambridge: Cambridge UP

Grimshaw, A., and Raventz, A. (2009) *Observational Cinema: Anthropology, Film, and the Exploration of Social Life* Bloomington and Indianapolis: Indiana UP

Hobsbawm, EJ., and Ranger, T. (1983) (Eds) *The Invention of Tradition* Cambridge UP

Jung, C.G. (1968) *The Collected Works of C. G. Jung Volume 9, Part I: The Archetypes and the Collective Unconscious* Translated by R. F. C. Hull, London: Routledge and Kegan Paul

Levin, D. (1993) (ed.) *Modernity and the Hegemony of Vision* Berkeley: University of California Press

MacClancy, J. (2003) 'Anthropology: "The latest form of evening entertainment"' in *A Concise Companion to Modernism* (Ed) David Bradshaw Oxford: Blackwell

Mauss, M. (1985/1938) 'A Category of the Human Mind: the notion of person; the notion of self' in *The Category of Person*, ed. Michael Carrithers, Steven Collins, and Steven Lukes Cambridge: Cambridge UP, p.p. 1-25 (2002/1954) *The Gift* Transl. by Cohen and West London and NY: Routledge

McDermott, R.F. (2011) Revelry, *Rivalry, and Longing for the Goddesses of Bengal: The Fortunes of Hindu Festivals* New York: Columbia University Press

McGuire, M. (2011) '"How to Sit, How to Stand; Bodily Practice in the New Urban Middle Class' in *A Companion to the Anthropology of India* (Ed) Isabelle Clark-Deces West Sussex: Wiley-Blackwell, p.p. 117-136

Morris, B. (1994) *Anthropology of the Self: The Individual in Cultural Perspective* London: Pluto

Mulvey, L. (1989/2009) *Visual and Other Pleasures* NY: Palgrave and Macmillan

O'Flaherty, W.D. (1975) (editor and translator) *Hindu Myths: A Sourcebook translated from the Sanskrit* London: Penguin

Otto, R. (1950) *The Idea of the Holy* Oxford UP

Paganopoulos, M. (2007) '*The Affinity between Anthropology and Literature: Reflections on the Poetics of Ethnography in the writings of Nikos Kavvadias'* Presented in 2007, in the 3rd Biennial Hellenic Observatory PhD Symposium, European Institute, LSE (2010) 'Jesus Christ and Billy the Kid as Archetypes of the Self in American Cinema' in the *Journal of Religion and Popular Culture* 22(1) -Spring Issue at http://www.usask.ca/relst/jrpc/art22%281%29-ChristAndKid.html (2011) 'The Archetype of Transformation in Maya Deren's Film Rituals' in *Jung and Film II: The Return* (Eds) Christopher Hauke and Luke Hockley London and NY: Routledge, pp 253-265

Plato (1992) *Faidon: or of the Soul* Athens: Kaktos Literature Group, my transl. from Greek

Ranciere, J. (2004) *Aesthetics and its Discontents* Transl. Steven Corcoran Cambridge: Polity (2006) *The Politics of Aesthetics: The Distribution of the Sensible* London: Continuum (2009) *The Emancipated Spectator* Transl. Gregory Elliott London: Verso

Rashiduzzaman, M. (1989) 'East-West Conflicts in Pakistan: Bengali Regionalism 1947-1970' in *The States of South Asia: Problems of National Integration* (Eds) A Jeyaratnam Wilson and Dennis Dalton London: Hurst, p.p. 111-130

Rousseau, Jean-Jacques (1987) *The Basic Political Writings* Translated by Donald A. Cress Indianapolis and Cambridge: Hackett

Said, E. (1978) *Orientalism* New York: Pantheon Books

Sen, A. (1982) *Poverty and Famines: An essay on Entitlement and Deprivation* Oxford: Calendon Press (1992) *Inequality Re-examined* New York: Russell Sage Foundation (1996) 'Satyajit Ray and the art of Universalism: Our Culture, Their Culture' in *The New Republic*, April 1, 1996, posted at: http://satyajitray.ucsc.edu/articles/sen.html [11/1/2012] (1998) *The Argumentative Indian: Writings on Indian Culture, History and Identity* London: Penguin

Seidler, V. (1987) 'Reason, Desire, and Male Sexuality' in *The Cultural Construction of Sexuality* (ed.) Pat Caplan London and NY: Routledge, p.p. 82-112

Shah, A. (2011) 'India Burning: The Maoist revolution' in *A Companion to the Anthropology of India* (Ed) Isabelle Clark-Deces West Sussex: Wiley-Blackwell, p.p.332-351

Spivak, G.C. (1993) 'The Burden of the English' in *Orientalism and the Postcolonial Predicament: Perspectives on South Asia* (Eds) Carol A. Breckenridge and Peter van der Veer Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, p.p. 134-157

Stocking Jr., G.W. (1994) *The Ethnographer's Magic and Other Essays in the History of Anthropology* University of Chicago Press

Tagore, R. and Chakravarty (ed.) (1961) *A Tagore Reader* (ed.) A. Chakravarty Beacon Press

Tambiah, S.T. (1990) *Magic, science, Religion, and the scope of Rationality* Cambridge UP

Thorat, S. (2004) *The Hindu Social System and Human Rights of Dalits* New Delhi: Critical Quest

Weber, M. (1968/1919) 'Science as a Vocation' in *On Charisma and institution Building* (Ed) S.N. Eisenstadt Chicago: University of Chicago Press, p.p. 294-309 (2003/1927) *General Economic History* Translated by Frank H. Knight New York: Transaction Publishers

Wolf, E.R. (1982) *Europe and the People Without History* Berkeley: University of California Press

Filmography

Novels adapted by Satyajit Ray

Bibhutibhushan Bandopadhyay (*Pather Panchali*/Song of the Road 1955/1929, *Aparajito*/ Unvanquished 1956/1931, *Apur Sansar*/World of Apu 1959/1931, *Asani Sanket*/Distant Thunder 1973), Tarasankar Bandyopadhyay (Banerjee) (*Jalsaghar*/The Music Room 1958, *Abhijan*/ Expendition 1962), Prabhatkumar Mukhopadhyay (*Devi*/ Goddess 1960) Parasuram (*Parash Pathar*/ Philosopher's Stone 1958, *Kapurush-O-Mahapurush*/Coward and Holy Man 1965), Premendra Mitra (*Kapurush-O-Mahapurush*/Coward and Holy Man 1965), Prabhat Kumar Mukherjee (*Devi*/Goddess 1960), Rabindranath Tagore* (*Teen Kanya*/Three Daughters 1961, *Charulata*/Lonely Wife 1964, *Ghare Baire*/Home and World 1984), Narendranath Mitra (*Mahanagar*/Big City 1963), Saradindu Banerjee (*Chidiakhana*/Zoo 1967), Sunil Ganguli Aranyer *Din Ratri*/ Days and Nights in the Forest 1969, *Pratidwand*i/Adversary 1970), Sankar (*Seemabaddha*/ Company Ltd 1971, *Jana Aranya*/Middle Man 1975), Munshi Prem Chand (*Shatranj Ke Khilari*/ Chess Players 1977, *Sadgati*/Deliverance 1981) Upendrakisore Ray (Goopy Gyne Bagha Byne/ Adventures of Goopy and Bagha 1968), Satyajit Ray (*Sonar Kella*/ Golden Fortress 1974, *Joi Baba Felunath*/ Elephant God 1978, *Pikoo*/ *Pikur Diary* 1980), Henrik Ibsen (*Ganashatru*/Enemy of People 1989)

Documentaries/autobiographies

Rabindranath Tagore 1961 commissioned by Government of India
Sikkim 1971 produced by the Chogyal of Sikkim, Himalayan state
The Inner Eye 1972 commissioned by Films Division, Government of India
Bala 1976: National Centre of Performing Arts, Bombay and Government of Tamil Nadu
Sukumar Ray 1987 commissioned by Government of West Bengal: birth centenary of Ray's father

Script-based films

Kanchanjungha (1962), *Nayak*/ Hero (1966), *Chidiakhana*/ The Zoo, or Menagerie (1967) *Aranyer Din-Ratri*/ Days and Nights in the Forest (1970), *Shakha-Prashakha*/ Branches of Tree (1990), *Agantuk*/ The Stranger (1991)

Children's stories

Goopy Gyne Bagha Byne (Adventures of Goopy and Bagha 1968), Sonar Kella (Golden Fortress 1974), *Joi Baba Felunath* (Elephant God 1979), *Hikor Rajar Deshe* (Kingdom of Diamonds 1980), *Pikoo* (1981)

Note: Ray contributed to the script of Spielberg's *ET* (1982) with an earlier script, though his contribution was not acknowledged. However, it is clear that the children's pov adopted by Spielberg's photography in *ET* is a direct re-adoption of Apu's point of view.

Appendices

Table 1. *Pather Panchali* (1955) Train Sequence

The first part of the sequence begins with the return of auntie Indir (played by Chunibala Devi) to Apu's house. The audience hears her walking-stick off screen, as she slowly enters into the frame, opening the old wooden gate of the garden with a big and warm smile on her old but gentle face: "Anyone at home?" she asks. Apu's mother, Sarbojaya Ray (Karuna Bannerjee), off-screen bitterly replies: "Why have you come back?" Following their argument over Indir's 'bad' influence on her daughter Durga, according to the neighborhood's malicious gossip, Sarbojaya remains cold, separately eating some nuts in a dark corner of their house while keeping her eyes away from Indir. With her warm smile the old Indir says: "I am not feeling very well. I'd like to spend my last days in the old home". Sarbojaya nervously replies: "What is the old home to you? The best thing you can do is leave". "Just a minute" Indir interrupts her sister-in-law's complains. Indir then slowly takes her usual place on the paved, dirty porch of the small house. She leaves on the floor her stick, her bangle of rags, her empty pot, and a bangle of hay, which she brought with her from the countryside. "What are you waiting for?" Sarbojaya continues trying to get rid of her. Indir replies: "Let me rest here for a while". The whole scene is watched by Apu's sister, Durga (Uma Das Gupta), as she bites off pieces of bamboo. Apu approaches behind her, and they both run playfully outside the forest into the fields. Apu's image (Subir Bannerjee), wearing his golden crown made out of paper cuts, echoes classical depictions of the young Shiva, as if he is playing with his sister Saraswati, the goddess of knowledge and music who is related to the mother goddess Durga.

Cut back to auntie Indir, who is struggling to fit in, under and because of the constant scrutiny of Sarbojaya. "Sister –in-law have you gone to sleep? Will you give me some water?" she asks. Sarbojaya's voice, again heard off-screen, smoothes and replies: "Your bowl is there; help yourself". As a result of Sarbojaya's somehow positive response, Indir rediscovers her beautiful smile. But her smile is not reciprocated by Sarbojaya. She does not pay any attention to Indir's warmth human touch. This saddens Indir's face as she duly pours water into her pot at the background of the screen. The framing of the scene is divided by the double lighting of Subrata Mitra, inventor of the 'bouncing lighting': the use of mirrors and white sheets to reflect upon and manipulate the 'natural' light of the film. In the dark foreground of the house, Sarbojaya remains cold, looking both indifferent and worried at the same time of an insecure future. The dark foreground of the wrecked house is juxtaposed to the brightly lit background of the garden, from which Indir tries to come in contact with her sister-in-law, in vain. The silence of the dialogue, accompanied by the tensed, repeated, and dissonant background note of Ravi Shankar's sitar that gradually comes to the foreground of sound, amplifies the ambience of alienation and isolation, which is contextualized within the poverty of the realistic setting. Indir waters a small tree, picks up her bangle and stick, and walks out of the garden. Sarbojaya stares at the empty space, bitter, angry, hurt. In the dark foreground of the wrecked house, a dog is searching for food amongst the junk. This shadow image of decay and Death is juxtaposed to Indir's stare at the house for the last time, as she walks off the screen to the brightly lit forest, to meet her death. Sarbojaya look at Indir for the last time, for a fleeting moment with sympathy, which is then immediately replaced by indifference as she drinks water from *her* cup.

The second part of the sequence continues on the double setting motif, with a cut to a long-shot that portrays Apu standing in the windy fields of hey at the background of the frame, juxtaposed to the parallel and static image of the electric wires that cut the frame diagonally in two. Apu is staring with wonderment at the electric bulbs at the top of the pillar standing against the moving clouds. In the next cut, Durga first looks at the wires and then at Apu in a suspicious way. Durga tries to distinguish the foreign sound of the electric wires, from the splashing sound of the two kids walking through the wet, muddy field, heard in the foreground. The scene is accompanied by the monotonous, disharmonious, electronic sound of a synthesizer, used to amplify the feeling of anticipation and insecurity of something foreign and alien arriving at long distance. But while Durga looks uncomfortable with the setting, Apu playfully places his ear on the electric column trying to hear the electric sound of the column. The two kids continue wondering around in the fields, and when Apu loses his sister from sight she smoothly throws at him a small stone, so that he can find her. Durga, like a mother to him, shares her bamboo stick, as they both sit in the shadow of long grown hey, blowing in the vivid wind. "Where are we? What are those?" Apu curiously asks pointing his finger towards the electric wires. Durga moves her head indifferently, but then covers Apu's mouth as she hears again the foreign sound of something approaching from a long distance, a mechanic sound within the natural sound of the wind. They both stand up to see where this new sound comes from, as gradually the sound of the wind gives away to the monstrous sound of a train. While Durga falls in her knees in fear at the sight of the train approaching, the excited Apu runs towards it, almost as if he wants to touch it. He runs along the railway, as the black figure of the train rapidly passes in front of the camera. As the train passes-by, Apu is left looking in wonderment at the black smoke the machine has left behind. Indir's death follows.

Table 2.1. *Devi* (1960) Opening Credits

The opening-credits sequence of *Devi* is constructed in the form of a music piece, beginning in low pianissimo tone which gradually builds on a carnivalesque crescendo. The first shot depicts an unadorned, alabaster statue of the Mother Goddess *Ma*, staring at the camera with her enigmatically blank eyes and smile. The white head statue portrays her as the provider and preserver. In mythology, these mother qualities are manifested in three forms: as Shri-Lakshmi (the goddess of wealth and material fulfilment, often depicted as submerging from the sea, echoing images of the Greek Aphrodite and Roman Venus); Parvati (the goddess of love as power, spiritual fulfilment, often depicted with two arms in the companion of her husband Shiva, but with four arms in the companion of a tiger); and Saraswati (the goddess of culture, music and the arts, often depicted with a sitar in her arms). In particular, her manifestation as Parvati, who is the reincarnation of Sati, the first wife of Shiva and daughter of the Himalayas, and whose desire lured Shiva into the material realm. Parvati is also known in seven different names/forms, including that of Durga (the Mother Creator) and Kali (the Black Destroyer). As the music changes motif, from a dissonant suspense-note played by a violin orchestra, to the low sound of Ustad Ali Akbar Khan's sitar that opens the next musical sequence, Ray superimposes on the image of the enigmatic statue the mask of Durga. As the music increases its tempo and volume, with the introduction of a tabla and violins at the background, the *tabula rasa* of Durga's face is transformed into the statue of Kali, through a second superimposition of jewelry, black hair and make-up placed on the head of the white goddess. The music then explodes into a festive tone, with the ringing bells and tablas heard during Durga's and Kali's harvest festivals that take place in the autumn. In this way, the opening scene introduces the audience in three superimposed images to the main theme of the film: the transformation of young anonymous wife to an object of veneration kept and exhibited in public display for the desperate devotees. Furthermore, it contextualizes the image of the Mother Goddess in three different contexts: the head-statue is enigmatic, the simplicity of the marble symbolizing the essence of the masculine symbol of the Mother, textually referring to ancient mythological times; the second form *evolves* into the mask of Durga/Kali, used in everyday life to be seen in houses, theatre, and temples; finally, the third image of the ornamented statue of Kali is used in festivals and within a celebratory and violent sacred context.

The second part of the sequence opens the film with the ethnographic recording of Kali's annual celebration that takes place three weeks after Durga's more prestigious celebrations, 'on the dark moon-night of the month of Kartik' (McDermott 2011: 183). The ritual culminates at dawn with a firework display, followed by a ceremonial procession to the river bank where the disposal of the *tabula rasa* in the river takes place. In the film, the introduction of ringing bells and chimes carries the audience into the festival, as the director zooms-out from the close-up of the face of Kali to the full body of the statue covered by the smoke of incense, then further back showing the participants watching the ritual performance, until it reaches outside the temple where children are playing among the gathered crowd. At the same time, a subtitle introduces to the European audience (as there are no subtitles of superimposed in Hindu letters on the screen) to Kali: "the Mother Goddess is revered in Bengal as *Ma*, the Mother. Belief in the human reincarnation has been widespread in India. This story is set a century ago." Cut to a middle-shot of the two male protagonists of the film, the *zamindar* devoted father Kalikinkar (played by Chhabi Biswas, who also played the *zamindar* in *Jalsaghar*, The Music Room 1958) next to his son Uma (played by Soumitra Chatterjee), both praying towards the heavily decorated statue. The father's eyes look reassured about himself and his faith. With a reverse-angle shot the camera reveals the eyes of the Mother Goddess focusing on *his* eyes, as he falls on his knees to piously perform his offerings to her. Then a series of jump-cuts follows that take place in the garden of the temple where a sacrifice is performed under the vivid sound of the participants' timpani. A close-up on the sword of the executioner as it falls on the head of an animal rapidly jump-cuts to the image of exploding fire-works in the sky.

In the third part of the opening sequence, the music changes from the live recording of the ritual to the sound of a European brass band, as the camera pans from the right to left first on the face of Koka (Arpan Chowdhury) carried on the shoulder of his uncle Uma. This is an image reminiscent of the final image in *Apu Sansar* of Apu also carrying his son on his shoulder staring at a bright future. But in this film, the light is artificial, produced by the fireworks, fleetingly burning for an explosive moment before they disappear into the darkness of the night sky. As the camera pans to the left, we see for the first time the image of his young wife Doyamoyee, or Doya (played by Sharmila Tagore) also staring at the fire-works with a shy smile in her sad eyes. As she turns to look at Uma's eyes the camera pans back to the left, following the calling of Koka to his uncle to look at the fireworks in the sky. The next shot dissolves to a second ethnographic recording portraying the morning mass procession of Kali's temple to the river, where her tableau is thrown in the water under the celebratory chorus of thousands of participants. The camera focuses for a final time on Kali's face, before she is thrown in the dark river, submerging into the dark abyss of the human soul. In the next sequence, Uma announces to Doya his departure to Calcutta to study, leaving her alone with his father Kalikinkar at home.

Note : Kali's festival follows Durga's by three weeks, on the dark moon-night of the month of Kartik. Durga's festival dates back to the 16th century, while Kali's later to the 18th. However, since the 6th century, Kali was known to be 'like a daughter, a younger sister, or a helper from Durga's angry forehead to help her battle demons'. Despite her fearsome reputation, she is also associated to alms giving. Kali Pujas and the temples dedicated to Kali tend to be smaller and less formal than Durga's, and for this reason since the 1970s their numbers increased (McDermott 2011: 183-186).

Table 2.2. Kalikinkar's Vision

The transformation of the Mother Goddess in the opening-credits in terms of narrative and structure, as well as, aesthetically, anticipates the sequence that portrays the vision of Kalikinkar Roy of his –daughter-in-law as the Mother Goddess. This sequence develops the central motif of the film, introduced in the opening sequence as described above, structurally similar to a musical fugue. Rhythmically, it builds up from allegro, through pianissimo, to fortissimo, accompanying a succession of dialogue, silence, leading to the final grant musical explosion: the first scene portrays the happy family life Doya enjoys. The scene takes place in Koka's bedroom in the evening, as Doya tells scary stories to the young Koka in the companion of his mother. This scene echoes old Indir's stories to the young Durga and Apu in *Pather Panchali*. This momentary happiness is manifested as a warmth form of communication between Doya, her sister-in-law and her nephew, which is then interrupted by Kalikinkar's vision that takes place in his bedroom, alone, in the second part of the sequence. The second scene shows Kalikinkar piously praying, but then having a troubled sleep, until, his sees a vision in his dream just before he wakes up at dawn. In the vision, he first sees the drawing of the three white eyes of the Mother Goddess, appearing from the abyss of the dark background, the depths of the human soul. The director zooms-into the drawing giving the impression that the eyes are gradually coming closer to the camera/ audience/ Roy. As the eyes become bigger, the third eye of the forehead begins floating, giving life to the mask, which is then superimposed on a close-up of the face of Doya, staring intensely at the camera/ audience/ Roy. Her face is covered in shadow giving the impression of a living black Kali. But then a bright light falls on her face and she is instantly transformed into MA. But unlike the traditional iconographies of the Mother Goddess, she takes the conventional position given to women at the time: shy, slightly bowing her covered head in understanding, or submission, smiling at the camera. A floating set of candles is superimposed on her face, which then dissolves onto Kalikinkar's shocked, anxiously sweaty face, who stares intensely at the camera. The clock sounds five in the morning, as he stands up in self-realization that his sister-in-law is the Mother Goddess, according to *his* vision. This second superimposition echoes the second transformation of the mask to the statue of Kali in the opening credits. As the recorded celebration of Kali that follows in the opening sequence, the third part of this sequence begins with the sound of ringing bells used to wake up both Kalikinkar and the viewers out of the trance state of his vision. Echoing the third part of the opening credits, Kalikinkar's vision is followed by the image of collective veneration of Doya by a group of male worshippers begging for miracles. Kalikinkar's vision becomes complete.

Table 3.1. *Charulata* (1966) Opening sequence

Charulata opens silently, almost indifferently, with English credits aimed to European audiences, as in *Devi*. But then, the beautiful sound of Ray's sitar, playing a Rabindranath Tagore slow-song, musically introduces the audience to the slow and elegant rhythm of the film. It opens the Hindu opening credits of the film superimposed on the foreground, and decorated with a close-up image of the hands of Charu (played masterfully by Madhabi Mukherjee) elegantly using a sewing-needle, crocheting a piece of white fabric stretched on a circular wooden frame, on which she has embroidered the English letter 'B', presumably for 'Bhubati', the name of her husband. As she cuts the thread with her mouth, the camera zooms-out to middle-shot that reveals her sitting on her decorated European bed in her bedroom. As the clock rings four, she calls for her servant without receiving an answer. She then begins to walk in the long corridor of the upper house, followed by the camera, while continues calling for her servant: "Brojo? Are you deaf? It's past four. Take the master his tea", in his office where he is working. She then turns around and walks towards the camera, as she tenderly holds, and looks at the embroider, on which the English capital letter of her husband's name is inscribed, looking as if she is thankful for the life he offers her. But then, the sound of a crow off-screen, a bad omen, interrupts her meditation. "Ay... Hush!" she shouts at it, moving toward the balcony to keep it away from the house. She then looks back at her husband's initial letter, tenderly held in her hands, but as she walks back to her bedroom and sits on her bed, she suddenly looks bored. Her movement in the house, contextualized within a slow moving series of tracking and panning shots, reveals the *mise-en-scene* of the entire setting, divided by separated spaces between *inside* and *outside* areas, such as the inside bedroom of Charu, which leads through the narrow corridor to the outer area of the balcony, facing the internal garden. Accordingly, her husband has his own space, the office in which he spends most part of his day, while the servants live separately downstairs as in the English Victorian houses of the 19th century. The architectural similarities to a European aristocratic house are further underlined by the heavy decoration of the rooms with European objects, the clock, a mirror, lamps, photograph frames, wall paintings, the square bed, the furniture, and a book left on her bed, which

attracts Charu's bored attention. She picks it up and moves to another space, through the balcony to the living room situated opposite her bedroom, followed by the camera that takes the audience in a house that feels like a maze: a labyrinth in which communication and vision is blocked by a series of small rooms, bigger rooms, and heavily decorated corridors.

As Charu enters the living-room, walking towards a shelve with books, the camera zooms into a close-up of her face, and with a reverse angle shot a close-up of her fingers searching the book titles, while singing the name of the author she is looking for: "Bankim". She finds a book with its title written on its cover in golden letters, in Bengal "Kapaalkundala". She picks up the book and firmly holds it in her left hand, as with her right hand she equally firmly closes the glassy frame of the book shelve, which makes the viewer realize that her figure in the previous close-up was distorted because of the glass placed in front of the camera. By closing the frame, her figure becomes clearer, as she stares at the book, hesitantly wondering if she should pick it up. But then, a hypnotic and repeated sound of the small timpani, heard from outside the house, draws her attention. The sound instantly changes her demine, as if it is calling for her, convincing her of her intentions. The indecisive expression on her face is suddenly, but elegantly, replaced by a re-assured and confident smile, which is then settled into a concentrated interest in the contents of the book. She turns around in another reverse-angle shot, and the camera follows her as she moves along the rooms and the corridors of the house, but this time singing the Bengali verses of the book, opened in her hands and eyes. It is as if this book makes her forget of her complete surrounding isolation and loneliness, brilliantly acted by Madhabi Mukherjee, and masterfully framed by Ray.

She then slowly walks towards a shut window, to see who is playing the timpani. Like a prisoner, she uses a set of small binoculars, designed to watch European opera, to see through the shut window frame, which looks like an old wooden cage. With her binoculars, she can see an old blind beggar on the street playing the small timpani and holding two monkeys. As he walks off her limited vision of the narrow frame of the binoculars, her interest is then attracted by other street sounds from the other side of the small room, as she watches again through the shut window frame people passing-by. Her gaze follows a middle-aged man walking in the hot sun, carrying a closed umbrella like the stereotype of an Englishman, an image that makes her smile. But then, in a long-shot, she slowly turns around inside the living room, looking again unhappy and bored, in between the shut, front window of the house, and a Victoria couch accompanied by an old table with an expensive, but empty, vase on it. As she smoothly holds on the European couch, she turns around staring at the heavily decorated, but at the same time, empty room, while her finger nervously play with the binoculars. She looks at the lavish surrounding with a kind of soft bitterness that has replaced her previously reassured smile at the sound of the beggar's timpani.

Following Tagore's slow musical rhythm, she slowly walks towards a grant piano opposite the windows of the living-room. As the camera continues to track her movements in the house, she stops, elegantly taking the piano-stool, slowly opening the piano's cover, and then disinterested hitting two notes in boredom, before closing it again. The soft sound of the piano stops the slow musical theme of Tagore, and then, absolute silence follows; only to be interrupted again by more noise from the street. As Charu aimlessly wonders with the pair of binoculars in her hands, the frame of her husband hastily passes-by in front of the camera, fast and out-of-focus at the background. She looks quite upset because he does not even acknowledge her presence. She then angrily starts to follow him. Bhupati (Sailen Mukherjee) returns unaware of his wife's feelings, passing-by without even looking at her, a pipe in his mouth, wearing glasses and a long, academic beard, and reading from a book. She suddenly hears again the sound of the beggar's timpani outside from the street that gives her new confidence and brings back her smile. In the next sequence, Bhupati announces the visit of his cousin, Amal (Sumitra Chatterjee), the passionate and romantic patriot, whose visit will change her (and her husband's) life forever.

Table 3.2. Charu's Vision in Garden

Following Amal's announcement that his papers have been accepted for publication, which also moved that he will move out of the house and Charu's life, Charu gets so upset that she shots both her windows and doors to cry. Her crying behind doors is picked by her husband, but for once more he cannot get through to her. The self-indulgent Amal also tries to find out what is wrong with her, while offering ice-cream in his playful manner, but also, completely, or willingly, ignoring the clear signs of forbidden love, or *prem*, that Charu sends to him throughout the film: "Look Charu, if I write something good should it stay in your notebook? Nobody else sees it. It never gets printed. That's wrong, isn't it?" "Of course" Charu replies while continuing looking at a book holding in her hands, shutting him out of her vision. "Then you must admit I write very well, don't I?" the self-indulgent Amal continues. "Of course" Charu repeats. "This is something that deserves respect, don't you think?" Amal patronizes. "Of course", the shut Charu enigmatically replies for a third time. "Then, I can hope for a little more respect in future, right?" As he walks out of the room with a self-assured smile, the music gets tensed, building on a dissonant chord played by a violin orchestra which reflects upon Charu's intense and angered internal world. As she hears Amal off the frame talking to her cousin about his plans for the evening, she angrily shuts her book, shuts her eyes, raises her chin, and tries to tolerate his complete ignorance and at times pretentiousness. In a conventional sense, she realizes that His (male) Mind cannot match Her (female) Heart, and this realization brings her to the self-realization of *her* submissive position in a man's world.

This moment of Jungian Individuation is illustrated through her momentarily day vision (day-dreaming) in the house's garden that follows. As Charu bitterly turns her head, she notices a copy of the journal 'Bishwabanhul' left on the bed. The opened magazine makes her to pick up a European ink-pen and her diary, trying to think of something to write. A close-up of her hand shows her trying to write something on an empty page, but only leaving a dot of black ink. She cannot think of anything. As she stares at the empty space in a close-up, the sweet slow theme of the music gradually comes in to the foreground, along with the change of her facial expression from bitter to thoughtful. She remembers how she happily used to sing the Bengali song about a Cuckoo in the garden, and writes down the title of her story: "The Cry of the Cuckoo", which she indecisively changes into the more dramatic: "The Lament of the Cuckoo". But then, she has second thoughts about the title, the story, and in a way about her garden, her house, and thereby her imprisoned life between two incapable men, her husband and her flirt. The Cuckoo song is not the same anymore, because it signifies her moment of self-realization, individuation, and transgression.

This process of self-realization begins through her day-dreaming vision that takes place in the garden. A panning of the camera shows a close-up of autumn leafs on the ground, along with scrunched up papers, a carpet with a notebook, a pen, an ink bottle, and continues with an extreme close-up of Charu's figure and face as she sits immobile on her childhood swing. She intensely stares at the camera. The silent, almost-still frame is interrupted by the sound of a cuckoo, and the slight movement of the swing, as if pushed by the breath of the wind. A further close-up into her bright eyes reveals the life inside them. This image of Charu's face with her three eyes echoes the images of Doya in *Devi*, especially as the director superimposes an image of an open, calm sea, onto her eyes. A second superimposed image of fishing boats follows, focusing on as the sail of one of them that shows a painting of hunting and agricultural life onto her meditating eyes. Here, as in *Devi*, the director uses the technique of superimposition to directly connect Charu's internal world and thoughts to her external social life; in other words, what is inside her is outside, and vice-versa. The image of the sailing boat is dissolved back to the image of Charu staring at the camera, no longer in an intensive, but rather in a meditating and thoughtful manner that shows her self-realization. The vision then continues with the imposition of a third image of an old lady working on a spinning wheal, and a bird imprisoned in a cage, an image of destiny as self-realization (Carl C. Jung). The spinning wheel dissolves into an image of a children's round-about and festive fireworks. Further superimposed images of children playfully running through the fireworks take the viewer further into Charu's vision, which with a rapid panning of the camera develops into a nightmarish vision of exoticism: the caricatures of an aboriginal elder, a Hindu priest and an ascetic, an image of a young man wearing make up, dancers, another ascetic in make-up holding a cheap paper reproduction of Shiva's/ Poseidon's triton, other dancers jumping and dancing in exuberance, an image of a voodoo priest drinking from a bottle, an image of an old lady begging, and more images of exuberant dancers moving without rhythm, without aim, without reason. As the music gradually fades out, along with the vision of Charu projected on her face, a sudden zoom-out takes us out of her trance and back to everyday reality. Cut to a close up of Charu's hand, this time holding a pen and putting it in the ink bottle, before beginning to finally write the title of *her* novel: "My village". In the next sequence Amal is shocked by Charu's successful publication.

Charu's vision has direct relevance to Ray's previous and future work. The close-up images of Charu's face echo the images of the *Devi*; however, Charu's face shows more intention, as well as sense of independence. Furthermore, her vision through which she, as well as, the director and the audience meditate and reflect upon her status, as well as upon the social position of women in Bengal in the 19th century, is a vision of Otherness: a vision through which she realizes her fixed 'destiny', supported by the caricature figures of the Hindu priests, ascetics and pilgrims, mixed with images of exotic and on purpose stereotypical images of aboriginal and voodoo priests, which is the world that she then denies to submit to. Her female *Shakti* (as in *Devi*) is much stronger than the social reality she has to confront in order to protect the purity of her Heart, manifested as *prem*: the 'forbidden' and true Love. It is important to note here, that this nightmarish vision has been used by Ray in other films which also portray the process of self-realization and transformation of his characters: such as with Arati (played again by Madhabi Mukherjee) in *Mahanagar* (Big City 1964) which also deals with Arati's social imprisonment at home and her effort to find work in the city; or with the rebel character of Siddhartha in *Pratidwandi*.

Michelangelo Paganopoulos graduated from the University of Glasgow with an Honours Degree in Film and TV studies combined with Music. In 1999 he moved to London to study social anthropology at Goldsmiths College. He received his PhD in 2012, which focuses on monastic life. During this period, he has also published a number of articles on film, literature, and anthropology. Since September 2004, he has been a Visiting Faculty at the Department of Anthropology at Goldsmiths, University of London. E-mail: *paganopoulos@hotmail.com*

© *Media Watch* 4 (1) 28- 39, 2013
ISSN 0976-0911 e-ISSN 2249-8818

Mythology, Masculinity and Indian Cinema: Representation of 'Angry Young Man' in Popular Hindi Films of 1970s

SAAYAN CHATTOPADHYAY
Baruipur College, University of Calcutta, India

In the 1970s popular Hindi cinema witnessed an emergence of action oriented films with a distinctive "angry young man" protagonist. Tracing the antecedents of Indian masculine subjectivity in colonial discourse, this essay seeks to constitute a framework that identifies vestiges of mythological narratives alongside the politico-historical factors, to explain the formation of the belligerent male in the post-independence popular Hindi films. Reconciling the problematic of overdetermined "Indianness"— conceived as spiritual, calm, and other-worldly, together with its opposite: aggression, anger and this-worldly, that is also constitutive of Indian masculinity— the essay argues, benevolence or militancy cohere in the masculine self and, are activated according to specific political conditions in history. The angry man figure inscribed in the 1970s popular Hindi cinema is explicable in relation to the 1960s political crises in India that exposed a delegitimized Indian state. This essay focuses on the mythic tale of Parashurâma in the epic Purânas*, which is instructive in understanding the rage and rebellion of the figure of the angry man— and his violent yet eventually sacrosanct masculinity— whose dharma (sacred duty) is to reinstate the flawed ideal even if that meant confronting the enemy within or going against one's own family*.

Keywords: Masculinity, gender, Hindi films, mythology, action films, post-independence

Films, through its specific representational forms and practices, are involved in the production and re-production of masculinity as a cultural category. The cinematic apparatuses and its complex relationship with the socio-political developments produce distinct cultural texts which not only bear ideological underpinnings but also show deep psychological enunciations. Even if one isolates and considers the portrayal of men within the hetero-normative category in mainstream Indian popular cinema, its intersection with class, caste and ideological underpinning makes it a problematic and unsettled category. "Hindi cinema's narrative are unfailingly centered on a hero and heroine, who together constitute its fundamental templates in which masculinity is the flip side of femininity" (Virdi 2003, p. 87). The unfixed nature of masculinity of the Hindi film hero is evident with the changes in the construction of masculinity in response to the nation's history and the hero's role as a primary agent shaping that history. Masculinity as a social/cultural category undergoes continual transformation, making it impossible to construct it as a universal, generic, absolutist category.

Correspondence to: Saayan Chattopadhyay, Department of Journalism and Mass Communication, Baruipur College, Kolkata-741 126, India. All rights reserved with Media Watch. For permissions and reprint, please E-mail : *mediawatchjournal@gmail.com*

In the 1970s Hindi cinema witnessed an emergence of action oriented films with a typical 'angry young man' as the protagonist. An impressive number of studies (Prasad, 2001; Kazmi, 2002; Banerjea, 2005; Srivastava, 2006) underline the volatile political situation during the 1960s and 1970s as one of the reasons for the emergence of such a distinct genre of film. The political events taking place progressively after independence made the citizens of the newly independent nation-state disillusioned and the rhetoric of an ideal Indian nation-state seemed concocted. The formation of 'angry young man's' masculinity needs to be understood within this context. As Prasad has discussed, with the gradual obsolescence of feudal family romance, 'ordinary' heroes entrance was natural into mainstream commercial films. Dockworker, mineworker, gang-leader, porter, police officer, small time crook: these were some of the roles Amitabh played in his career, roles that were predominantly lower class, positioned at the periphery of the respectable society yet a figure of resistance. However, the construction of masculinity has been influenced not only by a shift to proletarian themes but also at the level of a transformative construction of an industrial masculinity, with the corresponding political, aesthetic and institutional values. It is also interesting to note that the mass popularity of the Kung Fu films in India, with the release of Enter the Dragon (1973) also proved to be instrumental in shaping the aggressive masculinity of the hero. As Koushik Banerjea points out "In this decade of increasingly authoritarian rule led by Indira Gandhi, the celluloid iconography of Bruce Lee's lean and mean stance against the villainous Han found ample residue in the angry Amitabh Bachchan characters throwing off the shackles of their subaltern status to fight the henchmen of rogue goonda (criminal) capitalists" (p. 16). These studies do provide an insight into the political and ideological workings behind the emergence and popularity of the 'angry young man' genre. However, Indian understanding of the self has strong underpinning of spiritualism and sainthood, and hence, in this essay, while, taking into account the prevalent argument regarding the constructivism through socio-political discourse, I seek to understand in what way, mythological accounts also invest in the construction of such belligerent, violent male protagonist.

In the first section of this essay, I would attempt to offer a sketchy outline of the issues relating to the cinematic representation of Indian masculinity and in the following section I would delineate the notion of spiritual masculinity and the ways it negotiates with the historical and political conditions. In the subsequent section, refereeing to certain mythological accounts, I shall discuss about a certain ambivalence of the masculine self to move on to the specific myth of Parashurama to understand the construction of a violent, irate, outlawed, dissatisfied 'angry young man' in popular Hindi films. In the process, I shall attempt to unpack the logic of representation, in line with the mythological accounts to suggest how his ambivalent masculine subjectivity is formed negotiating with the ideological and the mythological underpinnings.

Mythology and Ideology

The politics of representation in Indian cinema

Popular films play the role of a normative referent in the ideological construction of masculinity. Ostensibly, the representation of masculinity changes over time with historical, political conditions and through a complex mutually complementary discourse. The analogousness of nation and women gets manifested in post independence popular Hindi cinema with its tendency to metonymic contiguity between family and the nation being congealed with a similar emotive affection that is central to the 'Indian joint family'. The notion of masculinity changes as the hero struggles with different categories of enemies. "These enemies took the form of

unprincipled profiteers in the 1950s, foreign aggressors in the 1960s, "smugglers" in the 1970s, separatist "terrorist" and politicians in the 1980s, and authoritarian patriarchs in the 1990s." (Virdi, 2003, p. 87) Consequently, scholars have attempted to explore this intricate and shifting nature of the construction of masculine self, and also tried to extract the constitutive elements of this formation of masculine subjectivity. In the films immediately after independence, such as, *Râm Aur Shyam* (1967) or *Naya Daur* (1957), invested with the responsibility of nation building, the hero is constructed with an idealized longing for a nationalist spirit, savior of his mother/nation. While the later films like, *Deewar* (1975), *Muqaddar Ka Sikandar* (1978), *Coolie* (1983), *Charas* (1976), assume the nation as a natural political entity with its own problems, which the hero tries to overcome.

However, in this essay, without undermining the ideological explanations behind the emergence of the 'angry young man', I wish to draw a parallel to the *purânic* mythological tales because myth and ideology, as belief systems and modes of argumentative discourse, are structurally different but functionally similar. It is important to note that 'myth', as Roland Barthes used it in Mythologies (1957), functions almost as a synonym of 'ideology'. While, ideology refers to a hegemonic power, which legitimates itself by endorsing beliefs and values suitable to it; naturalizing and universalizing such beliefs so as to make them obvious and seemingly predestined; demeaning ideas which might contest it; eliminating opposing forms of thought, conceivably by some tacit but organized logic; and making social reality ambiguous in ways convenient to itself. Such 'mystification', as Terry Eagleton explains, "frequently takes the form of masking or suppressing social conflicts, from which arises the conception of ideology as an imaginary resolution of real contradictions" (1991, p. 6).

The aspect of a socially constructed reality which is passed of as 'natural' is important in both mythology and ideology. The opinions and values of a historically and socially specific class are held up as 'universal truths'. Efforts to confront this naturalization and universalization of a socially constructed reality are disregared for lacking common sense, and therefore excluded from serious consideration. The genuine power relations in society (between classes, between coloniser and colonised, between men and women etc.) are obscured, reference to all tensions and difficulties blocked out, glossed over, their political threat defused (Barthes, 1957, pp.74-77). Hence, it can be useful to read certain mythological traces into the ideological explanation behind the representation of such belligerent, violent male protagonist in the popular Hindi films of 1970s.

Spiritual masculinity and the discursive masculine subject

"India has always been a separate world, hard for any outsider, Eastern or Western, to penetrate. Such a culture becomes a projective test; it invites one not only to project on to it one's deepest fantasies, but also to reveal, through such self projection, the interpreter rather then the interpreted." (Nandy, 1988, pp. 79-80). This over determined nature of 'Indianness' not only makes it problematic to homogenize the process of subjetivation but also reveals the duality and incongruity of subjective identity. Hence, while most discussions regarding India is tempted to construct around 'spirituality'— Indians as other-worldly, self-righteous, calm and merciful, one has to understand that on the flipside of it remains overtly this-worldly motives, terrible self-interest and an increased identification with the aggressors, that revived the ideology of the martial races and a number of nineteenth century social and political movements that constituted Ksatriyahood[1] "as a new, nearly exclusive indicator of authentic Indianness" (Nandy, 1988, p. 7).

So is this violent, irate, outlawed, disgruntled masculinity in Hindi cinema an entirely new formation that is emerging out of the distinct political historical conditions? The polymorphic conception of spiritual masculinity embodies in itself both the militant and benevolent aspects of masculine self. I would suggest that the ambivalence lies in its interpretation and deployment in response to political, social conditions, while the primary constituents remain fairly coherent.

The arguments against the colonial aggression and in favour of emerging nationalism in early nineteenth and twentieth century India incorporated an array of texts that invested in the construction of the colonial Indian masculinity and which undoubtedly shaped the understanding of postcolonial Indian masculine self as well. Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay, dynamically articulated the concept of *sannyasi* (literally means 'saint') or *santan* (literally means 'son' but it carries the connotation of 'sons of motherland'), militant, rebellious, violent at the same time ascetic, celibate thus 'spiritually pure'. The construction of the *sannyasi* or *santan* was devised to transform itself as a politically proactive, assertive, spiritual masculine figure ready to take up the all important 'task'— "The task of a *Santana* is a difficult one. Anyone who is not a renouncer in the absolute sense is not fit to carry out this work" (Chattopadhyay, 1953, p. 697). Indubitably, this 'task' in the colonial context was to drive out from the Motherland those who did not have faith in the *sanatana dharma* [2] and to liberate the Hindu nation-state.

Swami Vivekananda, through his writings and speeches delineated the formation of the spiritual masculinity as a discursive formation emerging out of opposition from 'other' religions and 'other' masculinities. His construction of the spiritual masculinity, akin to Bankim, was ostensibly linked with liberating the Motherland and the limitations posed by the colonial social customs. Drawing from various ancient Hindu scriptures, including the Vedas, Gita and Upanishads, Vivekanda's notion of spiritual masculinity blended together the strength of the *Kshatriya* with the potency of knowledge of the *Brahman*— "Vivekananda, however, chose to fuse militant virility with the 'pure' Brahminical principle of asceticism in order to render masculinity invincible." (Chowdhury, 1998, p. 127)

"The Hindu (a prominent Indian religion) believes that he is a spirit. Him the sword cannot pierce—him the fire cannot burn—him the water cannot melt—him the air cannot dry." (Vivekananda, 1989, p. 9) Such a construction of the invincible masculine Indian, especially when the colonial consciousness constructs the stereotypes of effeminate, emasculated colonized identity emerges from the specific historical conditions that play with the ambivalent notion of spiritual masculine subjectivity with its double bind of violent, militant masculinity and the ascetic, sagacious masculinity. Gandhi, in early twentieth century, interestingly enough, neither attempted to reiterate the notion of *Ksatriyahood* as the ideal Indian masculine self, nor did he ascertain a spirituality which was a means to achieve and retain superior physical prowess. Rather, borrowing from the tradition of saintliness and the mythological narratives of power derived from bi-unity, Gandhi constructed Indian masculinity by ratifying that "…manliness and womanliness are equal, but the ability to transcend the man-woman dichotomy is superior to both, being an indicator of godly and saintly qualities." (Nandy, 1988, p. 53) The construction of such a spiritual masculinity is irrefutably connected with his major concern for *Satyagraha*[3] or militant nonviolence. Since the doctrine of nonviolence can only be practiced properly by a masculine subject which has transcended the man-woman dichotomy. The masculine self becomes a fusion of maternal prerogative and masculine courage of acknowledging his feminine side. Thus in the specificity of the late colonial condition, the militancy was laid in the negation of the culture of violence, which was irrefutably necessary for the colonial rule.

The discursive formation of the masculine subject within the understanding of the colonial self, I want to suggest, reveals the polymorphous nature of spiritual masculinity, which embodies both militant and benign aspects. Since it draws upon such mythological materials which can be ambivalent in nature, the manifestation or invocation of either militant or benign aspects depends on the desired response to the historical, political situation and the interpretation of such notion of masculine self within that historically specific discourse.

Myth and masculinity: Ambivalent Indian masculine self

Myth, as noted by a number of eminent scholars (Freud, 1953; Jung, 1968; Lévi-Strauss, 1955; Rank, 1914; Arlow, 1961; Propp, 1968) provides an ideal fulfillment of a repressed desire. The external surface of the myth hides its true meaning and thereby prevents fulfillment, but it also contains the subliminal meaning and thereby may provide contentment. Depth psychology intimately engages with myth to explore the notions of self and sexuality and suggests a frame of reference to analyze the original motives and behavioral processes. The fundamental ideas of masculinity and femininity in the Indian context can evidently be traced to the Indian mythic narratives, and unlike the West, Indian myth is closely related to everyday life and emphatically forms the cannon of Hindu religious texts. Corresponding to models of infant care and to the structure and values of family relationships, popular and well known myths are isomorphic with the central psychological constellations of the culture and are constantly renewed and validated by the nature of subjective experience. (Obeysekere, 1981)

The discursive formation of the masculine self is unquestionably tied with the Indian mythological narratives since repeatedly Indian myth or *Puranic* allusions are made to establish such discourse and to prescribe and justify the way 'lives are lived'. When it comes to psychoanalytic discussions on the formation of masculine subjectivity, there is an intriguing disparity between Western and Indian psyche. In a letter to Freud, Girindrashekhar Bose (1929) evidently pointed out that "The desire to be a female is more easily unearthed in Indian male patients than in European…" Even relatively modern psychoanalysts, like Kakar has reiterated that this fantasy of embodying the sexual attributes of both the parents seems to be reasonably more common since,

> "The hegemonic narrative of Hindu culture as far as male development is concerned, is neither that of Freud's Oedipus nor of Christianity's Adam. One of the more dominant narratives of this culture is that of Devi, the great goddess, especially her manifold expressions as mother in the inner world of the Hindu son." (Kakar, 1996, p. 112)

This general tendency of the Indian male psyche to embody sexual attributes of both the sexes, or more specifically, nurturing in the unconscious the 'primitive idea of being a woman', I will argue, points to a specific understanding of the ambivalence that marked the discourse on spiritual masculinity. Vivekananda's notion of spiritual masculinity which combined the courage and heroism of the *Ksatriya* and the asceticism of a saint obliquely drew upon the Indian myth of Devi. This immensely popular myth has a number of versions and been narrated in folktales, proverbs, ritual worships and sacred Hindu hymns.

What is striking is that this *Shakti* or ultimate cosmic power, the "great fiery splendor" is 'feminine'. As J. Stratton Hawley and Donna Marie Wulff (1996, p. 39) have rightly pointed

out that *Devi Mahatmya* does not recognize that *Shakti* is feminine and that its possessors or vehicle is masculine— for *Devi* herself possess *Shakti*. The dramatic and extremely violent narrative concludes with the *Devi* forcefully piercing the demon, *Mahisasura* with her spear but the potent all conquering 'masculine virility' is evident throughout the myth. I would like to point to this ambivalent nature of the sexuality and notions of gender, embodied by the goddess or *Devi*. This very ambivalence is exploited by Bankim Chandra, Vivekananda and other radical nationalist leaders during the colonial time to construct the notion of a spiritual masculinity that makes an effort to tap into the idea of *Shakti* and not surprisingly as corollary to it the notion of spiritual masculinity is constructed upon this ambivalence.

Gandhi on the other hand is more direct is his proclamation of this bi-unity, the transcendence of being solely man or woman and acknowledging the androgynous identity. Like the myth of *Ardhanariswar*, an incarnation of Lord Shiva as half man and half woman embodying the union of femininity and masculinity, creation and destruction, *prakriti* (primordial nature) and *purusha* (primal manliness). However, again I would suggest that his construction of spiritual masculinity— of dualism, bi-unity for a more powerful self as deployed by Gandhi in the colonial context seemed more potent than the masculinity of the colonizers. Again the subtle trope of ambivalence constituted upon the acceptance of androgyny destabilized the structure of the colonial authority which is deeply connected with the Western concept of manhood.

Confronting the 'Enemy Within': Spiritual crisis and the 'Angry Young Man'

The construction of aggressive, proletariat & often criminalized masculinity in the such popular films like, *Deewar*(1975), *Sholay* (1975), *Hera Pheri* (1976), *Don* (1978), *Trishul* (1978), *Muqaddar Ka Sikandar* (1978), *The Great Gambler* (1979) can not be understood in isolation from the postcolonial anxieties of post independent India. The film industry of India, considered to be a mediator of Indian culture was substantially connected with the discourse of nationalism and the nation-state, hence Indian cinema is perceived as the vehicle of socio-political discourse and ideology. However, in colonial period the Indian film industry was still in its nascent stage. As Priya Jaikumar (2003) remarks identifying colonial Indian cinema as a survivalist cinema: "Since inception, India's film market was exploited by the United States until Indian films were able to create a domestic audience "without quota or subsidy," consolidated with the arrival of sound technology and political independence." (p. 83)

The overwhelming influence of Hollywood films, strategic censorship by the colonial government and a tumultuous nationalist movement limited the scope of legitimate mediation and dissemination of ideology and cultural politics through colonial Indian cinema. Though an impressive number of mythological, historical and social films were produced during this time but the scope of this paper does not allow me to delve deep into the specific traces of mythological enunciations in the representation of the colonial masculine self in Indian cinema. Rather, this article would grapple with the questions of how the notion of spirituality, one of the major constituents of the populist idea of 'Indianness' and its ambivalent manifestation is consciously or instinctively used to construct the 'angry young man' masculinity, especially in the popular Hindi films of 1970s. And in what way, that particular imagination of the masculine self is composed within the specificity of mythological insinuations that play a crucial role in response to particular political and ideological conditions.

In maternal melodrama the mother's dedication to her son is overwhelming, as portrayed in such exceptionally successful films, *Mother India* (1957) and *Aradhana* (1969). On the other hand, films that underscore the quintessence of masculinity are commonly told from the son's point of view, narrativizing, among other things, the hero compensating his mother for

suffering at the hands of the father. This is prominently featured in Raj Kapoor's *Awaara* (1951), *Lawaaris* (1981), Yash Chopra's *Deewar* (1975) and *Trishul* (1978). These films were extremely successful with both men and women. Almost all these films' narrative, at least implicitly, responded to the troubled and intensified restructuring of the Indian family during the second half of the twentieth century. These films, considered as a whole, express a metanarrative: shifting family politics within India's feudal-patriarchal culture giving way to capitalist patriarchy.

The transition of the construction of masculinity towards a violent, irate, outlawed, dissatisfied 'angry young man' has its roots in the period of intense political upheaval beginning in the mid-sixties. This crisis has been explained by Madhava Prasad (2000, p. 120) as "a deep disaggregation of the socio-political structure resulting in the delegitimation of the consensual ideology of the state." This period has been marked by, Indira Gandhi becoming the Prime Minister after Lal Bahadur Shastri's death in 1966 until 1975, when, amidst political unrest she declared a state of emergency which continued for eighteen months. The emergency was notorious for tyrannical suspension of civil liberties, restriction on the freedom of press and indiscriminate detention of opposition leaders. It was also infamous for Sanjay Gandhi's policy of mass sterilization and eviction of urban slums which left deep scars in the mind of the marginal disposed. Particularly, mass sterilization of male or vasectomy was identified as a threat to masculinity, which was being imposed vigorously by the state over the subaltern population. With the disintegration of the socio-political order, the middle class became open to the appeal of a new identity based on "disidentification with the 'socialist' programme in the national project". (Prasad, 2000). The ideological construction of 'angry young man's' masculinity needs to be discussed within this framework. Indian cinema or more specifically Hindi cinema is conceived as shared fantasy emanating out of the desire of the people of India linked with each other culturally and psychologically. The unfulfilled wishes, dreams and discontented desires are fulfilled like a daydream or fairytale[4]. (Kakar, 1996, pp. 24-27) Hence Hindi popular cinema in itself becomes myth, a social myth, as Jacob Arlow (1961) explains,

> "The myth is a particular kind of communal experience. It is a special form of 'shared fantasy', and it serves to bring the individual into relationship with members of his cultural group on the basis of certain common needs. Accordingly, the myth can be studied from the point of view of its function in psychic integration" (p. 375).

Thus, in the 1970s this 'shared fantasy' involved a way out from the deep political discontent and intense disenchantment with the postcolonial independent nation-state, candidly apparent in the then prevalent proclamation in Hindi, "*Ye Azadi Jhuta Hai!*" (This freedom is a lie!). Unlike the colonial time, I would suggest that the enemy does not come from outside like the *asura* (demon) rather the government and its governance proves demonic in its austerity, failure, violence and domination. The citizens of independent India neither find the mythic nation that the nationalist leaders made them foresee, nor do they find a veritable representative state leadership for consensual governance. Instead, what they vulnerably witness is a volatile political situation, disintegration of the image of the nation from an ideal to a natural political entity revealing many inadequacy and debility.

Not surprisingly, this postcolonial crisis has analogy with a number of Indian mythological narratives, but unlike the colonial discourse of nationalism, spiritualism and masculinity, such mythic enunciations did not receive recognition and reiteration, since the exclusionary trajectory of the national modernity found such traces incompatible. The dissatisfaction of the citizens

with the policies and governance of the state authority was originating from the gradual alienation of the marginalized, inept ruling class and the exclusionary nature of the state apparatus. Unemployment, inflation and increasing class conflicts and segregating urbanization evoked a shared fantasy of escaping such dreadful socio-political condition by defeating the enemy within. The struggle against such 'enemy within' has a double bind. While resistance against the colonial rulers or the religious 'other'[5] had no scope of transgression, since both the 'enemy' are alien to India and the 'Indianness' thus easier to confront and deracinate.

On the contrary, confronting the 'enemy within'— going against the legal apparatus, administrative machinery, judiciary and disciplinary institutions— in other words waging a war against the different institutions of the nation-state itself involve a sense of culpability. Revolting or retaliating against a keen, a brother, even the mother requires severe reparation, even perhaps the ultimate self-punishment. But to discipline this waywardness, to restrain the debauchedness, one has to commit the supposed "sin" of going against ones own people.

The responsibilities, privileges and limitations of every role are stipulated by an undeniable law, the *sanatan* or "eternal" *dharma*, and apply equally to the most powerful as to the weakest of subjects. A common belief reiterated in various Indian mythological tales is that the authority of social institutions rests in the *dharma* they encompass rather than in practical contractual agreements and duties. Besides , it is usually assumed that social conflict, subjugation and disorder do not originate from the organization of social relations, but begin in the *adharma* (Sanskrit antonym of *Dharma*) of those in positions of power. Since the paternalistic nation-state can not stray in the path of *adharma* thus it is up to the sacrificial individual who would punish those villains out of his personal vengeance (but that would indirectly serve the nation) that often has roots in his improper childhood. Hence, the extra-legal citizen subject has to die a sacrificial death so that the law-abiding ideal citizen subject may remain true to his self.

This narrative trope like a myth is reiterated in a number of popular films with very little variations. Thus, in *Muqaddar Ka Sikandar* (1978) following a similar narrative trajectory, Bachchan's character called Sikandar does the act of switching sides, positioning himself on the side of the "illegal" but morally upright margin, with an inevitable sacrificial end. In *Deewar* (1975), the male protagonist Vijay, again played by Amitabh Bachchan takes up this "sin" of going against the law and the state only to be killed in the end by his brother, Ravi, played by Shashi Kapoor, who, as a sub-inspector, remains an rightful part of the nation-state and the government. In *Sholay* (1975) Jai and Veeru played by Bachchan and Dharmendra respectively, represent the sacrificial individual who would punish the villains out of his personal vengeance and thus obliquely serving the nation. Similarly, in both *Don* (1978) and *Trishul* (1978), the male protagonist positions himself on the side of the "illegal" but at the same time morally upright location, which gave the figure its power and mass appeal.

Here, I would like to remind the metonymic contiguity between 'family' and the 'nation' being congealed with a similar emotive affection that is central to the 'Indian joint family' is a common rhetoric even in postcolonial discourse. Thus acting beyond the marked contour of individual agency delineated by the legal, judicial, administrative and other institutions of the nation state is akin to acting against the family, or the brother, or against the 'mother'. The notion of spiritual masculinity so far never confronted such a crisis in regard to its response to socio-political condition. Apparently it seems that the very basic idea of spirituality will perish if one resorts to retaliate and strike against the family, the brother or more importantly the mother. But for the attainment of the 'ideal' repudiation of the flawed and inappropriate ideal may become necessary. The mythological parallel may remind us the popular narrative of *Parashurama* narrated in the great epics and the *Puranas*—

> Seeing the charming king Gandharva; Renuka, the wife of sage Jamadagni and mother of Parashurama, sensed fleeting erotic desires for the king. Coming to know this Jamadagni became infuriated and ordered his four sons to immediately kill their mother. Matricide being the grievous sin, they refused to abide by their father's order. Being even more enraged, Jamdagni cursed his four sons to become imbecile. But the youngest of the sons, Parashurama, abiding by his father's order instantly decapitated his mother. Being very content with his son's obedience, Jamadagni sought to bless him with boons. Being asked what blessings he wants for himself, Parashurama asserted that the first thing that he wishes is his mother must be resurrected immediately and she should not be able to recollect what happened to her. Moreover, he should not be sinned for matricide; his imbecile brothers should gain back their normalcy and he should be able to lead a long, invincible life.

The interesting aspect of this mythic narrative is that after the matricide the first thing that the son, Parashurama wanted was that his mother should be resurrected and she should not have any memory of this incident. Thus by exercising the *Ksatriya dharma* (duty), he exterminated the flawed, deviated 'ideal', which his brothers could not exercise being limited with onerous Brahminic values. On the other hand, by asking for resurrecting his executed mother and more importantly by praying to make her mother forget that incident he displays his *Brahmana guna* (virtue). A perfect blend of *Brahmana guna and Ksatriya dharma* which manifests in response to imminent crisis – thus the sin of going against the institutions of the nation-state akin to revolting against ones own family, is mitigated as the intention is to reinstate the 'ideal' by retaliating against the 'flawed ideal'.

Hence the notion of spirituality in this construction of postcolonial masculinity emerging not out of a crisis from an alien regime but the newly discovered flaw and incoherence in the delusion of ideal. However, the discursive construction of masculinity is again formed on an ambivalence of the notion of spirituality, an ambivalence which easily accommodates violent, irate, outlawed actions at the same time, legitimizes it with the accepted self-punishment by being violently wounded, beaten and very often being dead. A popular cinematic trope in Hindi cinema of 1970s— the almost inevitable murder or death of the ladylove inscribe this attempted project of recuperating a deviated, spoiled 'ideal', while the suffering mother, embodies the tormented, anguished ideal which attempts to remain pure till the end. It is this untainted ideal that the male hero wants to unite with, an analogy with the unattainable reunion with the mother.[6]

Thus the construction of the 'angry young man', I wish to suggest, is evoked in the specificity of the post-independent crisis of the 'ideal national-state', and to rectify this 'flawed ideal' the violent, irate and dissatisfied masculinity is formed which firstly, becomes a construction of the shared fantasy of the population and secondly it plays with an ambivalence of good and bad, sacred and profane, spiritual and non-spiritual— all these a corollary to an ambivalence of Brahminic and Ksatriyahood. Here again, the mythic character of Parashurama[7] emblematically embodies the constituents of such a violent yet eventually sacrosanct masculinity, whose very formation, whose very history, legitimizes the violence, brutality. Often his foreseeable death underscores two issues. First, that such digression to rectify the ideal is necessary but will be sternly castigated and second to unite with the ideal one has to undertake rigorous penance perhaps a new birth.

These mythological narratives found a comfortable location in the cultural memory and made possible the wide acceptance and popularity of the 'angry young man' character in 1970s and 1980s. Hindi popular cinema like a social myth or perhaps akin to fairy tales, expresses the shared fantasy, which becomes the site for the overdetermined formation of masculinity with its ambivalence, its doubling and its temporality.

Conclusion

In this paper I have not tried to conduct a close textual readings of films to discuss about the representation of the 'angry young man' in the popular Hindi films of 1970s, rather my intention was to put forward few conjectures that may serve as an alternative interpretative framework to comprehend a social phenomena and its mediation in popular culture. The formation of the aggressive and often criminalized masculinity on screen, with its overdetermined masculine subjectivity underscores an ambivalence which has traces of Indian mythological narratives nurtured in the shared fantasy and the cultural memory of the cinemagoers. Popular cultural representations, whether through Hindi cinema or in any other form share a complex relationship with the ideological formation of the masculine self; but to understand the discursive formation of even such a clearly ideological and historically specific construction of the 'angry young man' it might be constructive to employ a psychoanalytical perspective interwoven with mythological traces. This trajectory is perhaps more accommodating to the apparent contradictions between the spiritual, ascetic notions of masculine subjectivity and the aggressive, violent masculine self. One of the objectives of this article was to suggest that it would be unwise to isolate the mythic and the fantastic from the political, ideological and historical, since they constitute and alter each other in the discursive formation of the subject. The altering notions of masculinity in Indian cinema, with the shifting nature of spiritual, political and ideological underpinnings become apparent in post-liberalization period of India as well, when the representation of the masculinity on screen altered considerably in the face of rising consumerism and globalization.

Notes

1. *Ksatriya*, is second highest in status of the four *varnas*, traditionally the military or ruling class of the traditional Vedic-Hindu social system as outlined by the Vedas and the Laws of Manu. *Ksatriya* means holder of *ksatra* (authority). According to Manu, due to the eventual differences in occupations, people ended up in different *jâtis* and caste. Those who studied the Vedas became known as *Brahmins*, those who practiced trade became *Vaishya*, those who labored became *Sudra*, and those who took up martial arts became *Kshatriyas*.
2. *Sanatana Dharma* denotes 'eternal natural law' created by divine sources. This is eternal and ever present and carries substantial spiritual and religious implications. However in the discourse of nationalism the interpretation of *Sanata Dharma* received political undertones. While the notion of *Sanatana Dharma* has the potentiality to go beyond limited religious and ritualistic articulations but during the colonial and postcolonial period the term has been specifically exploited to refer to exclusively Hindu identity and practices. Hence it is not surprising that the non-believers in *Sanata Dharma* did not only include British colonizers but also Muslims.
3. The term *satyagraha* was Gandhi's invention based on the conjunction of two words: *satya*, meaning 'truth', and '*agraha'* meaning firmness.
4. For classical Freudian myth, dreams and fairytales are alike. It is the contemporary Freudians who maintain that myth, dreams and fairytales are different from each other. And the difference occurs mainly on the aspects of wish fulfillment or denial and serving the superego, ego or the id. For a detailed discussion on myth see, Bruno Bettelheim, *The Use of Enchantment* (New York: Vintage Books, 1977)
5. As I have already mentioned the 'religious other' in colonial and postcolonial time is primarily Muslim; besides it also involves any religion other than Hinduism. Even though radical Hindu nationalist groups

like *Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh* (RSS)[National Volunteers' Organisation] emerged during the colonial period but it became perhaps more proactive in post-independence era, especially endorsing *Bharatiya Janata Party* (BJP). Vinayak Damodar Savarkar, Dayanand Saraswati, Keshav Baliram Hedgewar and other radical Hindu nationalists with there exclusionary often militant interpretations of *Hindutva* reinstated 'Hinduness' as intrinsic to the nation. For a detailed discussion see, Dayanand Saraswati, *The Light of Truth in Sources of Indian Tradition*-Volume II-Modern India and Pakistan, ed. Stephen Hay (New Delhi: Penguin Books, 1988); Vinayak Damodar Savarkar, *Hindutva* (New Delhi: Hindi Sahitya Sadan, 2003 edition) and Thomas Blom Hansen, *The Saffron Wave: Democracy and Hindu Nationalism in Modern India* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1999)

6. Amitabh Bachchan became a kind of personification of this scheme, with a certain amount of integration of star value within the narrative that was hitherto unattainable. While several stars were successful in forming a star-image, only Bachchan, who enjoyed unprecedented success, eventually evolved into a national figure. The turning point came with the scripts written by Salim-Javed, screenwriter duo. Filmfare, a popular Indian film magazine, in a special issue on cinema of 1970s commented, "They called him the One Man Industry and for sixteen years he churned out hits with assembly line regularity. *Zanjeer, Deewar, Don, Amar Akbar Anthony, Muqaddar Ka Sikandar, Trishul, Kasme Vaade, Kaala Patthar, Laawaris, Kaalia, Naseeb, Namak Halal, Andha Kanoon, Coolie, Mard, Geraftaar*…Never before had a star seen this kind of success, and for so long."
7. The mythological narrative of Parashurama's birth also underlines this ambivalence. Parashurama's grandmother Satyabati received a boon from her father-in-law, the great sage Vrigu. Satyabati being childless, asked for two potions from *Vrigu*; one for herself and another for her mother. The potion meant for Satyabati had Brahmanic qualities and the other one meant for her mother had *Kshtriya* attributes, since she belonged to a *Kshtriya* dynasty. But due to her mother's instigation, Stayabati unknowingly consumed the potion with *Kshtriya teja* and her mother had the potion with Brahminic attributes. So Satyabati's son, in spite of being born in a Brahmin family will bear *Kshtriya* attributes and her mother's progeny will bear Brahminic attributes in spite of being born in a *Kshtriya* lineage. After knowing this Satyabati, pleaded to Vrigu for not letting her son yield *Kshtriya* attributes. But since the potions were irrevocable, Vrigu informed Satyabati that her son will not bear *Kshtriya* traits but her grandson will display *Kshtriyahood*. Shortly, Satyabati gave birth to Jamadagni, who later married Renuka and had five sons, the youngest of them Parashurama, inherited the distinct *Kshtriya* traits in spite of being a Brahmin.

References

Arlow, Jacob. A. (1961). Ego Psychology and the Study of Mythology. *Journal of the American Psychoanalytic Association*, *9*, 371-393.

Bettelheim, Bruno. (1977). *The Use of Enchantment*. New York: Vintage Books.

Chatterjee, Partha. (1997). *The Nation and Its Fragments: Colonial and Postcolonial Histories*, Delhi: Oxford University Press.

Chattopadhyay, Bankim. Chandra. (1953). *Bamkim Rachanabali*, vols. I-III. Jogesh Chandra Bagal (Ed.). Calcutta: Sahitya Samsad.

Chowdhury, Indira. (2001). *The Frail Hero and Virile History: Gender and the Politics of Culture in Colonial Bengal*. New Delhi: Oxford University Press.

Freud, Sigmund. (1953). The Interpretation of Dreams, vols. IV-V, *Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud*, (ed. & tr.) James Strachey. London: Hogarth Press.

Hawley, John. Stratton and Wulff, Donna. Marie. (1996). *Devî: Goddesses of India.* University of California Press.

Jaikumar, Priya. (2003). More Than Morality: The Indian Cinematograph Committee Interviews. *The Moving Image*, *3*(1), University of Minnesota Press. 82-109.

Jung, C. G. (1968). *The Archetypes and the Collective Unconscious: Collected Works*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Kakar, Sudhir. (2007). *Intimate Relations: Exploring Indian Sexuality*. India:Penguing Books.

Lal, Vinay, & Nandy, Ashis. (Ed.). (2007). *Fingerprinting Popular Culture*. New Delhi: Oxford University Press.

Lévi-Strauss, Claude. (1955). The Structural Study of Myth. *Journal of American Folklore*, *68*, 428-444.

Nandy, Ashis. (2007). *The Intimate Enemy: Loss and Recovery of Self Under Colonialism.* New Delhi: Oxford University Press.

Nandy, Ashis. (Ed.). (1998). *The Secret Politics of Our Desires: Innocence, Culpability and Indian Popular Cinema*. New Delhi: Oxford University Press.

Obeyesekere, Gananath. (1981). *Medusa's Hair: An Essay on Personal Symbols and Religious Experience*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Prasad, Madhava. (2000). *Ideology Of The Hindi Film: A Historical Construction*. New Delhi: Oxford University Press.

Propp, Vladimir. (1968). *Morphology of the Folktale*. Laurence Scott (tr.). Austin: University of Texas Press.

Rank, Otto. (1914). *The Myth of the Birth of the Hero*. 1st edn. F. Robbins & Smith Ely Jelliffe. (tr.). New York: Journal of Nervous and Mental Disease Publishing.

Virdi, Jyotika. (2003). *The Cinematic Imagination: Indian Popular Films As Social History*. NJ: Rutgers University Press

Vivekananda, Swami. (1989). *The Complete Works of Swami Vivekananda*, vols. I-VIII. Mayavati Memorial Edition, Calcutta: Advita Ashrama.

Saayan Chattopadhyay is Assistant Professor and Head of the Department of Journalism and Mass Communication at Baruipur College, affiliated to Calcutta University, India. After a stint as a journalist, he is currently engaged in research in postcolonial media and masculinity. His research interests include masculinity studies, popular films, postcolonial journalism, performative theory. E-mail: *saayanchattopadhyay@gmail.com*

© *Media Watch* 4 (1) 40- 51, 2013
ISSN 0976-0911 e-ISSN 2249-8818

Vision of Tagore through Applicability in the Spectrum of Ray and Ghosh: Reflection of Feminine Approach in two Bengali Movies

MAUMITA CHAUDHURI
Barrackpore Rastraguru Surendranath College
West Bengal State University, India

Rabindranath Tagore had an enormous influence on Satyajit Ray, one of the great directors in India's long tradition of art house cinema who directed Charulata, and Chokher Bali is made by a director much influenced by Ray in turn, Rituparno Ghosh. The film Charulata affords a dazzling view of Satyajit Ray's mastery of the medium and gives vital proof of his ability to explore universal themes without compromising his uniquely Bengali sensibilities. Ray's script gracefully follows the maturing of Charu's artistic and feminine identity. The Bengali filmmaker Rituparno Ghosh writes and directs the costume melodrama Chokher Bali: A Passion Play which focuses on the situation of women. Set in the early 1900s, the film draws parallels between the British colonization of Bengal and the domestic situation of a Calcutta household. This paper tries to analyze the representation of Indian Bengali female characters, written by Tagore in the early 20th century, through the above mentioned two movies.

Keywords: Nationalism, womanhood, partition of India, man-woman relationship

The Nobel laureate Gurudev Rabindranath Tagore had written plenty of stories of which two have been selected for the paper. *Charulata*, one of the finest cinema directed by Satyajit Ray and *Chokher Bali*, another one of the purest cinema directed by Rituporno Ghosh. The feminity projected by the actresses in the early 1900s Bengal were beyond words. The detailed analysis and interpretations of the stories have been provided with the help of intimate relations, proper expressions and overall representations through both the movies.

Cinematic Spectacle of *Charulata*

Satyajit Ray remains largely committed to a social-realist imperative in his cinema. In 1966, following the critical success of *Charulata*, Ray wrote that he had chosen for himself "the field of intimate cinema… of mood and atmosphere rather than of grandeur and spectacle" (Ray, 1976). However, in *Charulata* there is evidence of a cinema born out of the exquisite love affair *between* intimacy and spectacle and an Ophulsian cinematic spectacle. *Charulata* is based on the 1901 novella *Nastanirh* (*The Broken Nest*) by Bengali author Rabindranath Tagore

Correspondence to: Maumita Chaudhuri, Department of Journalism & Mass Communication, Barrackpore Rastraguru Surendranath College, 6 Riverside Road, Barrackpore, North 24 Parganas, Kolkata-700 120. E-mail: *chaudhuri.maumita@gmail.com.* All rights reserved with *Media Watch*. For permissions and reprint, please e-mail: *mediawatchjournal@gmail.com*

(Robinson, 1989). Ray later said that he liked the novella because "it has a western quality to it and the film obviously shares that quality. That's why I can speak of Mozart in connection with *Charulata* quite validly" (Robinson, 1989). Ray decided to set the film in the 1880s instead of in 1901 and spent many months researching the historical background of the film. For the first time in his career he worked without a deadline both during pre-production and during the shooting (Robinson, 1989). Ray worked closely with art director Bansi Chandragupta and no interior scene was shot on location. All sets were built or remodeled, meticulously researched and detailed to accurately portray India in the 1880s. Ray cast Indian actress Madhabi Mukherjee in the role of Charulata, but had difficulty with her due to her addiction to eating Paan, which stained her teeth black. Because of this Ray had to be careful about what camera angles he used to film Mukherjee (Robinson, 1989). Ray once called *Charulata* his favorite of his own films (Robinson, 1989).

Charulata (The Lonely Wife) was Ray's twelfth feature film. Ray described the film as the one which has the least defects. In an interview with 'Cineaste' magazine, when asked about his most satisfying film, Ray said, "Well, the one film that I would make the same way, if I had to do it again, is Charulata." But the film works on many levels and like most Ray films, Charulata is universal in its appeal. In Charulata, Satyajit Ray explores the emergence of the modern woman in the upper-class of colonial India. One can not help drawing parallels with Ibsen's 'A Doll's House'. (*Charulata*, The Lonely Wife, 1965).

Charulata was also the filmmaker's second adaptation of a Rabindranath Tagore work (after 1961's *Teen Kanya*) and, indeed, one senses a close affinity between Ray's cinema and Tagore's literature. Like his literary idol's, Ray's narratives are alive with the textures of nature, the rhythms of native Bengali life, and the nuances of human gesture and behavior. A drifting camera, following Charu around the mansion's breezy corridors and apartments, opens the film. At one point, the camera moves her flitting from window to window, peeking through her lorgnettes at the humdrum of street life below. Otherwise, she thumbs through old novels by Bengali romantics or plays cards with Manda (Gitali Roy), her earthier, saucier sister-in-law. Ray's décor may be divertingly lovely, but he makes sure to include hints of Charu's inner reality: The iron bars on the window and the birdcage poised in the corridor, for example, suggest all is not well. Suddenly, the light in the room darkens and the winds pick up, threatening the home's blasé tranquility. The storm heralds the arrival of Amal (Soumitra Chatterjee), Charu's brother-in-law, an idealist-poet with whom she fell in love. True to Tagore, Ray marshals nature's tantrums to foreshadow or punctuate turning points in his characters' lives, and this is a particularly poignant moment because no one, least of all the happy-go-lucky Amal nor the dutiful Charu, expect the emotional storms to come (Antani, 2004).

'Broken Nest' reads more like a compressed novel than a short story, it moves through extended passages and gaps in time, through episodes and broad developments in characters and situations. The long introductory sequence of *Charulata* is probably the best example and a piece of cinematic poetry of the masterly technique of compression and telescoping Ray uses to translate descriptive passages. Almost without any dialogue the sequence establishes a typical afternoon in Charu's life, her loneliness, her affinity to novels, the spatial limits of her movements. It brings to life an object-world that embodies time – the wallpaper, the furniture, the items of daily use, but also the street sounds and the street images (Biswas, n.d.). These images are glimpsed by Charu through an opera glass: as she opens one blind after another on the wall to peek at the comically graphic characters moving in the street, her socially restricted movement momentarily turns into a playful choreography. And then Charu frames the figure of her husband

Bhupati with the opera glass - passing down the corridor not noticing her, lost in his book. Ray conjures up this interior with a dexterity that reminds of the image of Charu's embroidery in the title sequence, a texture of words is dissolved into a weave of images effortlessly before the eyes (Bandyopadhyay, 1993).

Ray conveys the innermost feelings and thoughts of his characters without any dazzling technique and with minimal dialog. A wonderful sequence is the swing sequence in the garden. In this scene Charu, who has been resisting her feelings for Amal, gives in and admits her love to herself. It is about eight-minute long sequence with almost no dialogue. With innovative camera and narrative style, Ray depicts Charu's state of mind and her dilemma. (*Charulata*, The Lonely Wife, 1965). In 1965, Penelope Houston of Sight and Sound remarked "...The interplay of sophistication and simplicity is extraordinary." *Charulata* belongs to that venerable category of films that unabashedly display their complexities, and are readily regarded as "exemplary" because of the delightful struggle involved in talking or writing about them. For several Ray enthusiasts – it *is* the director's masterpiece, a film that has been likened to Mozart's music (but with little objective justification), and is cinematically "close to perfection" (Nyce, 1988). However, Charu spends most of the narrative oscillating between the *Prachina* and the *Nabina*; she is never quite one or the other (Chaudhuri, 2004).

At a more discursive level, the whole film can be seen to be engaged in a dialogue with one of Bankim's essays, 'Women, Old and New', a major statement on what is known as the 'Women's Question' in the nineteenth century. All this is added to Tagore's original text which finds itself embedded in a tapestry of literary signs. The image of writing, the written word, forms a major visual motif – Amal writing, Charu writing, Bhupati getting intoxicated with the printed word. The alphabet shining on the embroidery over the titles signals a process which leads to the very last image of the film: the hands of Charu and Bhupati freeze before they could meet; the title of Tagore's story appears on the screen in calligraphic design. This would appear as merely explanatory and redundant unless follow the logic of appearance of the written word in the film (Biswas, n.d.). It is a final gesture of receding from the original story, of turning the work itself into an object of the film's gaze. The scene in which Bhupati comes to know about Charu's feelings for his cousin the camera makes a gesture very unusual for Ray: it climbs up the leg of a marble table slowly to reveal a letter lying on it while Charu and Bhupati are heard talking off-screen. The letter is from Amal and it will bring about an emotional outburst in Charu giving her feelings away (Ghosh, 1990).

Bankim's 'Women Old and New' was published in 1879 (Ray gives an exact time for the events, 1879, from the dateline on the copy of the magazine that Bhupati shows Amal) where he argues for a new woman who would be modern in the traditional way. She would embody the resolution of the conflict between tradition and modernity by finding her place in a re-invented patriarchy. She would learn to be the new old woman. As the film launches a dialogue with this essay it maps Tagore's story onto a historical grid, the political drama is brought out into the open. The story tells of the formation of the colonial subject, male and female, and of the inevitable irony and pain that attend the process. Tagore begins his story by an ironic description of the domains his characters occupy (Dutta & Lago, 1992). The idealistic, English educated Bhupati is worried about the expansion of British territories beyond the Afghan borders, but hasn't had the time to notice how his child bride has bloomed into womanhood; Charu's idleness is of a different kind, reminding one of a fruitless tree. As she develops an expressive selfhood, through her love and through her writing, the challenge of the demarcation of domains comes to face her, it demands a heavy price. The dichotomy of literature and

politics suggested in the story is developed into a strong motif in the film. The first is associated with the woman; the second belongs to the man (Biswas, n.d.). Bhupati entrusts Amal with Charu's literary education admitting that he has no taste for such things, busy as he is with the 'real world' of politics. Ray also makes him say to Amal that this politics, critical though it is of the colonial government's policies, is not meant to be disloyal to the masters. And from Bhupati the story showed how worried he and friends are about the outcome of the parliamentary elections in Britain; one of his friends has vowed to sacrifice a goat at the Kali temple if the liberals win (Ray, 1982).

Intermission

What begins as a seemingly straightforward character study quickly develops into a scathing critique of the social hypocrisies of the Bengali Renaissance. Charu becomes representative of a generation of women, encouraged to experience a sense of liberty and independence, but only within the *andarmahal* (inner sanctum of the house). Ray's structural and aesthetic approach to the delicate complexities of his thematics and narrative deserves careful scrutiny, and has certainly not gone unnoticed, but for the sake of brevity it is perhaps appropriate to only highlight the key aspects of his strategy. In the opening segment of the film, Ray takes full advantage of the cinematic apparatus at his disposal, in search of a "language entirely free from literary and theatrical influences" (Ray qtd. in Robinson, 1989). Dialogue is almost done away with; sound cues and music are carefully selected and introduced with pin-point precision, and the action and camera movement are orchestrated to mediate between Charu's reflective pauses and moments of acceleration. The end result is a wonderfully intricate, almost composed tableau that already discloses Ray's thematic concerns as well as his formal approach (Chaudhuri, 2004).

Amal and Bhupati are both dreamers and full of contradictions. In one pivotal, wonderfully played out scene, Bhupati urges Amal to give up poetry and accept a marriage proposal that could send him to London to study law. As Bhupati spins his gossamer visions of snowy London and fabled Europe, Amal is, for a moment, taken in. It's striking that Bhupati, a passionate revolutionary and Bengali stalwart, would be so enamored of Europe, the realm of his colonialist captors. Equally striking is that Amal, so easily swept away by visions of the Mediterranean, would so readily reject Bhupati's offer. For all his poetic flights of fancy, Amal is rooted in the soil of Bengal, its literature and music. Observing this exchange in silence stands Charu, nursing her own conflicted feelings of love and bitterness, both over Amal, emotions that first surfaced in the film's previous and most famous scene (Antani, 2004). Used recurrently as a self-reflexive motif in the film as well as making reference to an enforced spatial confinement (her restriction within the *andarmahal*). A momentary frame is created when Bhupati very briefly stops in his tracks to examine the book he is engrossed in. Charu is positioned a step behind within the frames of the ornate doors, implying an almost helpless vanity. The image, the pause, the positioning – all become highly symptomatic of the inertia that this relationship is based upon. In making the pause momentary, Ray projects this inertia as a trajectory, or the linear progression of a state of affairs, rather than a picture of complete stasis and inactivity. Charu's condition is not something that just *is*, but rather something that *continues to be*, a persisting "sameness" hidden in the wings of a period of socio-political mobility (Chaudhuri, 2004).

That scene, played out in the garden, is significant not only for what it reveals of Charu's heart, but as a microcosm of Ray's artistry. Pivoting the scene on Charu, he deliberately, even playfully, follows her observations, tracing the slow emergence of feelings she knows are

forbidden. As she arcs back and forth on the swing, Ray switches from intimate close-ups of Charu singing her signature tune to her point of view, showing the reposed Amal flitting in and out of her view. The effect is of a chipping away, of Charu realizing that the walls that have heretofore kept her feelings at bay are being intruded upon and expressed visually by Amal's jutting in and out of her point of view. This becomes devastatingly clear moments later—with Ray again using the optical point-of-view tactic—when she spies a mother and child through her lorgnettes and then turns her gaze to a preoccupied Amal. Ray cuts to a protracted close-up of Charu as the tides of regret—over her childless life, her yearning for romance—sweep across her face followed by a wave of sudden panic as her love for Amal dawns on her. It's a quintessential Ray moment of slow, patient observation leading to an emotional wallop of a climax (Antani, 2004).

Bhupati writes politics in English, Amal and Charu writes literature in Bengali. And then to a further division: Amal writes for public circulation, in an ornate register, Charu would like to write for a strictly private exchange, in an unadorned style through which she can evoke personal experiences. Towards the end, after Amal has left the house and Bhupati's magazine has failed, Charu and Bhupati go on a visit to the seaside and plan a poignantly illusory reconciliation between the poles of opposition – between the public and the private, home and the world, politics and culture. Why not bring out another magazine, they propose, which will have politics in English and literature in Bengali (Rudra, 1996).

What Tagore conveys through the words of his omniscient—but interestingly not completely omniscient—narrator, telling that Amal's feelings are like that of a traveler upon a mountain path with one foot extended over a deep ravine, Satyajit Ray shows in a scene wherein words give context to what Amal is thinking. Preceding this scene, Bhupati has found out from his newsprint supplier that Umapati has been cheating him. The Motilal character in Tagore's short story disappears completely from Ray's film. But Bhupati is no less despondent in Ray's depiction of him (Seton, 1971). At the epiphanic moment, when Amal has some sort of realization, Ray shows us a shot Amal, then of Charu. The camera is positioned as though over Amal's shoulder. We the viewers are, as it were, seeing Charu through Amal's eyes. She appears at a distance, then disappears from our and Amal's view. Her glance had been cast in the direction of Amal, and she seemed—and in fact was—completely unaware of the calamity that Bhupati has so recently learned befell him. The simile of the traveler stepping off a mountain path into the ravine is completely missing in Ray's translation. Instead, Ray has Bhupati speak the words Tagore wrote to Amiya Chakravarty, about the earth receding from his feet (Chakravarty, 1966). Tagore meant to convey with that conceit the emotions he felt after Kadambari Devi's death. Ray has Bhupati use that same image to express Bhupati's feelings after learning that Charu's brother has deceived him. The nature of that verbal image is, of course, comparable to the epiphanic extended simile in Tagore's short story. The verbal message, spoken by Bhupati, is not lost on Amal. The facial expression of Soumitra Chatterjee, the actor, conveys all that need to know of Amal's state of mind and, in fact, maybe more than Tagore's words can say. Like Tagore's original, Ray's translation has Amal appear but briefly after this, even more briefly than Tagore allows him to stay. Amal then vanishes during the rest of the film, except for his voice reading his own (Seely, 2000).

When Charu's story is published in a literary magazine, much to Amal's awe and amazement, the bond between her and Amal strengthens into mutual admiration; that is, until Amal begins to feel uncomfortable. Blind to all but his own ideals, Bhupati is left to weather the fate of his business and his marriage. *Charulata's* storyline weave and tighten all the way to its

final seconds when Ray brings it to an abrupt and startling halt. In conveying in filmic terms Tagore's closing message that Charu and Bhupati's marriage is suspended forever in doubt, he brilliantly opts for a series of tableaus (Lago & Sen, 1971). The music, rising in crescendo, is strangled. The figures of Charu and Bhupati stand frozen across a series of still frames with the aggrieved Bhupati returning home and with Charu reaching out pleadingly to usher him back into the household and into the marriage. He, tentatively, appears to want to take it. But, in spite of the lamp a servant is bringing, the corridor—the home, at large—looks haunted now by the spectre of marital discord. The appearance of the title, "The Broken Nest" ("Nastanirh") in Charulata's final shot underscores this and fills the screen. It's Tagore's original title for the story and, by placing it at the film's end; Ray shrewdly endows it with a portentous quality (Antani, 2004). It was ray's cinematic answer to Tagore's original ending.

Though Ray's film has its share of dialog, and very good dialog at that, his translation style relies heavy on the wordless scene. The frozen quality of the stills conveys well the emotional state of their relationship, cold and unmoving, but with the possibility of a thaw (Robinson, 1990). Tagore's conclusion to his short story is much more definitive in its meaning. Bhupati is going to leave Charu and Calcutta itself for parts south. Charu, in a panic, asks to be taken along. Bhupati at first says no. Charu pleads with him. He relents and invites her to come. And she, in a callous and casual and concluding remark says simply, "*thak,*" meaning "no, let things stay as they are, I'll not go." The ending in Ray's translation is dramatic and in a way more ambiguous, less conclusive. Even he admits to not being sure exactly what the still shots convey, though the ending seemed somehow right to him. According to him, Tagore's way of ending with a word of dialog would have been wrong for his translation into film. He termed it as, "really crucial moments in a film should be wordless"(qtd. in Robinson, 1990).

Even while celebrating motion on a swing in her garden, Charu is never entirely mobile. The creaking of the branches as the ropes stretch against them is much too real. Having briefly taken flight, the bird must return to her broken nest. In search of an equally meaningful cinematic resolution, Ray terminates his film with a striking freeze, reminiscent of Truffaut's *Les Quatre Cents Coups* (1959). Charu and Bhupati stand captured in an inescapable moment of stasis, their hands outstretched towards each other in quiet recognition (Chaudhuri, 2004). A script (written by Ray) that delicately turns and builds on itself, music (composed by Ray), layered in motifs across the film, and, of course, Subrata Mitra's heaven-lit cinematography, the film becomes a profoundly enriching experience. Though *Charulata* has been obscured in the Ray canon by a certain trilogy made at the outset of his career, it remains a singularly accomplished song to love, idealism, heartbreak and disillusionment (Antani, 2004).

Cinematic Spectacle of *Chokher Bali*

The early part of the twentieth century was a period of upheaval and unrest in the Indian subcontinent. Politically, Bengal was particularly vulnerable: it was facing partition by India's British rulers even as societal and family values tugged and pulled at the heartstrings. Rabindranath Tagore—keenly observant and mature in his early forties—was at a creative high. Quick to sense the restlessness and changes, he penned a series of short stories and novels, including *Chokher Bali*, *Nashtaneer* and *Gharey Bairey*, which portrayed a new discord brewing within the family and society at large as its characters were pitched against an impending political unrest (Aishwarya's screen presence and passion play, 2003). Tagore elaborately records early 20th century Bengali society through his central character, the rebellious widow, who wants to live a life of her own. In writing this novel he exposes the custom of

perpetual mourning on the part of widows, who were not allowed to remarry and were condemned to a life of seclusion and loneliness. It is a melancholy, stirring tale of the deceit and sorrow that arise from dissatisfaction and sorrow. Tagore has said about the novel, "I have always regretted the ending." (Chokher Bali, Critical acclaim, n.d.)

Based on a novel by Tagore, published in 1906, and filmed once before in 1938, it was set in Bengal at the beginning of the 20th century, a time of change. The state is threatened and there are political, social and philosophical debates in the air. The position of women is one of these subjects: *Chokher Bali* explores, in a claustrophobic, often languorous fashion, the fate of a spirited, singular woman who chafes against constraints (Hawker, 2005). Chokher Bali: A Grain of Sand is Tagore's classic exposition of an extramarital affair that takes place within the confines of a joint family. On the one hand, Chokher Bali: A Grain of Sand is a sensational account of two illicit relationships: Mahendra's infatuation with Binodini which blinds him to everything else, and Binodini's secret passion for Behari of which she is never able to speak of. On the other hand, it is a complex tapestry woven by the emotional interplay between five finely etched characters: the impulsive Mahendra, his adoring mother Rajlakshmi, the frail and sensitive Asha, the strong, silent Behari, and the self-willed and irresistibly attractive Binodini. A compelling portrayal of the complexity of relationships and of human character, this landmark novel is just as powerful and thought-provoking today as it was a hundred years ago, when it was written (*Chokher Bali*–A Grain of Sand, n. d.).

Set in the 1900's, director Rituparno Ghosh illustrates Tagore's characters beautifully on screen in this dramatic and luscious tale of deception and relationship manipulation. We are introduced to Binodini (Aishwarya Rai) who becomes a widow within a year of her marriage. Binodini is an educated and liberated woman - who refuses to conform to her expected widow status—something completely taboo in that era. The admirable part about Tagore's story and Ghosh's direction is that despite her crafty schemes, we are empathetic for Binodini's behaviour and she doesn't come across as a clichéd negative character (*Chokher Bali*, Critical acclaim, n. d.). An attractive young widow in early-20th century Bengal stirs passions both literal and metaphorical in the film, a slow-burning, dialogue-driven but still highly cinematic drama lit by a radiant performance from Hindi megastar Aishwarya Rai. Running just short of three hours, the picture is a quantum leap for Bengali helmer Rituparno Ghosh, here revisiting his favorite theme of upper- and middle-class domestic dramas centered on women. Good-looking result, shot in ochrish colors and handsomely kitted out, snagged festival dates with its semi-arty approach, and even some niche theatrical business with careful handling and Rai's growing name appeal (Elley, n. d.).

Chokher Bali is a strong film that can be viewed as an illustration of several issues with *sensuality and its denial*: The film is about relationships and temptations, the film is a glimpse into Bengali society and their strong philosophies and the film is a portrayal of a widow who refuses to conform to her cultural forms and her ultimate fate. It's also a pleasure to witness no songs lip synched as this would only disturb the story's flow. However, the dubbing leaves much to be desired. The film is definitely offbeat and would only appeal to a niche audience due to its periodic settings and ideologies (Chokher Bali, Critical acclaim, n. d.). Film is based on a 1902 novel, known as "Binodini" in English, whose works were also filmed by the late Satyajit Ray ("Charulata," "Three Daughters," "The Home and the World"). Written just before the first partition of Bengal by the Brits in 1905, and long before the final one in 1947, Tagore's story focuses the story in a large Calcutta household. With the benefit of hindsight, Ghosh has stirred in a smidgen of political background (notably, the growing resistance to

British rule), and explicitly makes the young widow's social situation reflect that of the country as a whole. Opening reel packs in a lot of backstory that needed to be further simplified in the English subtitles (or with an explanatory caption) for non-Bengali viewers (Elley, n. d.).

Along with the onset of liberal tones came the inevitable: a breakdown of old customs and values leading to an upsurge of promiscuity and lascivious self-indulgence. Widow Remarriage, female education and the European missionary influence had a liberating effect. Passion in all forms found itself suddenly out of the closet. Rituparno Ghosh's film adaptation of Tagore's *Chokher Bali* dwells on such turn-of-the-century syndromes that seem to reshuffle human society and its beliefs nearly every hundred years, bringing forth a new social order with its new set of interpretations, morals and value systems (Aishwarya's screen presence and passion play, 2003). Ghosh sets the film between 1902 and 1905. In the film, the 1905 Partition of Bengal is the litmus that tests the troubled waters on the home front. By following the novel closely, Tagore and, to an extent, Ghosh, provide an excuse for Mahendra's slips and follies. But reality is often more complex than what meets the eye. In *Chokher Bali*, Binodini reads *Bishbriksha.* That is where all reference ends. In the film, the *Bishbriksha* reference is left unattended. Ghosh ends up structuring the complexities in the relationships through a different mode. Binodini actually orders a tree cut to allow air and light into Mahendra and Ashalata's richly furnished but dark and stuffy bedroom (Aishwarya's screen presence and passion play, 2003). The interplay of light and shade and the streak of the golden sunset glow that lights up Binodini and Ashalata are beautiful and, at the same time, a clever projection of the various hues and shades of the relationships. A scar in a conjugal relationship, however shortlived, runs deep enough to create future disharmony. All the characters are inconsistent in their dealings and thought patterns. Inconsistency is what the novel and the film deal with (Aishwarya's screen presence and passion play, 2003).

Chokher Bali is Binodini's novel. Binodini – a young, beautiful and charming widow and the grain of sand in Asha's eye. The novel revolves around Binodini, capturing her in all her avatars – as a hapless widow, as a gamine, as a seductress, and as a repentant woman. Tagore lends expression to her longings and fancies in immense detail, so much so that at some points the narrative becomes a tacit debate on love, longing, morality and relationships. And in doing so, he manages to make all to fall in love with her. Tagore's novel is as simple and as complicated as only a true exposition of love can be (Chokher Bali – A Grain of Sand, n. d.). Binodini is a complex character. Her complexities are more inborn than the result of her plight as a lonely young widow. Intelligent, moderately educated, and exceedingly beautiful, Binodini's sense of dignity and mental strength belie her age and social position. She is also an enchantress, a fatal attraction for all those who happen to come close to her. The director's choice of Aishwarya Rai as Binodini raised eyebrows while the film was being made. It will continue to do so as long as Binodini retains her intriguing appeal (Aishwarya's screen presence and passion play, 2003).

Binodini is an intriguing heroine and articulate but with a destructive edge. Towards the end of the film, she declares - spelling out, a little too obviously, that her three identities have enveloped her: she is defined and confined by being a widow, English-educated and a young woman. Other elements - her sensuality - are denied. The film is at its strongest when it creates the atmosphere of that repressed sensuality and the complicated byplays in the relationships between the main characters. It feels more heavy-handed when it deals with the consequences and aftermath of these developments, setting them against current events and debates (Hawker, 2005). Also, one does feel like questioning (this is more to do with Ghosh's dubbing instructions than Rai's portrayal) Binodini's English-speaking skills. A few years of training at home with an

English nun does not normally enable an Indian girl in the first decade of the last century — unexposed to Western society at large — to speak English with a perfect accent, stopping only to fumble with the word 'spleen' (Aishwarya's screen presence and passion play, 2003).

Intermission

Ghosh's special ability is his eye for detail and his research. He creates an unquestioned authenticity (with art director Bibi Roy's innate sense of aesthetics and history) in the film, which has been mainly shot indoors (with the ghats of Varanasi and the garden house picnic episodes the only exceptions). One might choose to relate to Satyajit Ray in both these episodes—the use of the opera glass and the swing at the picnic with Ray's *Charulata*, the barge and the ghats of Varanasi with *Aparajito* and *Joy Baba Felunath*—since Ghosh's obsession with Ray is well-known (Aishwarya's screen presence and passion play, 2003). The tea-making scene and the red jacket episode between Binodini and Ashalata are subtle hints at the artificial ostentatiousness in the relationships that the women of the household share with each other. Binodini's control over Ashalata and her love life have been finely portrayed. Perhaps Ghosh was thinking of a larger, uninitiated audience who would fully appreciate the pains of a young widow only through strong visuals (Aishwarya's screen presence and passion play, 2003). The house that Binodini enters seems consumed by the languor and hedonism of Ashalata's and Mahendra's relationship: writer-director Rituparno Ghosh sets up elaborate tableaus and luxuriant images that emphasise the texture and colour of fabric, skin, and hair. There might be strict rules regulating women's desire (forbidding widows to remarry) but there are still ways to express sensuality in the culture. There's a self-conscious pleasure in play and performance, in the act of being observed, that the two ladies engage in. Although Binodini is the central character and Rai makes her an alluring, mercurial figure, Sen gives Ashalata a touching quality (Hawker, 2005).

The magic of Rai's performance lies in her underplaying of Binodini's ambition to divide and conquer the household, while always playing the dutiful widow. In other hands and with less subtle helming, the role could have devolved into pure, vampish melodrama; in Rai's graceful playing in the early stages, the viewer is never quite sure whether she's a very clever gold-digger or a genuinely devout and charitable young woman. Through the three hours, Ghosh keeps the melodrama well battened down in the slightly stylized performances. Abhik Mukherjee, also open up the picture in the last hour. Only at the final fence does the picture stumble, with an epilogue that unnecessarily joins the dots between Binodini's situation and Bengal's colonial history: Till then, the political turmoil outside the household has been referred to only in fleeting references. Though Rai dominates the film with her delicately sensual presence and physical grace, she's surrounded by some well-cast players. Chakrabarti is splendid as the grumpy old materfamilias. Sen touching as the simple-hearted Ashalata, and Chatterjee believable as the weak, Westernized Mahendra. The friendship between the two men is less convincing, with Raychaudhuri more of a cutout as the politicized Behari (Elley, n. d.).

Debajyoti Mishra's background score is a big draw. His choice of song sequences from Tagore's musical *Mayar Khela* enhances the film's appeal and essence as a play of passions and a game of enchantment and definitely not as one of a freedom struggle for oppressed women. The inherent storyteller is Rituparno Ghosh has successfully transcended the bounds of a period piece to make credible interpretations and universal statements (Aishwarya's screen presence and passion play, 2003). Production design and costuming are aces, and not allowed to overwhelm the picture, thanks to the muted, ochrish lensing. Detailed soundtrack of external

street noise also prevents the household scenes from becoming too claustrophobic. "Chokher Bali" is a picture that goes the distance and repays patience, so long as early problems of clarity can be fixed (Elley, n. d.).

Those expecting *Chokher Bali* to be an extension of Sanjay Leela Bhansali's *Devdas* are in for a disappointment warns the director of acclaimed films. Rituparno Ghosh is equally wary of being compared with Ray. Ghosh doubts if his film's literary antecedents will click with the average Hindi moviegoer in Mumbai. "I don't think *Chokher Bali* is meant for him". He remarked: "The Bengali audience expects it to be a renewal of Satyajit Ray's renderings of Tagore's novels *Charulata* and *Ghaire Bhaire*… The national audience would connect Aishwarya's presence in Bengali literature with *Devdas***.** But my film has little to do with *Devdas* or *Charulata***.** Every period creates its own glamour and nostalgia. The same is true of cinema" (Ash will be remembered in Chokher Bali, 2003). Making Chokher Bali has been a dream comes true for Ghosh. The maker has left no stone unturned to ensure that this period drama stays true to its essence. "I am personally taking care of every department. *Chokher Bali* needs extra caution. This is my first period film, therefore totally alien to me. Even the incidental hawker on the street has to speak and walk correctly."Ghosh fondly concludes, "A lot of people are waiting for her [*Aishwarya*] to fail. In my opinion, Ash has not only given one of her finest performances but also one of the best in cinema. She will be remembered in *Chokher Bali* not only because she is Aishwarya Rai but also because she has become Tagore's Binodini" (Ash will be remembered in Chokher Bali, 2003).

Some changes were made when the novel was adapted to the screen, the director said at a crowded press conference in New Delhi. "I have given the film a backdrop of nationalism, a sense of creeping rebellion which runs parallel to the journey of the woman protagonist," he said. Aishwarya, who plays Binodini, a young widow who falls in love with her best friend's husband, said there could not have been a better combination for her first Bengali film. "This was the best combination I could have hoped for — Rituparno as the director, Tagore's novel and Binodini as the character."The director helped me step into the character easily despite the language barrier. Had the two been playing contemporary characters, he would have allowed them to dub for themselves, Ghosh added. "Binodoni is very special to me as it is one of the deepest characters I have essayed till now," Aishwarya said. The film, shot in 40 days flat with a budget of Rs 2 crores, is about the marginalised sections of society, women in general and widows in particular, Ghosh said (Why Ash loves Binodini, 2003). .He says that Rai's presence in *Chokher Bali* helped hugely during negotiations for overseas distribution. Rai has high-profile visibility and everyone who is anyone in the global film world knows who she is. After all, she is a former Miss World, a jury member at Cannes and a brand ambassador for several multi-national companies.

The film was later dubbed into Hindi and was released internationally under that language. Upon release, *Chokher Bali* met with positive critical and box office reception (Alluring Ash, 2003; Bollywood News | Hindi Movies News | Celebrity News, 2012; Bengali films zoom in on profits, 2004) .Other titles are Choker Bali: A Passion Play (International: English title), Sand in the Eye (India: English title), Binodini (India: English title). The film contains no playback singing. Sreela Majumdar dubbed for Aishwarya Rai in this Bengali film and *Sudipta Chakraborty* dubbed for Raima Sen. In old days in Bengal, women and girls who were best friends would often set a common nickname for themselves and address each other by that name. In this story, two friends Binodini and Ashalata call each other 'Chokher Bali.' Aishwarya has given one of her finest performances and one of the best in cinema (*Ash will be remembered*

in Chokher Bali, 2003; Aishwarya's screen presence and passion play, 2003; Chokher Bali will widen my horizon, 2003; A director's film, 2003) .

Notes

Awards (Charulata) : Charulata was rejected from the 1965 Cannes Film Festival (Berlinale, 1965), but won Ray his second Silver Bear for Best Director in a row at the 15th Berlin International Film Festival in 1965 (The Telegraph, 2005). Charulata also won the Golden Lotus Award for Best Film at the National Film Awards in 1965, President's Gold Medal, New Delhi, 1964, Catholic Award, Berlin, 1965 and Best Film, Acapulco, 1965.

Awards (Chokher Bali) : Chokher Bali won the National Film Award for Best Feature Film in Bengali and was nominated for the Golden Leopard (Best Film) award at the Locarno International Film Festival in 2003. The film screened at the 34th International Film Festival of India on October 19, 2003 (Why Ash loves Binodini, 2003). It was the Official Selection at the Chicago International Film Festival in 2003 and was showcased in over 25 international festivals including the Toronto International Film Festival (The Toronto Film Festival, 2003), London Film Festival, Palm Springs, Karlovy Vary and Washington DC International Film Festival besides winning the Apsara Film Producers' Award for the Best Regional Film 2004.

Charulata and *Chokher Bali* were the two movies who had an immense storyline, extremely well woven by Tagore, poignant direction by Ray and Ghosh and justified feminine reflection by Madhabi and Aishwarya. The writer, the two directors and the actors are both of nationally and internationally acclaimed statures. The world of cinema will definitely remember these two stories as well as the two movies for a long period.

References

"A director's film," (2003). The Hindu. (Chennai, India). www.thehindu.com. Retrieved on November 16, 2003.

"Aishwarya's screen presence and passion play", (2003). Retrieved from http://in.rediff.com/movies/2003/oct/07chokher.htm on November 11, 2011.Top of Form

"Alluring Ash," (2003). The Hindu, (Chennai, India). www.thehindu.com. Retrieved on November 13, 2003.

Antani, Jay.. (2004). Charulata, *Slant Magazine,* Retrieved from http://www.slantmagazine.com/film/review/charulata/996 on December 13, 2011.

"Ash will be remembered in Chokher Bali", (2003). Retrieved from http://sports.rediff.com/movies/2003/may/05ritu.htm on January 22, 2012.

Bandyopadhyay, Samik. Ed., (1993). *Indian Cinema, Contemporary Perceptions from the Thirties*. Jamshedpur, India, Celluloid Chapter.

"Bengali films zoom in on profits," (2004). Rediff.com. Retrieved on July 8, 2012.

"Berlinale Prize Winners". (1965). *berlinale.de*. Retrieved on February 20, 2010.

Biswas, Moinak. n. d., *Writing on the Screen: Satyajit Ray's Adaptation of Tagore*, Jadavpur University, Calcuttá, Índia, Retrieved from http://www.ipv.pt/forumedia/5/9.htm on. Februaury 23, 2012.

"Bollywood News, Hindi Movies News, Celebrity News," (2008). BollywoodHungama.com. Retrieved on July 8, 2012.

Chakravarty, Amiya. (1966). First published in the volume called *The Fugitive and Other Poems* by Macmillan, and subsequently included in *A Tagore Reader*, ed., Boston, Beacon, pp. 331, 332.

"Charulata, The Lonely Wife," (1965), Retrieved from http://www.satyajitray.org/films/charu.htm on March 10, 2012.

Chaudhuri, Neel. (2004). *Charulata*: *The Intimacies of a Broken Nest*, Senses of Cinema. Retrieved on May 31, 2011. Retrieved from http://sensesofcinema.com/2004/cteq/charulata/

"Chokher Bali – A Grain of Sand," n. d., Retrieved from http://thebookbook.blogspot.in/2007/11/chokher-bali-grain-of-sand.html on April 15, 2012.

"Chokher Bali, Critical acclaim", n. d., Retrieved from http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Chokher_Bali on May 01, 2012.

"Chokher Bali will widen my horizon," (2003), The Times of India. www.thetimesofindia.com, Retrieved on June 6, 2003.

Dutta, Krishna. & Lago, Mary. (Trans.), (1992). Rabindranath Tagore 'The Broken Nest', in *Selected Short Stories,* Calcutta, India, Rupa & Co.

Elley, Derek. n. d., *Chokher Bali: A Passion Play*, Retrieved From http://www.variety.com/review/VE1117921521?refcatid=31 on June 19, 2012.

Ghosh, Debiprasad. ed. (1990). *Bangla Bhashay Chalachhitra Charcha 1923-33*. Calcutta, India, Cine Club of Calcutta.

Hawker, Philippa. (2005). *Chokher Bali*, Retrieved from http://www.theage.com.au/news/Reviews/ChokherBali/2005/06/15/1118645865285.html on August 22, 2012.

Lago, Mary M. & Sen, Supriya. (Trans.), (1971). Rabindranath Tagore, The Broken Nest (nashtanir), Columbia, MO: University of Missouri Press, p. 59.

Nyce, Ben. (1988). *Satyajit Ray: A Study of His Films*, Praeger, New York and London, n. p. p. 94.

Ray, Satyajit. (1982). *Bishay Chalachchitra*. Calcutta, India, Ananda Publishers Private Limited.

Ray, Satyajit. (1976). *Our Films, Their Films*, New Delhi, India, Orient Longman, p. 57.

Robinson, Arthur. (1989). *Satyajit Ray: The Inner Eye*. Los Angeles: University of California Press. (London, Andre Deutsch, 1989; Calcutta, Allahabad, Bombay, New Delhi: Rupa, 1990), pp. 157, 159, 160, 161, 162, 164, 169.

Rudra, Ashok. (1996). *Shilpir Swadhinata*, Subrata ed. (1996). *Satyajit, Jiban ar Shilpa*. Calcutta, India, Pratibhash.

Seely, Clinton B. (2000). *Translating Between Media: Rabindranath Tagore and Satyajit Ray*, Keynote Address Delivered at the Twelveth Annual Tagore Festival, University of Illinois, Champaign – Urbana, IL. Retrived from http://www.parabaas.com/rabindranath/articles/pClinton1.html on September 29, 2012.

Seton, Portrait. (1971). Bloomington, IN and London, Indiana University Press, p. 180.

"The Telegraph - Calcutta: Nation," (2005). Telegraphindia.com. Retrieved on May 31, 2011.

"The Toronto Film Festival," (2003). www.times.com. Retrieved on October 10, 2012.

"Why Ash loves Binodini," (2003), Retrieved from http://www.rediff.com/movies/2003/oct/20ash.htm on October 31, 2012.

Maumita Chaudhuri is Assistant Professor in the Department of Journalism & Mass Communication at Barrackpore Rastraguru Surendranath College, 6 Riverside Road, Barrackpore, North 24 Parganas, Kolkata, West Bengal-700 120. E-mail: *chaudhuri.maumita@gmail.com.*

© *Media Watch* 4 (1) 52- 66, 2013
ISSN 0976-0911 e-ISSN 2249-8818

Globalization of Bollywood: Gain of Markets or Loss of Audiences?

MIRA K DESAI
SNDT Women's University, Mumbai, India

Films are one of the oldest medium of entertainment. Human civilization has witnessed sea change in film creation-production-distribution-consumption processes in last few decades. This paper examines the question whether globalization of Bollywood has taken place in terms of markets as well as audiences, the forms and shapes of the process of globalization and if the process has led to gain of markets and/or loss of audiences. It uses an Indian cinema-hall-going audience survey, content of Bollywood productions and Box office figures across markets to argue that the process of globalization of Bollywood has neither lead to gain of markets nor loss of audiences. It is an inevitable development creating hypo-real markets whereas audiences connect only to culturally proximate contents. Analysis indicates that while on one hand Bollywood films creating 'global' markets, it is losing 'local' audiences.

Keywords: Globalization, Bollywood, Indian cinema, market and audience survey

The late 20th century was characterized by liberalization, privatization and globalization. This meant reducing role of state, increasing influence of private sector and collapsing of geo-political and socio-cultural boundaries. Role of television and internet in fueling such processes was immense. The 'global village' became 'reality' and so are the shifts in the ways human beings across the world communicated, spent time and entertained themselves.

Films, one of the oldest medium of entertainment underwent changes due to processes of globalization. Bollywood, film industry based in Mumbai, India which produces films in Hindi language, was no exception to this development. Conception, production, distribution and consumption of films witnessed sea-change in the last two decades due to satellite television, advent of internet and digital technologies. Films targeted to diasporas, global distribution, world television premiers, internet releases of the films are becoming regular features and the multiplexes have created newer audiences. The film markets became global but that may or may not mean global audiences. Markets refer to mainly economic conception targeting 'possible consumers' of the 'product' whereas audiences are socio-cultural and to an extent political concept. As evident consumers as well as audiences have association with the 'text' i.e. film content and producers/creators of the films have 'perceived' 'receivers' when they conceive/ create a film. And for obvious reasons the 'text' of the film would reflect 'idea of the receiver' as constructed by the film production teams in general and director of the film in particular.

Correspondence to: Mira K Desai, Associate Professor, University Department of Extension Education, SNDT Women's University, Juhu Campus, Mumbai-400 049, India. E-mail: *drmiradesai@gmail.com*

Three data sources have been examined. Firstly, audience survey findings, secondly, content assessment of few selected Bollywood productions over the last decade and thirdly, box office successes of Indian, overseas as well as within Indian territories of last decade have been used to draw conclusions. The main objective is to triangulate 'globalisation' (elements of global culture) in Bollywood film texts, Mumbai Cinema-hall going audience preferences and box-office figures as indicative of markets for Bollywood films. There are mainly three research questions: if Bollywood text were 'global,' historically or is a recent phenomenon; secondly, why do audiences go to cinema halls for Bollywood films and thirdly, what have been the global and local box-office trends for Bollywood films.

Globalisation and Bollywood

Globalisation as well as Bollywood has been matter of much academic and political discourse. Here, globalization refers to compression of time and space, interaction of global-local, cultural commodification and rise of newer markets. Bollywood refers to films made in Hindi or Bombay cinema. Process of globalization of Bollywood can be examined at various levels. It could be film content, visual texts, production alliances, distribution processes, overseas revenues, diasporic audiences and so on. Post-2000 globalization of Bollywood reflected in many aspects of productions ranging from filming locations, international cast, global storylines, newer marketing strategies, international distribution agreements to diverse consumption avenues. Bollywood witnessed two diverse trends in last decade or so. Rise of films with modest budgets, no big stars, and very local stories doing fairly well at the box office contrary to much publicized, large productions with international collaborations failing at the box office.

It has been accepted by scholars as well as industry that Bollywood had, since its inception, been influenced by global markets (Ernst and Young & FICCI 2007; Karan & Schaefer 2009). Early Bollywood production of Hindu mythology *Raja Harishchandra* by Dada Saheb Phalke in 1913 which was a silent film became possible because of imported British technology. Numerous films including the song "*Mera joota hai japani, patloon Englishtani, Sar Pe Lal Topi fir bhi dil hai Hindustani"* (My shoes are Japanese, these trousers are English, the red hat on my head is Russian, but even so, my heart is Indian) in film *Shree 420* in 1955 by legendry Raj Kapoor to Bengali films by Satyajit Ray in fifties portrayed attracted global audiences.

The pace and presentation in Nineties was overwhelming. In 1994 *Hum Aapke Hain Kaun* (1994) with two weddings and a funeral was full of ceremonies and 14 songs, appealed to non-resident India sensibilities and raised an estimated USD3.5 million in business overseas. The next big success, *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge* (1995), became a cult film for diasporic audiences in the US, the UK and the Middle East. Capturing the cultural gap between first and second generation Indians settled overseas, it grossed about USD 4 million at the overseas box office. The film also led to formula films about balancing of modern and traditional values in subsequent overseas successes. *Dil To Pagal Hain (1997), Kuch Kuch Hota Hain (1998), Taal (1999), Kabhie Kushie Kabhie Gham (2001), Kal Ho Na Ho (2003),* are in many ways, a continuation of the same theme. Contrary to that Sony Pictures releasing of India (part of Columbia Tristar) produced the Hindi film *Saawariya* (2007) which did miserably at the Indian box office. Walt Disney and *Yash Raj Films* joint animation production venture to make film like *Roadside Romeo* (2008) sank at the box office. There were collaborations like *The Namesake* (2007) directed by Mira Nair is a Hollywood film produced by UTV Motion Pictures in collaboration with Hollywood's Fox Searchlight and the Japanese company Entertainment Farm.

Ernst & Young and FICCI (2007: 4) report remarks that Indian films are screened in 110 countries as varied as Peru, the US, the UK, Malaysia and Australia. The report titled "Indian content on Move" by Ernst & Young & FICCI (2007:4) identified three clusters of Indian content catering to three segments of audiences. First purely Indian content – one that features the trademark colorful scenes, song, dance and drama; made by Indians exported mainly to non-resident Indians. Secondly, Indian-themed featuring rich Indian mythology, culture, and characters based in India seeking global audiences; and the next is markets with supply deficiency of local programming with high programming costs compared with the size of the local audience acting as a deterrent to local production where genres like animation content or kids programming content has a huge demand for fresh programming in West Asia, Eastern Europe and other such markets.

Karan and Schaefer (2009) found strong empirical evidence that filmmakers have utilized hybridized indigenous/glocalized and exogenous/globalized content in Hindi films to positively impact box office returns, and that this trend is accelerating in the global era. Ernst & Young & FICCI (2007: 6) report notes evidences of many large Indian film and television companies having huge profits in the UK, the US, Canada and the Middle East; whereas Japan, Korea, Singapore, Russia, China, Poland, Germany, and Spain are perceived as key emerging markets.

Indian film companies have gone global in acquiring funds as well as fiscal incentives for shooting and other activities abroad. The globalization of consumption is facilitated through new forms of distribution and exhibition (satellite TV, DVD, internet) and the possibility of reaching out to niche audiences across the globe. In December 2000, the Joint Institutional Committee on Financing Entertainment Industry headed by the Department of Banking,Ministry of Finance laid down certain guidelines for offering financial assistance to the film industry. This happened at the time when certain producers (Mukta Arts, TIPS Industries and Pritish Nandy Communications) made their companies public thereby obtaining access to public money to support film production.

In 2006, Eros International, one of the India's largest film distributing company, listed in London's Alternative Investment Market (AIM). In 2007, overseas entertainment earnings were made tax free by the Indian government encouraging media firms to step up distribution arms in foreign markets. This resulted to overseas ventures started by Yash Raj Films followed by several others like Reliance–Adlabs and UTV that established their distribution arms overseas. Sundaram (2005: 57) notes that the most aggressive in global distribution, Yash-Raj Films and production company, with simultaneous releases in diaspora-linked multiplexes worldwide and extravagant high budget family films include lucrative international distribution contracts, Bollywood-themed events, stage shows, and brand promotions.

Audiences and the Markets

Audiences here refer to socio-cultural construct, mainly viewers of the Hindi films in cinema halls. This paper uses box-office collections as indicative of 'market'. It is assumed that markets can be created or expanded whereas audiences are socio-culturally situated having their own history and context. Audiences and markets cannot be used as synonymous because there might be audiences but the market may not be substantial enough as expected by the industry. Markets are also most often 'geographical' based on revenues whereas 'audiences' are 'socially situated in a given culture' associated for gratification and are constituted through the 'text'. Most often markets evolve, audiences usually have defined tastes but their tastes evolve socio-

culturally. While market can be perishable, audiences may remain with the products for life. Old Hindi film songs are classic example which still finds 'audiences' and created 'market' in form of variety of '*Antakshari*' on Indian television.

Audience reception researches over the years have clearly showed that texts are polysemic and there is a multiplicity in reading of media text. Meanings are created through the interaction between audiences and media texts within contexts, where audiences bring in their experiences and knowledge in the act of interpretation.

The Indian media reports, in 2011 that the legendry filmmaker Raj Kapoor's granddaughter, Kareena Kapoor when she visited Russia, received overwhelming response for being Raj Kapoor's granddaughter, suggest an act of contextuality by Russian audiences. Based on ethnography of audiences in Punjab, India, Rao (2007: 73) remarks, "Bollywood films attempt to connect to the diasporic audiences and focus on the 'audience as consumer' in urban and metropolitan areas, they are leaving other economically and culturally marginalized audiences behind". Dudrah (2006) cites examples of mobile messages with Bollywood film names and film music productions between India and UK as ways in which Bollywood films have become part of the diasporic South Asian popular culture.

Film market players are producers, distributors, exhibitors and ticket buyers (audiences in the context of this paper). As per the Ernst and Young report (2004), there are approximate 400 film production houses/producers in India, only about 32 are registered as corporate entities. Ticket prices in markets such as the UK and the US are 10 times those in India and a cable subscription in those countries costs six times the average it does in India. Ernst & Young & FICCI (2007: 6) report stated that the Indian films bring one-fifth of revenue from overseas markets. Interestingly based on the processes, KPMG-FICCI (2011:55) report notes that the revenue in 2009 and 2010 from overseas theatrical was only eight per cent indicating reduction of overseas markets for Bollywood films.

Local and Global Markets

Boxofficeindia.com notes about the business of Bollywood in India. The distributor earn from the net gross minus theatre rentals. Markets are more interested to distributor shares to estimate profitability. The theatre rentals differ depending upon the type of the theatre. Multiplexes give 50% in week one, 42.5 per cent in week two, 37.5 per cent in week three and 30 per cent thereafter to the distributor. Single screens are mainly on rental for big films so if a film generates big collections then 80 per cent or even 90 per cent of that income goes to the distributor. Smaller films find it hard to get a release at single screens, as exhibitors know that the film may even struggle to collect the theatre rental. So single screens exhibitors are very particular when it comes to showing a smaller film at their theatre and for the big films it is the other way round. Films like *Ghajini*, *Wanted*, *Raajneeti* and *Dabangg* have proved that if a film works at single screens, a producer can recover a big chunk or perhaps the entire investment from single screens itself in a way making multiplex revenues redundant. The 240 multiplex cinemas in India, which cater to the middle classes and sell tickets for as much as INR 400 (approx 8 USD) account for only a tiny portion of the screens in the country but generate about two thirds of the cinema industry's sales. Some estimates suggest that nine out of ten multiplexes, many of which are in expensive inner-city locations, are making a loss as they battle to service the debts that financed their construction and their expensive rents. Multiplexes quoted rising costs in power and wage bills, high price of land, diminishing audiences (two out of three films failing to fill the small hall even in the first week), to seek a higher percentage in profit. Producers said no, and they had their own reasons.

Unlike the local reality, Dudrah (2006: 108) notes about Loews theatre at Times Square, New York which is a discount multiplex with mainstream Hollywood film advertised at 4.95 USD but ticket for each Bollywood showing is 10 USD. Loews hires the prints of films for a one-off fees and therefore the price is double than at other theatres in US. But when it comes to the Indian film industry, at USD2 billion, is a fraction of Hollywood (Ernst & Young & FICCI, 2007). UTV Motion Pictures went on to the record that unpredictability of overseas operations acts as a strong deterrent for producers and distributors and UTV's distribution networks exist primarily in 'tried and tested' regions. Chitrapu (2010) noted that in spite of glowing reports in the popular press, Indian films earned only 1 per cent of global film revenues. In UK, despite press reports of the Indian films having tremendous opening weekends, the total theatrical revenue earned by the 62 Indian films which entered the charts of the top 200 films in the UK in 2007 was only approximately US$ 29 million or 2 per cent of the total theatrical revenues earned by the top 200 films in the UK that year. In 2007, in the UK, 14 out of the top 20 foreign films were Indian. These were part of a total of 69 Indian films that constituted 13.7 per cent of all releases. These films accounted for only 1.8 per cent of the total UK box office revenues in the said year. The largest film companies range between USD7 million to 50 million in revenue. None makes it to any listing of top 100 companies in India.

Cinema-Hall going Audience Survey

The author had set out to examine film viewing behaviour and preferences of cinema-hall-goers in Mumbai on an insistence of a small-budget filmmaker. Behavior referred to liking, language and genre choices and reasons for opting for a particular film in a cinema hall by the cinema-hall goer. In all 12 postgraduate students visited eight theatres on three weekend days during 9th to 11th February 2003. The theatres were selected purposively from Mumbai city and suburban areas. Eight theatres were multiplexes (Fame Adlabs, G7, Imax, Cinemax) as well as single screens (Eros, Metro, Regal, New Excelsior). The data was collected on Friday from 5Pm to 8Pm, Saturday from 11Am to 4Pm and on Sunday from 12Pm to 9Pm. The students waited outside the cinema hall and approached people entering to watch the film or exiting after the film. Cinema-hall-goers, incidental samples of the survey, were ready to respond prior to watching the film in place of towards the end of the film. Though the study was carried out as a commissioned study for a client to decide a film release strategy, it lends evidence to some of the popular notions about preferences to cinema-going in urban India.

Sample : Total 400 people were interviewed covering 194 males and 206 females representing age groups below 21(30 per cent), 22 to 35 (54 per cent) and above 35 years (16 per cent) in the age range of 15 to 50 years. Their occupational profiles indicated students (34 per cent), business professionals (31 per cent), service people (25 per cent) and home-bound (10 per cent) individuals (homemakers, elderly). Majority of the cinema-hall-goers owned computers at home, had cable and satellite connections and even half of the surveyed population had VCR/VCP/VCD/DVD at home at the time of data collection.

Results : The survey confirmed that film viewing is a ritualistic activity for cinema-hall-goers in India. Except for one in ten, everyone watched films regularly and eight in ten, reported monthly viewership of films in cinema halls. One third of the audiences reported to be watching a film once or twice a week and most of them reported to be watching it in theatres. When asked about their last visit to the theatre, six of ten had watched it within a month whereas four in ten were less frequent to cinema halls.

'Time pass' and 'for fun' are the two reasons cited by equal proportion of cinema-hall-goers. Interestingly, one out of ten cinema-hall-goers labeled 'family and friends' as a reason for having come to watch a film and two out of ten watch films for relaxation. Five per cent people cited multiple reasons. Cinema-hall-goers were asked multiple questions so as to ascertain their film preferences. Their response were collated and tabulated as shown in Table 1.

Table 1. Differences in Film genre preferences of cinema-hall-goers of Mumbai

Type of Film	Film they had come to watch (N=395)	Films they usually like to watch (N=395)	Films Named as liked by them* (N=395)
Action/thrillers	200 (50.6%)	110 (27.8%)	118 (29.9%)
Love Story	134 (33.9%)	116 (29.4%)	157 (39.7%)
New wave	38 (9.6%)	4 (1.0%)	69 (17.5%)
Comedy	16 (4.1%)	11 (2.8%)	12 (3.0%)
Drama	5 (1.3%)	38 (9.6%)	23 (5.8%)
True story	-	102 (25.8%)	3 (0.8%)
Historical	-	7 (1.8%)	2 (0.5%)
Others	2 (0.5%)	7 (1.8%)	11 (2.8%)

* The cinema-hall-goers were asked to name film liked by them the most and was decoded to the film genre type.

Table 1 suggests that while half of the cinema-hall-goers had come to watch 'action/ thrillers', the most preferred category was 'love story' as reported by one-third of them. Even when 'new wave' films, made by experimental film makers/most often low budget films though were not named by them or liked by them but when they were asked to name films they liked, they referred to 'new wave' films. Also as clearly evident the responses of 'what cinema-hall-goers usually like to watch' and 'what they liked' varied as in the third and fourth columns of the Table 1. They 'usually' like to watch 'true stories' (one forth referred to it as preferred genre) but if one examines names of the films given by them it is not even a one per cent for it. Also such films did not get made could be the reason for explanation but the same holds true for 'historical' genre. Also the recent success of reality genre on television too gets explained by this finding.

Interestingly language of film viewing of cinema-hall-goers also confirms popularity of 'national language' Hindi amongst cinema-hall-goers and yet increasing preference to global language in form of Hindi and English. It needs to be kept in mind that the survey was carried out in Mumbai which is the most modern city and financial capital of India and in 2003 (at the time of the survey) transnational television had already began.

Figure 1 shows language preferences of cinema-hall-goers. Since survey was carried out in Mumbai, having a strong multi-lingual, multi-cultural character, preferences for other languages was not found very prominent. Half of the cinema-hall-goers watched 'only Hindi' films whereas four out of ten watched 'Hindi as well as English' films. Only English was only three percent whereas very small proportion watched regional and other language films.

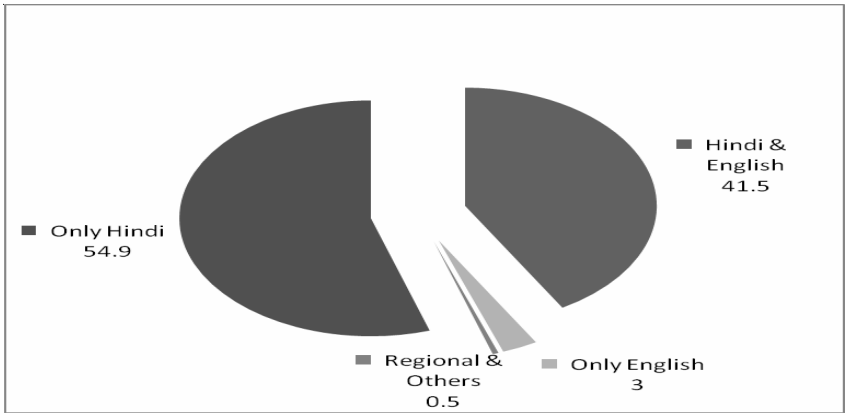


Figure 1. Preference for Language of film by cinema-hall-goers

Figure 2 indicates that one third of the cinema-hall-goers watched films 'only' in theatre whereas six out of ten cinema-hall-goers watched films wherever they can; instead of having a fixed preference. They watched films on television, on VCD/DVD or most often in theatre. Three out of ten cinema-hall-goers watching films only in theatres suggested association of films as 'outdoor media'. Proportion of cinema-hall-goers watching films 'indoors' (in house through VCD/DVD or on television) was limited as evident from the Figure 2.

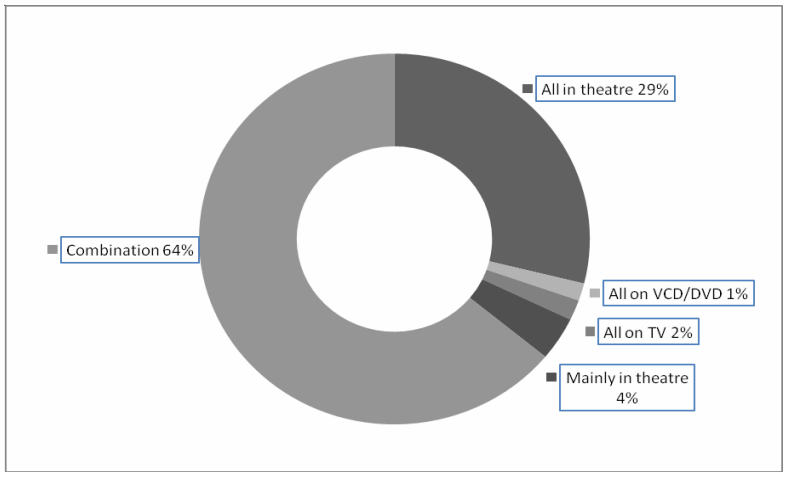


Figure 2. Place of film viewing by cinema-hall-goers

Table 2 presents tabulation of two sets of responses of cinema-hall-goers about factors impacting their choice of films. When they were asked 'how do they decide that they would watch a particular film', responses differed when examined compared with the responses to the question 'which film did they like the most and why'. While half of the cinema-hall-goers liked a film based on its 'story' they decide to watch a particular film either because of story or promos/trailers. One fifth of cinema-hall-goers gave importance to 'stars' (cast of the film) and reviews of the film had least importance as the film was already liked by the person because of the star. Other factors influencing liking for a film were locations, costumes, emotions and so on.

Table 2. Film genre preferences of cinema-hall-goers of Mumbai

Factors	Decision about film selection (N=395)	Reason for liking a film named by them (N=395)
Not fixed	5 (1.3 %)	21 (5.3%)
Producer/Banner	21 (5.3%)	4 (1.0%)
Trailer/Promos	94 (23.8%)	2 (0.6%)
Director	49 (12.4%)	24 (6.1%)
Story	95 (24.1%)	211 (53.4%)
Music	38 (9.6%)	15 (3.8%)
Hero/Heroine/Villain	62 (15.7%)	75 (19.0%)
Reviews	31 (7.8%)	-
Others	-	43 (10.9%)

* The cinema-hall-goers were asked factors for specific films liked by them.

Eight out of ten cinema-hall-goers responded that they recommend films to others. In order to understand interpersonal influence, cinema-hall-goers were asked proportion of people they thought listen to such recommendations. Out of those eight out of ten cinema-hall-goers, half stated that 'less than half' people get influenced by their recommendations.

Findings : In India recommendations, interpersonal viral, pushed viewing are common and the audience survey data clearly supported that films are viewed by Indian audiences as 'ritual' and is 'family and friend-centric' outdoor activity. The viewership, most often, since born out of 'ritual', does not have clear individual preferences for genre or decisive factor in making cinema-hall-goers visit theatre. Present research confirmed that cinema-hall-goers in India habitually watch films in theatres and recommend it to their friends and relatives. When it comes to making decision about which film to watch then cinema-hall-goers mainly depends upon promos and trailers but their preference for a particular film is based mainly on the 'story' and 'hero/ heroine/villain'. Though at the time of study half of the cinema-hall-goers had come to the theatre hall to watch 'action/thriller', the preferred genre was 'love story' and 'true story'.

Bollywood over the Years

This section discusses issues like foreign actors in Bollywood films, changing story lines, overseas locations, and foreign musicians in Bollywood films to explore if such globalization is a recent phenomenon or has been the process over the years.

Foreign actors in Bollywood : The 'fearless Nadia', an Australian from the Russian Circus popularly known as '*Hunterwal*' (The Lady with Hunter) in the 1930s acted in 50 Bollywood films. Bob Christo, also an Australian, was a successful villain in Bollywood films around in the 1970s even when Russian actress Kseniya Ryabinkina featured in Raj Kapoor's *Mera Naam Joker* (1970). Tom Alter, A second generation India-born American is part of Bollywood for last few decades but last decades witnessed many foreign actors in the Bollywood. Rachel Shelley, a British television actress, portrayed Elizabeth Russell in Ashutosh Gowarikar's *Lagaan* (2001) and Paul Blackthorne played her villainous and racist brother Captain Andrew Russell. Alice Patten, the actress daughter of British actor Chris Patten played an idealist filmmaker who arrives in Delhi to make a film on the basis of her late grandfather's diaries in Rang De Basanti (2006). Kalki Koechlin in Dev D (2009); Giselli Monteiro, Brazilian model and Florence

Brudenell-Bruce, British model in *Love Aaj Kal* (2009); Tania Zaetta, an Australian actress in *Salaam Namaste* (2005); South African beauty Ilene Hamann debuted in Pooja Bhatt's *Rog* (2005); Antonia Benath and Polly Adams from Britain in *Kisna*—the Warrior Poet (2005), Shannon Ezra in *Salaam-E-Ishq* (2007), Barbara Mori in Kites (2009), Kylie Minogue in *Blue*(2009), Toby Stephens, Hollywood actor in *Mangal Pandey* – The Rising (2005) are few of the examples. Today Indian actors making entry into Hollywood is also not a new story. The reasons and causes for such entry are not in the scope of the present paper but one can assume that since the stories are becoming global so are the faces.

Changing stories : In last one decade, there were divergent trends. On one hand, there were stories told for 'global' audiences whereas on the other, there were very very 'local' stories. Bollywood films by Karan Johar and Subhash Ghai took viewers overseas whereas there was localization by many others. Filmmakers like Vishal Bhradwaj, Anurag Kashyap, Anurag Basu, Nagesh Kukunoor, Habib Faizal, Milan Lutharia, Dibakar Banerjee, Sujoy Ghosh and many others contributed through films like *Hyderabad Blues* (1998), *Maqbool* (2003), Iqubal (2005), *Khosla ka Ghosla* (2006), *Bheja Fry* (2007), *Oye Lucky Oye* (2008), *Do Duni Chaar* (2010), *Dirty Pictures* (2011), *Kahani* (2012), *Ishaqjaade* (2012) and so on. New talents by established banners Mukta Searchlight productions, UTV motion pictures spot boy production, even Yash Raj and Vishal Bhardwaj Production Company brought in new formats in Indian cinema.

Vishal Bhardwaj, originally a music composer turned writer turned director turned producer debuted with children's film *Makdee* (2002) followed by two Shakespearean adaptations, *Maqbool* (2003) based on Macbeth and *Omkara* (2006) based on Othello besides another children's film, Ruskin Bond stories in *The Blue Umbrella* (2005) and *Saat Khoon Maaf* (2011). Bhardwaj represents Bollywood filmmaker who brought in 'global' content with 'Indian' adaptations contrary to filmmaker Frahan Akhtar. Farhan Akhtar (son of legendary film writer Javed Akhtar), responsible for bringing in Hollywood sensibilities in Bollywood with his films starting with *Dil Chata Hai* (2001), *Lakshya* (2004).

Foreign locations : In last decade many more Bollywood films got shot overseas, some appear more of tourism promotion products rather than film. *Kaho Naa Payar Hai* (2000) was shot in Thiland and New Zealand besides India. *Kal Ho Naa Ho* (There May Be a Tomorrow or Not) (2003), Hindi film set in New York City, was produced and co-written by Karan Johar. *Salaam Namaste* (2005) film directed by first-time director Sidharth Anand and produced by Yash Raj was the first Indian movie to be filmed entirely in Australia. In 2006*, Dhoom 2* became the first Bollywood film to be shot in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil. Eighty per cent of the *Don: The Chase Begins Again* (2006) was shot in Malaysia and its sequel *Don 2* released in December 2011 was shot in Berlin. *Kabhi Alvida Naa Kehna* (Never Say Good Bye) (2006) directed by Karan Johar and produced under the Dharma Productions released on 11 August 2006 in India and North America. *Dostana* (2008) was the first Bollywood film to be filmed entirely in Miami, United States. *Love Aaj Kal* (Love now and then) (2009) took the viewer through Punjab, Delhi, London, England, San Francisco, and Kolkatta.

Foreign musicians : When Oscar winning Indian music director A R Rahman has gone global, many foreign musicians entered the world of Bollywood song and dance. Unlike with many other Bollywood productions, filmmakers of *Kal Ho Naa Ho* (2003) complied with international copyright laws and obtained the license to use Roy Orbison's *'Oh, Pretty Woman'*

for an extended musical sequence taking place in the streets in New York. Vipul Shah produced *Singh is King* (2008) having title track composed by British Bhangra Band RDB (Rhythm Dhol Bass) and cameo by rapper Snoop Dogg, giving American attention to Bollywood film. Snoop Dogg's performance has been described as 'the first time that a mainstream American artist has performed on a Bollywood soundtrack' (Perry, 2008). The performance shot in Chicago showed the rapper wearing Punjabi shirt and a turban dancing alongside Bollywood actor Akshay Kumar. Morcom (2001) elaborates examples of Hollywood music in Bollywood citing examples of *Mother India* (1957), *Mughal-e-Azam* (1960), *Raja Hindustani* (1996) whereas inverse flows have yet to be studied. Indian musicians like A R Rahman gaining two Oscars and playing in Hollywood and British productions is one such example.

Overseas box office : *Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham* (2001) is the highest grossing Indian film in the overseas market until 2006. The film as it is known, climbed up to third place in the British box office within two weeks of release, and maintained its place for over three weeks. The film was also thought to have broken the American box office top 10, but this remains uncertain due to a lack of confirmed figures from the distributors. The film was the first Bollywood feature to see a theatrical release in Germany (with German subtitles, a dubbed version was produced). The second half of the film is set principally in London. Punathambekar (2005) did ethnographic detail and a thematic reading of the film. He found that the film articulates everyday struggles over being Indian in the US to a larger project of cultural citizenship that has emerged in relation to India's tentative entry into a transnational economy and the centrality of the NRI (non-resident Indian) figure in India's navigation of this space.

The film *Salam Namste* (2005) told story of two young and modern Indians, Nick and Ambar, who had left their homes in India to make a life on their own in Melbourne, Australia. The story of one year in their life, dealt with their problems and relationships, from their first meeting at a Western wedding ceremony, to their decision to move in together without marriage, to their breakup upon discovering that Ambar is pregnant, theme not socially acceptable in India. It attempted to give sanction to student populations abroad to negotiate with contrasting value orientations. *Don- The Chase Begins Again* (2006) starred Shah Rukh Khan, a remake of earlier *The Don* (1978) starring Amitabh Bachachan. The film begins with a close up of Euro currency note in its first frame. The visual clearly targeting the UK box office was made by Farhan Akhatar. In 2008, Bollywood actor Shah Rukh Khan was awarded the title of '*Datuk*', the equivalent of a Knighthood in Britain, by the Malaysian government which ran into controversy. *Kabhi Alvida Naa Kehna* (Never Say Good Bye) (2006) explored themes of adultery and extramarital affairs. Although its earnings in India waned at the box office after the first week of release, the film was a success internationally and in the United States it became the highest grossing Indian film of all time, beating Kabhi Khushi Kabhi Gham's five year old record. In the United States it grossed over USD1.3 million and USD1.4 million in the United Kingdom on its opening weekend and was screened in over 1,200 cinemas worldwide. *Namastey London* (Hello London) (2007) was a romantic comedy directed by Vipul Amrutlal Shah borrowed from the Manoj Kumar starrer *Purab Aur Paschim* (East and West) (1970) explored concept of Indians being born in foreign nations, forgetting their Indian roots, trying to become like people of that nation. The film made for Indian audiences abroad projecting controversial topics like public kissing and alcohol abuse. The film did better overseas than in India. *My Name Is Khan* (2010), was distributed by FOX Star Entertainment, which bought the rights for the film for a sum of INR 1 billion, thus becoming the most expensive Bollywood film

of 2010. It is also the highest buy over for any Indian film, breaking *Ghajini* (2008) record of INR 900 million. It released globally in cinemas in February 2010. Upon release, the film broke many box office records, and became the highest grossing Bollywood film overseas. Star Plus is said to have paid approximately INR 15 crore for the satellite television rights of the film, highest for any Bollywood film.

The above elaboration clearly reveals that globalization of Bollywood is not a recent phenomenon as foreign actors and Hollywood music in Bollywood existed historically. But stories have been changing as Bollywood is now approaching overseas box office with stories that attract 'foreign' market. Lot of such films did not work commercially in Indian markets as the values and experiences were not 'local'. But markets are getting expanded either for creating audiences or for catering to the existing audiences. Music, costumes, Bollywood themed parties and weddings are becoming global fashion.

Indian Box Office and Audience : In this section films' market success based on Indian box office figures has been analysed using data from boxofficeindia.com. The web site estimates 'the business of Hindi films using all sources and contacts available and the numbers are all indicative as actual numbers are rarely given out by producers and distributors India'. Name of the film and its success in a given market were tabulated to examine local as well as global markets. Table 3 shows comparative of Indian box office with overseas box office and their year of release based on the revenues. The tabulation here refers only to names and year as the rank refers to success based on economic figures. It shows how six out of ten films differed as far as market success of Indian versus overseas markets are concerned. Since the 'local audiences' did not find 'globally targeted' films appealing enough, those films did not do well on Indian box office. Only four films *Three Idiots*, *Dhoom 2*, *Rab Ne Bana Di Jodi* and *Om Shanti Om* were successful across local as well as global markets commercially.

Table 3. Box Office success of Bollywood films in India and Overseas

Rank	Indian Markets	Year	Overseas Markets	Year
1	*Three Idiots*	2009	*My Name Is Khan*	2010
2	*Ghajini*	2008	*Three Idiots*	2009
3	*Gadar Ek Prem Katha*	2001	*Kabhi Alvida Naa Kehna*	2006
4	*Hum Aapke Hain Kaun*	1994	*Om Shanti Om*	2007
5	*Raajneeti*	2010	*Dhoom 2*	2006
6	*Dhoom 2*	2006	*Rab Ne Bana Di Jodi*	2008
7	*Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge*	1995	*Veer-Zaara*	2004
8	*Rab Ne Bana Di Jodi*	2008	*Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham...*	2001
9	*Om Shanti Om*	2007	*Don - The Chase Begins Again*	2006
10	*Krissh*	2006	*Jodhaa Akbar*	2008

Source: Data compiled from http://www.boxofficeindia.com/ retrieved in November 2011

Top grossing film *Three idiots* in Indian markets made net gross of INR 202,57,00,000 (approx 40,514,000 USD) and distributor share of INR 99,02,00,000, (approx 19,804,000 USD) whereas the overseas top grosser *My Name is Khan* made total USD 19,210,000 including 4.04 million in UK and 4.20 million in North America. The first week's share of full overseas was around INR 16 crore (USD 32 million), approximately Rs. 1.5 to 2 crore (4,56,000 USD) more than that of *Three Idiots*. But the response on Indian markets was not up to the mark, as evident from the sharp decline in box office collections. This also gives the indication that

whereas *Three Idiots* continued to yield handsome shares for 7-8 weeks, MNIK was not be able to do it for more than a couple of weeks as it happened eventually.
Table 4 shows names and release years of top-five films which are 'all time earners' at Indian and overseas box office. As again evident except *Three Idiots* which did well both locally as well as globally, remaining films did not fare well at both the box offices. Also prior to 2000, Bollywood films did not make it big at overseas box office since few were released and fewer targeted those markets.

Table 4. All Time Top Earners (Inflation Adjusted) for Indian and Overseas Market

Rank	India	Year	Overseas	Year
1	*Hum Aapke Hain Kaun*	1994	*Three Idiots*	2009
2	*Gadar Ek Prem Katha*	2001	*Kabhi Alvida Na Kehna*	2006
3	*Three Idiots*	2009	*Om Shanti Om*	2007
4	*Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge*	1995	*Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham*	2001
5	*Raja Hindustani*	1996	*Veer Zaara*	2006

Source: Data compiled from http://www.boxofficeindia.com/ retrieved in November 2011

Table 5 shows that even within the domestic box office, two urban centres; Mumbai and Delhi, if compared there had a variation in the market success of the films. Mumbai is a financial capital whereas Delhi is a political capital and the films having political and partition contexts (*Rajneeti* and *Gadar Ek Prem Katha*) did well at second and fourth rank in Delhi whereas *Lage Raho Munnabhai* and *Hum Aapke Hain Kaun* ranked second and fourth in Mumbai box office. *Lage Raho Munnabhai* for Mumbai audiences and *Gadar: Ek Prem Kahani* for Delhi audiences, 'shared linguistic and historical experiences…to create cultural commonalities that lend themselves to a sense of closeness or proximity in audiences to certain cultural source' (Pastina and Straubhaar, 2005).

Table 5. All time top earners for Mumbai and Delhi

Rank	Mumbai top grosser	Year	Delhi top grosser	Year
1	*Three Idiots*	2009	*Three Idiots*	2009
2	*Lage Raho Munnabhai*	2006	*Raajneeti*	2010
3	*Ghajini*	2008	*Ghajini*	2008
4	*Hum Aapke Hain Kaun*	1994	*Gadar Ek Prem Katha*	2001
5	*Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge*	1996	*Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge*	1995

Source: Data compiled from http://www.boxofficeindia.com retrieved in November 2011

Findings : Only four out of ten Bollywood films did commercially well in 'local' as well as 'global' markets clearly indicating how globalised Bollywood films (shot abroad, featuring foreign artists, story line with western themes, western visual syntax) did not find local audiences and did well in only one of the markets. Cultural relevance of the content had been decisive factor for the success of Bollywood films even in local markets as audiences identified with the 'cultural connect' in terms of context, language, actors, themes, music, story and so on. Even the recent success of dubbed Hollywood in India suggests linguistic proximity as an important variable for market expansion.

Bollywood, Markets and Audience

About 3.7 billion cinema tickets are sold in India every year, according to Ernst & Young, an accountancy group, more than twice as many as in the next biggest market, the US. Most tickets are still cheap, however – costing 30 rupees in some single-screen theatres – and earnings are low compared with the West. Being a largest film producer in the world, India also has largest admissions and cinema screens second to US. At the same time the figures are inverse when average film budgets, screens per head, ticket price, and annual film spending per head are concerned. Indian Box Office earns revenues second in the world next to the US. Locally the amount collected at the ticket window is taxed in India. This tax is called entertainment tax. These taxes vary from state to state. The entertainment tax rate has come down a lot in practically all the states since 2003. The highest rate today is in Uttar Pradesh, in Northern India, which is 60 per cent. The gross collection of a film at the present time (2010) can be anywhere from 30-35 per cent higher than the net collections today depending on where the collections are coming from.

The countries that have become specialized in film production, i.e. those with a high annual number of non-subsidized feature film releases, are countries with vast home audiences, such as India (1041 film releases in 2005), USA (599 releases in 2006), Japan (417 in 2006), and China (330 in 2006)(figures from European Audiovisual Observatory, 2007). Ernst & Young & FICCI, 2007 notes that Hollywood does an estimated three per cent to five per cent of the total box office revenues from India, though there are no restrictions on imports in India. But the KPMG-FICCI (2011: 61) remarks, "popularity and share of Hollywood films in India is getting bigger year on year basis. While this is largely a metro centric phenomenon, the dubbed versions in Hindi and Tamil have also been doing well in non-metros".

In media economics, Waterman and Lee (2002) found significantly positive relationship over time between measures of domestic consumer spending on movies and domestic box-office market shares, and a negative relationship between domestic movie spending and American movie market shares based on their study of trends in theater box-office in the US, Japan, Germany, Italy, France, and the UK since the 1950s. Domestic and overseas box office figures for Bollywood films confirm the similar trend.

Globalization has not produced a homogeneous global culture (Tomlinson, 2001), and numerous media studies have shown that media products moving across cultural boundaries are subjected to local reception and interpretation irrespective of the medium (Ang 1985, Wang G et.al. 2000, Desai and Agrawal 2009). Media economists researching the value of media products note that the value in a foreign market is not completely predictable by their performance in their original market. Hoskins and Mirus (1988: 500) coined the term 'cultural discount' to refer to the phenomenon that a cultural product rooted in one culture "will have a diminished appeal elsewhere as viewers find it difficult to identify with the style, values, beliefs, institutions, and behavioral patterns of the material in question". On similar lines Straubhaar et. al. (1995) gives concept of 'cultural proximity' for audience interest.

If one looks at findings of the Indian cinema-hall going audience survey, Bollywood film viewing is more of ritualistic, sociological activity for them. Globalization of Bollywood in nineties with avenues for legitimate, non-black financial underwriting and multifold distribution and consumption avenues has without doubt led to expansion of markets. But that does not mean the audiences too have been created. The process of expansion of markets is taking place with losing of local audiences for Bollywood. Historically 'pan Indian' Bollywood content,

now by attempting to become 'global', is fragmenting its audiences. At the same time audiences which are habituated to visit cinema-halls for Bollywood films are here to stay and their choice of 'a film' is a collective sociological process and not an individual decision.

Conclusion

Bollywood is reaching into newer markets with overseas distributions and newer themes but the examination of film texts, local audience behaviour and box office figures clearly suggests that globalization of Bollywood is neither gaining audiences nor newer markets. For Bollywood audiences, films are not only mere 'watching of film', but more of an experience of being part of film culture by visiting cinema hall as 'social outing', recommending films to others and 'watching' films for 'the sake of it' with family and friends. The capital and capitalism through marketing investments and cultural commodification is making 'global'. Bollywood is increasingly becoming irrelevant for 'local' audiences. And in the process of globalization Bollywood is gaining newer audiences overseas. So, while pace of globalization of Bollywood is for real, the gain/loss of markets or the audiences is not so real.

References

Ang, I. (1985). *WAtching Dalla: Soap Opera and Melodramatic Imagination.* London: Methuen.

Bhattacharya, R. (2002). *Anatomy of HIT.* Retrieved September 10, 2010, from Screen: http://www.screenindia.com/old/20020315/fcover.html

Chitrapu, S. (2009). A regional mosaic: lingustic diversity and India's film trade. *Annual Conference of the International Communications Association.* Singapore: Paper presented .

Chitrapu, S. (June 23-26, 2010). The big stick behind "soft power"? The cse of Indian films in international markets. *Annual Conference of the International Communications Association.* Singapore: Paper presented at the Panel 'South Asia and Soft Power: Undrestanding Bollywood's Gloal Influence through the lenses of film flows .

Desai, M. K., & Agrawal, B. C. (2009). *Television and Cultural Crisis: An analysis of transnational television in India.* New Delhi: Concept.

Dudrah, R. K. (2006). *Bollywood- Sociology goes to the Movies.* New Delhi: Sage.

Hoskins, C., & Mirus, R. (1988). Reasons of the US dominance in the international trade in television programmes. *Media, Culture and Society , 10* (4), 499-515.

Joseph, S., Campbell, C., & Cahoon, K. (n.d.). From National to Regional cultures: the five cultures and television markets in NAFTA.

Karan, K., & Schaefer, D. J. (February 12-14, 2009). Marketing, Hybridity and Media industries: Globalization and expanding audiences for popular Hindi Cinema. *5th International conference on Internationalization of business in changed environment.* Mathura, UP, India: paper presented.

KPMG-FICCI. (2011, November). *Hitting the high notes- Indian Media and Entertainment Industry Report.* Retrieved November 21, 2011, from KPMG site: http://kpmg.com

Morcom, A. (2001). An understanding between Bollywood and Hollywood? The meaning of Hollywood-style music in Hindi films. *British Journal of Ethnomusicology , 10* (1), 63-84.

Pastina, A. C., & Straubhaar, J. D. (2005). Muliple Proximities between television genres and audiences The Schism between telenovelas' Global Distribution and Local consumption. *Gazette: The International Journal of Communication Studies , 67* (3), 271-188.

Perry, B. (2006, August 1). *Snoop Dogg's Bollywood Cameo- Rapper appears in musical 'Singh is Kinng'*. Retrieved Septmber 20, 2010, from variety: http://variety.com/articles

Punathambekarn, A. (2005). Bollywood in the Indian-American Diaspora- Mediating a transitive logic of cultural citizenship. *International Journal of Cutlural Studies , 8* (2), 151-173.

Rao, S. (2007). The Globalization of Bollywood: An ethnography of Non-elite audiences in India. *The Communication Review , 10*, 57-76.

Straubhaar, J. C. (1991). Beyond Media Imperialism: Assymetrical Interdependence and Cultural Proximity. *Critical Studies in Mass Communication , 8*, 39-59.

Sundaram, R. (2005). Media globalization: An Indian perspective. *Global media and communication* , 55-58.

Tomilson. (1991). *Cultural Imperialism: A Critical introduction.* London: Pinter.

Wang, G., Servaes, J., & Goonasekera, A. (2000). *The communication landscape-Demystifying media globalization.* London: Routledge.

Waterman, D., & Lee, S. W. (Working paper, revised February 22, 2002). *Thetrical Feature Film Trade and Media Policies in the United States, Europe and Japan-.* Retrieved September 17, 2010, from http://papers.ssrn.com/sol3

Young, E. & FICCI (2007, October). *Indian content on the move.* Retrieved September 2009, from Company website: http://ey.com

Young, E. & FICCI (19-20 December, 2007). *India's digitl revolution: Impact on film and television sectors.* New Delhi: Focus 2007-Global Summit Entertainment & Media.

Websites referred

http://www.bollywoodtrade.com/box-office

http://www.imdb.com/

http://www.boxofficeindia.com/

http://www.ibosnetwork.com/

http://www.madametussauds.com/

Mira K Desai is Associate Professor in Communication Technology at University Department of Extension Education, SNDT Women's University, Juhu Campus, Mumbai-400 049, India. E-mail: *drmiradesai@gmail.com*

© *Media Watch* 4 (1) 67- 73, 2013
ISSN 0976-0911 e-ISSN 2249-8818

Depiction of Contemporary Media: Thematic Analysis of *Pipili Live*

ARCHANA R SINGH

Panjab University, India

Pipli Live, a 2010 movie of Aamir Khan Productions evoked exceptional response both from the audience and the critics. The reviewers either wrote eons in its praise or rubbished it as being superficial and lacking depth. The reviews appearing soon after the film's release, concentrated not only on the quality of the film but also about the politics, the farmers and their problems. The media conveniently ignored the media. They never really spoke in depth about the way contemporary media scenario has been depicted in the film. This paper tries to look at this aspect of the film through the process of thematic analysis. It also brings to light the popular perception about media in the minds of the common man.

Keywords : *Pipili Live*, thematic analysis, media and Hindi films, depiction of media

The number of farmers in India who have committed suicides between 1995 and 2010 as per the cumulative data by The National Crime Records Bureau, GOI is '2, 56,913'. (Sainath, P. 2011) The agrarian crisis is as grim as ever and media, apart from a few newspapers, continues to treat it as just another story. Cinema has tackled the issues of agrarian crisis since *Mother India, Upkaar, Dharti kahe pukar ke* and many others to the latest *Summer 2007* but one film that has tackled the above issue through a satire on political, bureaucratic and media response to the same is *Pipli Live.* Whatever the opinion about the quality of the film, it has certainly brought together the plurality of Indian society and the diversity of Indian people in focus. While the film talks throughout about the impending death of a farmer, it delves upon one apparent and one implicated death; that of the 'mud digger' being symbolic of silent death of the poor and impoverished and in one stroke manages to metaphorically announce the death of the rural print media through the small time reporter of sole proprietor rural newspaper. The

Correspondence to : Archana R Singh, Chairperson, School of Communication Studies, Panjab University, Chandigarh-160 014, India. E-mail: *archana@pu.ac.in*

film takes a long hard look at the market driven media environment and a student of media can discern a commentary on the dilemma being faced by the Indian media persons in every dialogue and description.

The profession of journalism is in a state of flux and the insecurity is being felt by the journalists. The perpetrators of this change are as varied as the change itself, ranging from processes to personnel. The politico- economic decisions of globalization, liberalization, privatization; bureaucratic decisions such as encouragement to FDI; business decisions such as changing ownership patterns and emergence of Trans National Organizations; professional decisions such as corporatization of media, cut throat inter and intra media competition and underlining the above changes are the personal decisions made at every hierarchical level by the journalists.(Singh, 2011) The profession of journalism is definitely going through a re-formation. The journalists are not immune to the changes as these changes affect them the most. However, traditional journalistic ideals are so deeply ingrained in the minds of the journalists that every new realization is seen through the ideals set forth by their predecessors. It is not an independently growing profession but a series in a continuum where some yard sticks have to be followed, some measures taken, some traditions broken and some bridges burnt. Professional boundaries, marked distinctly by the roles in the context of 'then and now', are been built around the organizational structures in the corporate world and their place within them. (Schwandt A, 2007)

Objectives

This paper, tries to identify the deeper nuances of media diversity as shown in the film, *Pipli Live*.

1. To go beyond the superficial depiction of media appearing to be only about salability of the story and the circus created by electronic media pouncing on 'breaking news'.
2. Take a concentrated look at the diverse aspects of media which speak about the changes that the profession of journalism is going through and the insecurity being felt by the journalists.
3. Conduct a qualitative thematic analysis of the film through emerging themes and their contribution to the narrative.

Theoretical Perspective

Development of video as an inexpensive and convenient medium led to a theoretical shift, from positivism towards interpretivism. With the rise of interpretivist and phenomenological approaches in the social sciences, there has also been a shift away from language and linguistically derived models of society and towards studies oriented towards the body, to music and dance, and to feeling, emotion and memory. Written descriptions, and interview and survey methods, can go some way towards both recording and presenting such research, but film and photography not only enrich such studies, they can provide insight beyond that which is possible with mere words alone. Of course, such uses of investigator-generated visual representations are not exclusively interpretivist. In the areas of proxemics, kinesics, etc visual data has been generated and used in an essentially positivist way, as in the use of static video cameras to gather 'data' that can augment conversational analysis. (Marcus, 2007) Interpretivist research after all relies on the interpretation of the researcher and the audience may or may not agree.

Methodology

The film has been analyzed through thematic analysis also called as interpretive content analysis; this is a common general approach to analyzing qualitative data that does not rely on the specialized procedures of other means of analysis. In this exploratory approach, the analyst codes (marks or indexes) sections of a text according to whether they appear to contribute to emerging themes. (Schwandt A, 2007) The priori, non content-specific scheme of coding has been used for the purpose of analyzing the visual data. It is first developed from careful study of the film and the theoretical interests that drive the inquiry. The codes are derived directly by the researcher from the themes originating in the film and the qualitative data are examined. The codes are organized in a manner that the film can be deconstructed along qualitative themes.

Unit of analysis and codes

Every single appearance of 'media' and 'media workers' whether print or broadcast. Emerging themes or codes relating to the issue along with their operational definition are:

1. Urban/rural: The trade area of the medium
2. Rich /Poor : The economic status of the medium
3. Alert/laid back: The news sense of the medium and its workers
4. Sensitive/Callous: Social responsibility followed by the medium
5. Opportunist/idealist: News gathering techniques used by the workers
6. Print/television: Type of medium
7. Sole proprietor/Corporate: Ownership type of the medium
8. Political pressure/market pressure: Pressures to which the medium succumbs
9. Inter-media competition: Competition between different media
10. Intra-media competition: Competition within the medium

Data Analysis

Inter-media competition and intra-media competition

The first media form to make an entry into the film is a sideways quiet entry of the newspaper. Natha's brother, Budhia, is shown listening to a newspaper story about farmers' suicide published in 'Jan Morcha' being read out at a tea stall. The story helps Budhia become knowledgeable about the compensation being offered by the government and helps him make up his mind.

In contrast, it is in the market driven corporate journalistic environment that the city media makes its presence felt in the film. Urban elitist media in the form of English news channel makes its entry into the frame of the film with a 'Shilpa Shetty' story in the lead. Farmers' suicide story is the third lead in the bulletin on air. Hindi media makes its entry as a viewer of English Channel. This is a sorry comment on the secondary status of Hindi electronic media as also frequent dialogues of the Hindi anchor(interestingly called Kumar Deepak), where he keeps stressing on the aspect that no one watches English news, points towards the complexes within the mindset. The Hindi channel news room is abuzz with irrelevant stories being planned and absurd sensational headlines being written. The entire sequence is biased in favour of the English media who appears to be self confident to the extent of being pompous and arrogant. Hindi channel appears to be taking a cue from the English channels and being overtly competitive and begrudging.

The competition amongst the media is clear. Print media does not seem to be in the rat race at all because it is visible either as a small newspaper or as an international publication. No mention has been made of national dailies. The electronic media in their race for TRPs appear cut throat proving the public perception right.

Opportunist/idealist, political pressure/market pressure

The nexus between politicians with the correspondents of the English channels is casual, friendly and one of symbiotic interdependence made clear by their dialogues about attending each other's parties while the relationship with Hindi channel reporter is about sycophancy and feet touching. The whispered personal conversation with the minister and the abrupt interjection by the lady anchor (Nandita) when questions get uncomfortable speaks volumes about the three ways inter relationships between the two anchors and the politicians.

The entire sequence where media people are shown talking or interacting with politicians is an outsider's window into the world of varied media forms and their compulsions. That a relationship exists between the two is understandable as the first and the fourth estate have to develop a relationship of trust but here it is more about media quitting the role of the watch dog in favour of a more lucrative deal. News making is a business, which has to thrive with government support and also permission. It is also a business that needs to appeal to its consumers, while informing, educating, and entertaining them, the ultimate motive being profit. The earliest media theories stressed upon diffusion of innovations as the way to spread information to the poor masses in the developing world while the developed world always had media catering to the tastes of their consumers. (Chaffee, Steven H., & Fausto, Izcaray, 1975) We have now reached a state where the media centered models have become obsolete and globalization has made it possible for the developing and the developed world to come together on the same platform and the audience centered models of the western world become popular.

Print/electronic

The larger than life position of electronic media matches the perceptions that the common man harbours about the two media. Print is the first medium to make its entry and is depicted as a reliable medium. It is also the first medium to break the Natha story. It evokes two immediate reactions: Governmental action in the form of 'Lal Bahadur' and License of *Jan Morcha* being revoked.

Print media has several interesting aspects in the film:

1. Breaks the news at the local level.
2. Breaks the first Natha story.
3. Is being followed by/referred to local politicians.
4. Is represented only by small sole proprietor rural newspaper and only one instance of an international magazine when the Natha family makes it to the cover of the Times with the headline, 'The great Indian tragedy'.
5. It exists in two extremes of hyper-local and global i.e. either the Pipli newspaper or Time magazine.
6. There is no national or regional print media to provide inter-media or intra-media competition.
7. Is prone to closure and governmental action.

8. Is not considered as competition by the electronic media. The inter-media competition is visible in the broadcast channels only.

Rural/urban/rich/poor

Few characteristics that emerge in the film are a comment on what the filmmaker perceives to be the popular perception of the media.

1. The reality and rhetoric of the two worlds that live within India is depicted clearly in the differences between the media depicted in the film. The Rural media is symbolized by a sole proprietor (NavKranti Prakashan) small newspaper called 'Janmorcha', an aggressive suggestion to the otherwise meek existence. The sole reporter of the sole proprietor newspaper is Rakesh who is introduced to the audience in most 'non-news' scenario and a poetry recital.
2. Later however, rural print media reporter turns out to be the only media person with a 'nose for news'. He is first to recognize the Natha story, first to break it in his newspaper, first to recognize a good story in the Mahto the mud digger and discusses it with the urban elite media who condescendingly agrees to send a reporter to do a feature) .He is sensitive enough to recognize the fact that a death due to hunger is a bigger story as compared to a 'threatened suicide'. He is also first to notice the futility of Natha story, first to notice suspicious behavior of police officers who have kept Natha in a warehouse , first to reach the spot and find Natha and first to martyr his life for the cause of a good story. He is however unaware of his capabilities and is starry eyed about electronic media.
3. Hindi urban electronic media has been portrayed as sensationalist, lazy, opportunistic and self congratulatory. They mostly are shown as keeping an eye on the English Channel reporter and following her lead.
4. The English language television channels are insensitive, opportunistic, TRP driven and unconcerned with human discomfort and cleverly hide their callousness behind the garb of professionalism.
5. The contrasts do not end here. On reaching Pipli, before and during the media blitzkrieg Nandita is often seeing reprimanding and instructing Rakesh while he acts as the local organizer for the elite media.
6. Throughout the film, the Hindi urban elite media is shown indulging in sensational journalism and in fact encouraging superstition in one sequence by asking the villagers to pretend to be possessed.
7. The inane reporting tricks being used by various television channels can be characterized thus: Crude opportunistic with local residents and condescending towards local media. Competitive with rivals, callous towards the family of the protagonist. Sycophantic towards powerful politicians and ready to politicize the issue.

Sole proprietor/corporate, alert/laid back, sensitive/callous

The Natha story is picked up by the English Channel followed closely by the Hindi channel based solely on the editorial decision making of the higher hierarchy of the media establishment and not by the reporters. At one point journalist (Nandita) asks the owner, 'what are we expected to do about this?" and when asked to cover the Natha story says, 'Farmer kind of stories are not my stories' .The urban Hindi journalist calls the suicide story a 'non-

story' and wants to work on scams when the competitive boss wants to know why they don't have the story. Rakesh, clearly seems to be popular in his circle and has an audience who he manages to captivate with his poetry recital but his respect for the owner is visible when he hides the cigarette that he has been smoking. The situation contrasts with instances when the Hindi and English media urban journalists do not agree with their seniors.

The reporters are shown taking decisions on event oriented news and not on perspectives crossing the thin line between 'media events' and 'news events'. News events are 'not preplanned but newsworthy'. To exemplify the distinction, the assassination of J.F. Kennedy is a 'news event'; the funeral of Kennedy is a 'media event'. The ubiquitous-ness of the media and their global reach mean that wherever newsworthy events are anticipated, the media are present to ensure they are covered, although not always live-to-air. (Dayan, D. & E. Katz, 1992). We have reached a stage now that unless covered live, the event is neither a media event nor a news event.

The pressures being felt on sole proprietor newspapers begin with intimidation and end with revoking of the license. The action that comes at the slightest provocation renders the reporter jobless. It is common knowledge in journalistic circles that newspaper editors make decisions about what to report as news based on several factors, including audience interests and cost of producing a newscast or newspaper (Hamilton, James T, 2004).What is more, local newspaper editors and the local news organizations that employ the reporters are different enough in terms of resources and the audience to whom newspapers appeal to produce variation in the amount of local news coverage (Montague, Levering&Levering,1983). Closure of the newspaper, would result in the entire staff being unemployed and the semi trained journalist of a rural newspaper is unlikely to find employment in large urban corporation despite his reporting skills.

The sole proprietor is portrayed as scared. As it is he is struggling with lack of support system, limited resources and untrained staff, and to add to his woes are the political and bureaucratic pressures. He cringes at every question and places the blame on the correspondent. The respect which the correspondent displayed earlier is lost as he stares unbelievingly at his proprietor. The look on Rakesh's face bears a familiar expression which many a reporter has had when their story was not supported by the management.

Conclusion

Media departs from Pipli. The basics of journalism suggest verification. Ditties like, 'When in doubt, find out' seem to have lost their meaning considering the perceived behaviors of media in the film. The small time print reporter dies in the explosion and everyone assumes that Natha is dead. Of course, Natha, the farmer is dead, a fact that media has not noticed. Natha, the migrant labour has just been born. However, the more tragic death is that of Rakesh. He, symbolizes, print media, the sensitive media, the only media with some nose for news, the alert media and the small grassroots media. The film at this point reflects the condition of this variety of journalists in the media. These journalists are unrecognized, unappreciated, dying a quiet death amid the din of corporate media. As they go extinct, the elite urban media blows dust to the rural hinterland and will return to the Piplis of India only when they have the TRP friendly, eyeball catching, 'breaking news'!

References

Banks, Marcus. (2007), Using Visual Data in Qualitative Research, The place of visual data in social research: a brief history, Contributors; Print Pub. Date: 2007, Print ISBN: 9780761949794, Online ISBN: 9780857020260, DOI: 10.4135/9780857020260, Print pages: 20-34. *SAGE Research Methods Online*. October 2010.

Chaffee, Steven H., & Fausto, Izcaray.(1975).Mass Communication Functions in a Media-Rich Developing Society. *Communication Research,* 2: 367, DOI: 10.1177/009365027500200403, http://crx.sagepub.com/content/2/4/367

Dayan, D. & E. Katz.(1992). Media Events: The Live Broadcasting of History. *Cambridge, MA Harvard University Press*,1992

Hamilton, James T. (2004). All the News That's Fit to Sell: How the Market Transforms Information Into News, *Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press*

Kern, Montague, Patricia W. Levering, and Ralph B. Levering. (1983), The Kennedy Crises: ThePress, the Presidency, and Foreign Policy. *Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press*

Sainath, P. (2011). In 16 years, farm suicides cross a quarter million. http://www.thehindu.com/opinion/columns/sainath/article2577635.ece?homepage=true. Retrived on October 29, 2011

Singh, Archana R (2011). A profession in transition: challenges, constraints and concerns. A study of changing professional identity of journalists. *Paper presented at the International conference on Changing global paradigms of Media*, Patiala, India , Oct 21-23, 2011

Thomas, Schwandt A. (2007). Thematic analysis, *The SAGE Dictionary of Qualitative Inquiry,* Print Pub. Date: 2007 Print ISBN: 9781412909273 Online ISBN: 9781412986281 DOI: 10.4135/9781412986281.

Archana R Singh is Associate Professor & Chairperson, School of Communication Studies, Panjab University, Chandigarh-160 014, India. E-mail: *archana@pu.ac.in*

© *Media Watch* 4 (1) 74- 83, 2013
ISSN 0976-0911 e-ISSN 2249-8818

Dirty Harry as Pornography: Revealing the Unrevealed

VAN ROBERTS
Mississippi University for Women, Mississippi State, USA
MARK GOODMAN
Mississippi State University, Mississippi State, USA

Dirty Harry was released 40 years ago. We contend that it was a very influential film because it was one of the first mainstream pornography films. Our analysis shows how the producers of Dirty Harry used the signifiers and ideology of a porn film to reveal the dirty side of society. Today, those porn film signifiers have created a porn film ideology, which is a common element on television and in film.

Keywords: *Dirty Harry,* obscenity, pornography, semiotics

Arguably the most influential law and order thriller since Fritz Lang's *The Big Heat*, *Dirty Harry* was forged in the cross-hairs of turbulent 1960s politics and controversial censorship practices. Rooted solidly in the blue collar tradition of the 1930s Warner Brothers' crime thriller, *Dirty Harry* depicts a number of social ills growing out of metropolitan life in the 1970s. In the 1966 *Miranda* v. *Arizona* case (384 U.S. 436), Chief Justice Earl Warren and the U.S. Supreme Court ruled that individuals in police custody had certain constitutional guarantees when authorities questioned them about crimes. The court enacted this mandate so suspects and prisoners would not be forced into incriminating confessions. Although the Constitution states that authorities have no right to compel an individual to act as a witness against him or herself, police were not required to inform the suspect that anything said could be used against them. The *Miranda* ruling changed everything. Authorities now had to advise suspects and prisoners about the right to counsel before and during police interrogations. Furthermore, suspects and prisoners had to waive their right before questioning could commence. In the aftermath of *Miranda, e*nraged citizens and police claimed that the Supreme Court had gone "soft on criminals." Meantime, *Dirty Harry* exploited the changes in film censorship. The ratings had changed to a classification system and *Dirty Harry* embraced an R rating to show elements that would have been prohibited five years previously.

In this paper, we will deconstruct *Dirty Harry* through a semiotic analysis to show that this mainstream film is ideologically pornographic. By splitting the conventions from the semiotic language of film (Metz and Taylor, 1990), we can deconstruct the underlying ideology of the

Correspondence to: Mark Goodman, Professor, Department of Communication, Mississippi State University, PO Box PF MS 9574, Mississippi State, MS 39762, USA. All rights reserved with Media Watch. For permissions and reprint, please e-mail: *mediawatchjournal@gmail.com*

text (Derrida, 1998). Further, the directors shot this film in a way that is consistent with the semiotics of the pornographic genre. Like a dirty film which reveals for public inspection that which is normally hidden from public view (borrowing a concept from Linda Williams), *Dirty Harry* reveals the hidden, decadent, seamy, seedy side of urban culture. Only the porn flick's genital display and performance of intercourse are absent from *Dirty Harry,* and both are symbolically present. While *Dirty Harry* may be dressed up like a "clean" film, in reality this film is a "dirty" movie.

As a film genre, pornography is more than prurient stimulation induced by sexual performance and revealing genitals. A porn film states ideological positions about men, about women, about their relationships, about the power present in those relationships, and about cultural hierarchies of domination. Pornography traditionally reaffirms male domination over women through the power of the phallus in action. In this ideological sense, the 1971 Warner Brothers' thriller *Dirty Harry* is a "dirty" movie. Once scholars define *Dirty Harry* as a pornographic film, the concept of "pornography" expands beyond the concept of "skin flick" into an ideological definition.

Politically, *Dirty Harry* concerns the efforts of the eponymous, conservative right-wing protagonist hampered by the ultra-liberal policies of government in a highly permissive city intent apparently on rewarding criminals at the expense of the citizenry. Societal permissiveness creates an obscene, decadent culture hidden beneath a facade of law and justice. As a film, *Dirty Harry* reveals this hidden decadence, just as a "skin flick" reveals hidden genitalia and ideology. The audience becomes voyeurs, removed by space from the decadence but permitted to watch what is supposed to go on behind closed doors, or in the case of *Dirty Harry*, on the rooftops, down the alleys, in the parks and tunnels at night, and in the degenerated sections of San Francisco.

Being voyeuristic makes *Dirty Harry* a phallocentric film. Mulvey (1988) contends that the "phallocentrism" (p. 57) of film results from the cinematic use of the voyeuristic camera that gives film a male perspective that objectifies women by allowing men to look at them and put them on display. Because film is so pervasive, film conventions naturalize the subjugation of women because the male gaze is incorporated as a cultural signifier, thereby institutionalizing objectification and subjugation into the culture's dominant ideology. From Mulvey's perspective, all film is pornographic ideologically. The frequent use of the telescopic lens to spy on potential victims reinforces the voyeur perspective as first *Dirty Harry,* then the audience watching safely in their theatre seats, objectify victims into subjects of fetish desire.

The fetish replacement for the phallus becomes the guns and knives used by Callahan and Scorpio to impose their will on the objectified victims. Closeups and extreme closeups present these weapons to the audience to view and gain "knowledge" about them, just as closeups of female genitalia and sexual pleasure provide men "knowledge" about women, argues Kuhn (1982 and 1985). Pornographic pleasure for the male begins when a woman is forced into sexual acts, Kaplan (1983) explains. Similarly, in *Dirty Harry* Scorpio forces his victims into their acts; then Callahan coerces Scorpio to recognize Harry's superiority. Scorpio's gratification comes as his victims go into uncontrolled spasms because of his penetration of their bodies with knife or bullet. His gratification recalls Williams' (1989) description of the male pleasure in watching the female body in the uncontrolled frenzy of orgasmic excitement or the hard core film's climax of the "money shot," the demonstration of masculinity during ejaculation. "Hard core tries not to play peekaboo with either its male or its female bodies," explains Williams (p. 49). "It obsessively seeks knowledge, through a voyeuristic record of

confessional, involuntary paroxysm, of the 'thing' itself." In the same way, *Dirty Harry* provides knowledge of societal decadence by permitting the audience to watch as its victims involuntarily die. The intensity of the experience for the *Dirty Harry* viewers of watching victims being targeted, penetrated, and die may be comparable to that of the person watching a pornographic film. Yet, like pornography, the viewer is protected.

One of the attractions of the pornographic film, writes Kuhn (1985), is that the male can possess the object of his attraction without risk. Kuhn contends that the vagina becomes the representation of the totality of femininity. The male who possesses a woman's vagina possesses the woman's body, the woman, and her affections. Real life possession carries the risk of rejection, Kuhn explains, but pornographic depiction of the vagina is not threatening since the cinematic replacement for the real allows the male to possess that which makes the woman female but with the knowledge that she will always perform in the ways that bring him sexual pleasure. In *Dirty Harry* the audience can experience vicariously the brutality of a decadent society without coming into real contact with the dirt of the alleys or strip shows or gutters. The audience can participate in Scorpio's murders without condoning them; the audience can become empowered like Callahan, can be masculine like Callahan, and finally kill the evil like Callahan. *Dirty Harry* offers decadence without responsibility, just as a pornography film provides sex without risk.

Historically, *Dirty Harry* is an important film because this film brought the dirty film into the Hollywood mainstream. *Dirty Harry* is the first mainstream porn film, a genre which now includes many films. Our analysis of this film contributes to the understanding of the genre of the major stream porn film. We conclude by discussing the ideological and hierarchical implications of the porn film becoming mainstream.

Plot Synopsis

A synopsis of *Dirty Harry* establishes how this popular and profitable exercise in 1970s film noire readily accommodates pornographic signifiers. A deranged sniper atop an adjacent skyscraper shoots a girl in a penthouse motel swimming pool. Inspector Harry Callahan is assigned to the case. Either the City of San Francisco must pay $100,000, or the killer, who has signed the note as "Scorpio," will resume his murderous ways. At first, the mayor stalls for time, but delay prompts Scorpio to ambush a juvenile. The city sets a trap for Scorpio, but he escapes and kills a policeman. Angered, Scorpio abducts a fourteen-year-old girl and demands $200,000. The mayor agrees to pay the ransom, and Callahan volunteers as the bag man.

Events take a turn for the worse. Scorpio beats up Callahan and refuses to tell him where the girl lies buried. As the killer is about to kill Harry, his partner intervenes. Before the killer can flee, Callahan stabs Scorpio in the thigh with a switchblade. Eventually, Callahan tracks the wounded Scorpio to a football stadium. He shoots Scorpio in the leg and violates the killer's civil rights. The District Attorney declines to prosecute the killer, and threatens to indict Harry for violating Scorpio's rights.

After the police release Scorpio, Harry starts following him. Scorpio hires a thug to rough himself up, and he frames Callahan for the beating. The police chief orders Harry to stop his surveillance. After the killer leaves the hospital, he hijacks a bus load of kids. Scorpio demands not only $200,000 but also a plane to fly him wherever he wants. Harry intercepts the bus in route to the airport. The killer crashes it into a gravel plant and runs. As Harry chases him out to the sludge pond in the rear of the plant, Scorpio grabs a kid fishing. The boy escapes when Callahan wounds the killer. Harry taunts Scorpio, and the killer grabs his gun. Harry's

bullet hits him in the chest, hurling him into the sludge. Afterward, Callahan pitches his badge contemptuously into the drainage pit where the corpse of the killer floats.

Porn Signifiers

Pornography in the 1970s channeled its impact ostensibly through two basic shots: the meat shot and the money shot. Linda Williams (1989) observes that the meat shot and money shot and their projection of the hidden aspects of sexual behavior became genre signifiers of these mainstream porno films shown in cinemas. Don Siegel's *Dirty Harry* exploits these porn characteristics. A porn film reveals sexual decadence; Siegel reveals social decadence. The action in the porn film climaxes with a closeup of the performance of the penis; the action in *Dirty Harry* revolves around the phallic replacement—guns and knives. Further, pornography empowers the masculine, ideologically satisfying male viewers; Harry Callahan's ultimate superior masculinity also empowers male viewers.

The meat shot encompasses any sexual act with the penis either erect or penetrating a female orifice. Meat shots typically portray a man with an erect penis as ready for action. Dirty Harry's dialogue states the same point: "When I see a naked man chasing a woman down an alley with a butcher knife and a hard-on, I don't figure he's out collecting for the Red Cross." (Fink and Riesner, 1971, 9) Meat shots in *Dirty Harry* show the characters brandishing their weapons, whether those weapons are guns, knives, or fists.

The money shot displays the engorged penis ejaculating seminal fluid, producing visual evidence of the male experiencing pleasure, what Williams (1985) describes as "the most blatantly phallic of all hardcore film representations" (p. 93). Siegel "'delivers the goods'" (Williams p. 106) by depicting a male character firing his gun with the subsequent images of blood erupting from the opponent's body. As Williams writes, the money shot "can be viewed as the most representative instance of phallic power and pleasure" (p. 93). When either Harry or Scorpio discharge their firearms or use other weapons to draw blood, the need to depict the firing, stabbing, or smashing action serves "as the ultimate climax—the sense of an ending—for each heterosexual act of violence" shown (p. 95).

Incorporating Pornography

Dirty Harry appeared at a pivotal moment in cinematic history when relaxed film censorship allowed the exhibition of hardcore porno films in mainstream public theatres. Major studio films such as Arthur Penn's *Bonnie & Clyde* (1967), Sam Peckinpah's *The Wild Bunch* (1969), John Schlesinger's *Midnight Cowboy* (1969), William Friedkin's *The French Connection* (1971), Stanley Kubrick's *A Clockwork Orange* (1971), and Bernardo Bertolucci's *Last Tango in Paris* (1973) challenged the limits of mainstream film censorship. Eventually, the movie ratings board relented and replaced the X-rating on *Midnight Cowboy* with an R-rating because the filmmakers refrained from showing actual sexual acts. Similarly, *Dirty Harry* availed itself of the expanding latitude in film censorship to depict its themes with great realism (Zimmerman, 1972, 59).

Traditionally, hardcore pornos have been generically referred to as "dirty," implicating their unsavory content and nature. Inspector Callahan is addressed as "Dirty Harry" four times in the film. The first reference clarifies Harry's egalitarianism. He wears a judicial blindfold of sorts because racism exerts little weight in his judgments. The second time, his partner Chico uses the nickname after Harry peeps into a window while Hot Mary entertains her boyfriend. Later, Harry advances his own theory about his nickname: he constantly tackles

the dirtiest jobs. Lastly, Chico concludes for himself in Bresler's office: Harry "always gets the shit end of the stick" (Fink & Riesner, 1971, 62).

Implicit in each of these examples is Harry's relationship with Scorpio because the killer constitutes another "dirty" assignment. Scorpio forces Harry to scramble breathlessly through San Francisco at night. Along the way, Callahan—as well as the audience—encounters a diverse bunch of perverts and thieves.

Analysis of Specific Scenes

A closer examination of several scenes reveals that pornographic conventions exploited to arouse the audience and to scourge their deviant response by converting their pleasure at such prurience into degeneracy. Those scenes include Scorpio's initial shot, the foiled bank robbery, the foiled sniper attempt, the Hot Mary episode, the night stakeout sequence, the Mount Davidson park clash and the follow-up Kezar Stadium confrontation, Scorpio's hired beating, and the showdown at the gravel plant. For brevity, this paper will focus on three scenes—Scorpio's initial shot, the Mount Davidson park clash, and the final showdown—that demonstrate the pornographic nature of this film.

Scorpio's first shot

Pornographic signifiers, such as phallic performance, voyeurism, objectified identities; meat and money shots materialize in the breakdown of this scene. After its introductory tribute to slain San Francisco policemen, *Dirty Harry* shifts to a superimposed closeup of a cop's badge dissolving into a low-angled, closeup of a silencer on the muzzle of a high-powered rifle. The barrel of the rifle looms in intimate proximity with the camera. According to film theorist Louis Giannetti (1993), intimate distances "range from skin contact to about eighteen inches away" as the silencer is shown in a closeup shot. The rifle with the silencer embodies the phallus and phallic performance. Giannetti describes this distance as one of "physical involvement—of love, comfort, and tenderness between individuals" (p. 63-63).

Meanwhile, jazz composer Lalo Schifrin's musical score serves as a porn signifier, according to Shadioan (1974, p. 170). The music is "sado-sensual—especially the female chorus with its wordless vocal refrain (the Scorpio "theme")"—underscored as it is with a syncopated beat.

Voyeurism plays a major part in this brief (little over a minute's worth of time), yet sexually taut, sequence of images. Siegel frames a young woman in a medium shot from the sniper's point of view as seen through the telescopic sights as she rises and walks to one end of the penthouse pool. A social distance of about four to twelve feet as magnified by the scope appears to lie between the assassin and his victim, signaling the transaction of impersonal business. Appropriately enough, the young woman suspects nothing as she swims laps. Siegel neatly establishes the setting with a zoom shot that pulls back from the far skyscraper to reveal another skyscraper where the anonymous assassin stands poised over his rifle. The viewer remains at a public distance here from the killer varying from twelve to twenty-five feet. Scorpio fulfills the role of a voyeur. Scorpio's pleasure in killing from ambush allies itself to the voyeur's pleasure he derives from the object of his attention being unaware of his gaze.

In this sequence, the assassin consumes the female swimmer with his predatory telescopic gaze until Scorpio shoots her. He is watching the unsuspecting woman in a yellow, one-piece bathing suit as she dives into the pool and swims laps. An ensuing shot repeats the earlier, uncomfortably intimate closeup of the silencer on the rifle muzzle. Siegel cuts back to

the woman's graceful aquatic strokes as seen from killer's perspective in the cross hairs of his sniper scope. The magnified distance between the swimmer and the killer creates a personal distance of perhaps four feet. Scorpio restrains himself from shooting her immediately because he derives voyeuristic pleasure from watching her swim. The swimmer's beauty and sexuality seem to transfix the sniper's attention. Essentially, Siegel alternates between intimate, personal, and public distances in the relationship between Scorpio and the murdered woman. Although Scorpio is clearly shooting at her, Siegel has gone to extreme lengths to bring these two participants, as well as the spectator, into a kind of close proximity that suggests the intimacy of a sexual coupling. Siegel uses a closeup of an ejaculated bullet spreading blood in what the killer experiences as the pleasure of someone else's pain. Then, the audience confronts her death struggle from intimate distance, similar to the porn camera's closeups of orgasm. As the first victim drowns, the camera pulls out to the safety of the master shot.

Siegel objectifies both killer and his victim in a pornographic way. Siegel conceals the killer's identity throughout the first scene. Neither his face nor any part of his facial expression can be distinguished during this scene. Instead, the powerful rifle dominates all of the shots like an enormous phallus. Scorpio's entire body appears to be grafted to the rifle. The rifle in the killer's hands distinguishes his murderous function while her yellow swimsuit amplifies the woman's femininity and vulnerability as a victim. Each signifier fits with Freud's sexual fetishism concept "that objects or parts of the anatomy are used as symbols for and replacements of the socially valued phallus" (Myers, 1995, p. 265).

The intrusive closeup shots of the rifle barrel as well as the images in the sniper scope both constitute meat shots. The closeup of Scorpio's finger squeezing the trigger and the sinking girl spewing blood both represent the equivalent of money shots. Siegel presents audiences with an intimate, extreme closeup image of the killer's gloved finger pulling the trigger, then he crosscuts to non-point of view images of the girl in an intimate closeup spouting blood. Although she is dying, her mouth opens in a gasp as she spins as if in orgasm. At the public distance of a long shot of perhaps twelve or more feet, she drowns, bleeding. These camera shots and movements with the appearance of blood correspond roughly to what Linda Williams (1989) calls "visual proof of her objectification and humiliation" (p. 112).

The elements of phallic performance and voyeurism represent pornographic signifiers, but the "sexuality" of the shot degenerates when Siegel suddenly has the sniper fire his rifle. One minute the audience is invited to share in Scorpio's voyeurism, only to be brutally jolted out of it when he shoots the woman. She dies with an awkward clumsiness that heightens the unsavory nature of the outcome. Then the whole pornography hierarchy is reversed. When Harry examines the swimmer's body, the filmmakers have placed the dead girl in a long shot at a public distance, but they have positioned her face and breasts turned toward the camera so that the lighting exposes her cleavage. She is an objectified body on her back, ready to be taken sexually by a male if this were a porn film, but in this film she is dead, turning the porn signifier of preparation for intercourse into a cultural signifier of extreme deviance.

Mountain Davidson park and Kezar stadium scenes

Several pornographic signifiers encode the Mount Davidson Park scene. Scorpio wields the upper hand until Harry surprises and stabs him. Initially, Scorpio appears in a red ski mask, concealing and objectifying his identity. The killer forces Callahan to drop the bag and demands to see his gun. Scorpio's tone of voice and the half-described request reverberates with porn signifiers, comparing this confrontation to that of a pervert asking to see his privates. When

Harry produces his forty-four magnum, Scorpio coos with awe, "That's a big one." Scorpio emasculates Callahan, taking the gun from him and then beating him, tells the helpless Callahan not to pass out until his pleasure is complete. Scorpio towers over Callahan here, while Harry in closeup writhes beneath him in passive agony. Instead of divulging the whereabouts of kidnapped victim Ann Mary Deacon, Scorpio reveals that he has decided to let the buried girl die.

Perhaps the most evocative meat shot in this scene and the entire film occurs when Harry produces the switchblade taped to his ankle. At this point, Chico overhears Scorpio's decision to kill Harry and intervenes. During the gunfight, Harry plunges the blade into Scorpio's thigh, penetrating flesh like a meat shot. Siegel cuts from this image to Scorpio's face in closeup with his lips forming a circle as he screams like a woman having an orgasm.

The Kezar Stadium sequence contains pornographic overtones, too. Callahan and his new partner, De Georgio, learn about Scorpio's lair, enter Kezar Stadium without a search warrant, and search of the premises. Siegel intercuts extreme closeup images of Scorpio's voyeuristic eyes as Harry searches for him. Harry chases the hobbling Scorpio (a wounded animal injured by Harry's phallic penetration) onto the football field while De Georgio switches on the powerful stadium lights. Siegel shows Harry in a closeup with his magnum occupying the foreground the image, then reverses the angle to reveal Callahan's perspective over his gun sight as he snaps off the shot that takes down Scorpio, a slug in the leg. Harry demands the whereabouts of the suffocating girl; Scorpio whimpers about his violated civil rights. A frustrated Callahan treads on the bloody leg in a closeup, and he grinds his foot into the killer's wound. Callahan is superior here, controlling a hierarchical relationship while a whining, sniveling, objectified Scorpio writhes beneath his foot. In a reversal of the old romantic movie convention where the camera modestly averts its gaze from the lovers when things get steamy, Siegel pulls his camera back and retreats into the foggy night. At dawn, Harry stands from afar and watches as a team of police and paramedics remove the fully nude body of the kidnapped 14-year-old girl from a hole and load her onto a litter. In a porn film, this would be a moment of sexual excitement. A long lens reveals female genitalia, the object of the voyeur's desire, and holds the image in closeup. But, as with the swimmer, Siegel twists prurient signifiers into a degenerate offering of pedophilia and necrophilia.

Final showdown

Phallic performance, body language, and meat and money shots constitute the pornographic signifiers in this scene. The showdown scene properly begins when Scorpio spots Harry standing on the railroad overpass. Harry jumps onto the bus as it passes under the bridge, and bullets rip through the metal as Scorpio fires wildly into the roof. Furiously, Scorpio commandeers the bus, runs a Volkswagen beetle off the road, and buries the accelerator. The killer swerves the bus to dislodge Harry. Callahan hangs on and lowers himself so that he can look inside the school bus. Harry brandishes his big magnum and points it at Scorpio who is behind the wheel. This shot serves as a meat shot with each character waving a gun in the other's face.

Scorpio crashes the bus and flees into the gravel factory with Harry in hot pursuit. The limp that Scorpio runs with here serves as a visual signification of his sexually aberrant nature. The killer scrambles toward a lake where he notices a boy fishing in the sludge pond. He snatches the boy without hesitation, shoves his pistol into his throat, and threatens to "blow his brains out." Harry saunters closer to Scorpio and his hostage. Looking as if he were going to

surrender to Scorpio, Harry about faces suddenly and wounds Scorpio in the shoulder, setting the boy free. Scorpio loses his gun, an act akin to castration which feminizes him, and the final showdown proceeds with the killer poised to reach for his weapon. Harry's signature taunt (Make My Day) is played for maximum dramatic power, and the filmmakers frame him from a low-angle with his magnum in front of him. Scorpio is shown from a reversed angle, crouched with his fingers stretched out toward his pistol, his mouth open. Giggling insanely, he scoops up his gun, and Harry fires at him. The money shot is clearly presented as Harry's forty-four magnum is shown firing in closeup. The impact of the bullet catapults Scorpio's body backwards. The dead killer flies through the air in three different shots to hit the water with an orgasmic splash. In a low-angled long shot from a public distance, Harry approaches the sludge and stares down into the camera. Siegel reverses the angle and shows Scorpio's body floating face up with his mouth open, a near duplicate shot of Scorpio's first victim.

Conclusion

Dirty Harry, it is essential to clearly understand, is not ostensibly pornographic in the same sense as a *Deep Throat*. Director Don Siegel has availed himself of pornographic references and signifiers to encode visually the film's ideology. The dialogue speaks of the decadence of society. The action shows us the decadence. The settings place us in the decadence. All of this encoding is then placed into a specific cultural context, into the culture of real social decadence—pornography. *Dirty Harry* gives us the cues of prurient sexual arousal—voyeurism, sexual availability, sexual gratification—then spins the hierarchy on its axis, making the violent the sexual and the sexual deviant. In this way, *Dirty Harry* reveals the hidden decadence of society.

Emerging from this crisis of cultural demise is the hero, Harry Callahan, who becomes the answer to a question posed by Linda Williams (1989): "We should be asking what it [pornography] does for viewers"? (p. 5). Given *Dirty's Harry's* success at the box office, in rentals, and on television, the question should be asked: What does this film do for the viewers? Because this movie is a pornographic film, Harry controls the phallus—the gun, the gun empowering him to control his world, both cinematic and ideological. As we stated in the introduction, a porn film states ideological positions about men, about women, about their relationships, about the power present in those relationships, and about cultural hierarchies of domination. Just as a porn film resolves the power relationships in favor of male pleasure and patriarchy, so *Dirty Harry* presents the audience with the dominance of male power over a decadent, perverted world. The conventions of the porn flick in *Dirty Harry* reinforce the socially decadent tone of the film, a necessary element of the film if the patriarchal ideology, stated by Callahan and his gun, is to be successfully rationalized as a natural outgrowth of the plot, centered on the conquest of decadence by the male hero. Once the phallus is empowered and naturalized, the patriarchal ideology of both the porn film and *Dirty Harry* is reaffirmed, justifying male pleasure as a legitimate pursuit of those watching the film.

Forty years after *Dirty Harry*, the mainstream porn film is a popular formula for television and film. *CSI* adopts some of the signifiers of the porn film as the investigators examine death on a weekly basis to determine how the body was penetrated by the perverts. *Criminal Minds* shows the perverted death caused by the sexually deranged person, who is caught as the investigators penetrate his mental deviance. Voyeuristic presentations are the main attraction of the reality shows—*Survivor, Dancing with the Stars, The Bachelor,* et al. Barely dressed women and men perform actions mimicking sexual foreplay and intercourse.

The audience voyeuristically watches the performances and roots for the person who best fulfills the expectations of patriarchal ideology.

Angelina Jolie made herself a star playing the male in mainstream porn films from *Lara Croft: Tomb Raider* (2001) to *Salt* (2010). The Lara Croft character—or the updated Evenlyn Salt—controls the phallus by killing and defeating her mostly male enemies. Yet, her skin tight outfits and nude scenes make her the objective of the male phallus seeking to dominant her, including those in the audience.

At the 2011 Academy Awards, Natalie Portman won best actress for *The Black Swan*. This is a mainstream porn film. The film gives the audience a voyeuristic view of a ballerina's mental and physical challenges as she sexualizes herself for the pleasure of others.

Dirty Harry transformed the porno film from the dark backrooms where a few men gathered for sexual pleasure into a mainstream genre. As many scholars point out the signifiers of sex are used to sell everything from products to news commentators (Bernstein, 2007; Skerski, 2006; Pardun & Forde, 2006; Chambers, 2006; Kastleman, 2007; Macdonald, 1995). This genre sexualizes viewing from the couch to the theater. Attwood (2009) calls it "The Sexualization of Western Culture" and Slattery (2001) describes as the "Immodest Proposals." Today, the signifiers of porn sexualize mainstream viewing everywhere we look. People seem to asking the creators of the mass media to give us sex at every turn. In the words of Harry Callahan, "Make my day."

References

Attwood, F. (2009). *Mainstream Sex: The Sexualization of Western Culture.* New York: I.B. Tauris.

Bernstein, E. (2007). *Temporarily Yours: Intimacy, Authenticity, and the Commerce of Sex*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Chambers, J. (2006). Taste Matters: Bikinis, Twins, and Catfights in Sexually Oriented Beer Advertising. In T. Reichert & J. Lambiase (Eds), *Sex in Consumer Culture: The Erotic Content of Media and Marketing*, 159-177. Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates.

Derrida, J. (1998). *Of Grammatology*. Translated by G.C. Spivak, *Of Grammatology.* Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press.

Fink, H. J. and Riesner, D. (1971). *Dirty Harry* (unpublished screenplay). 71.

Giannetti, L. (1993). *Understanding Movies*. New Jersey: Prentice Hall.

Gilligan, J. (1996). *Violence: Our Deadly Epidemic and Its Causes*. New York: G.P. Putnam & Sons.

Kaplan, E. A. (1983). *Women and Film: Both Sides of the Camera*. New York: Methuen, Inc.

Kastleman, M.B. (2007). *The Drug of the New Millennium: The Brain Science Behind Internet Pornography Use*. PowerThink Publishing.

Kuhn, A. (1982). *Women's Pictures: Feminism and Cinema*. Boston: Routledge and Kegan Paul.

Kuhn, A. (1985). *The Power of the Image: Essays on Representation and Sexuality*. New York: Routledge and Kegan Paul.

Macdonald, M. (1995). *Representing Women: Myths of Feminity in the Popular Media*. New York: Arnold.

Metz, C. and Taylor, M. (1990). *Film Language: A Semiotics of the Cinema.* Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Mulvey, L. (1988). Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema. In C. Penley (Ed.), *Feminism and Film Theory* (57-68). New York: Routledge.

Myers, K. (1995). Towards A Feminist Erotica. In G. Dines and J. M. Humez (Eds.), *Gender, Race, and Class In Media: A Text Reader* (263-70). London: Sage.

Pardun, C. & Forde, K.R. (2006). Sexual Content of Television Commercials Watched by Early Adolescents. In T. Reichert & J. Lambiase (Eds), *Sex in Consumer Culture: The Erotic Content of Media and Marketing*, 125-139. Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates.

Roberts, V. (2011). Dirty Harry. In P.C. DiMare (Ed.), *Movies in American History*, 130-132. Santa Barbara: ABC-CLIO, LLC.

Shadioan, J. (1974). Dirty Harry: A Defense. *Western Humanities Review, 28*, 165-179.

Skerski, J. (2006). From Sideline to Centerfold: The Sexual Commodification of Female Sportscaters. In T. Reichert & J. Lambiase (Eds), *Sex in Consumer Culture: The Erotic Content of Media and Marketing*, 87-105. Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates.

Slattery, T. (2001). *Immodest Prpoposals: Through the Pornographic Looking Glass*. New York: Writers Club Press.

Williams, L. (1989). *Hardcore: Power, Pleasure, and the "Frenzy of the Visible*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Zimmerman, P. D. (10 January 1972) Review of *Dirty Harry. Newsweek*, 59.

Van Roberts is Associate Professor, Department of Communication, Mississippi University for Women, Mississippi State, USA. He is a noted scholar in film criticism and history. E-mail: *vroberts@as.muw.edu*

Mark Goodman is Professor, Department of Communication, Mississippi State University, Mississippi State, USA. His specialty is media effects, semiotics, and persuasion. E-mail: *mg654460@yahoo.com*

© *Media Watch* 4 (1) 84- 94, 2013
ISSN 0976-0911 e-ISSN 2249-8818

Users' Gratification, Self-Schema and Facebook Behaviour: A Study of Selective Young Facebook Users

SANTOSH K. PATRA
Mudra Institute of Communications Ahmedabad, India
RAHUL GADEKAR
Mudra Institute of Communications Ahmedabad, India
PRADEEP KRISHNATRAY
Pondicherry University, India

Major objective of the present study is to look at the relationship of personality traits of the young Facebook users with their behaviour on Facebook and the gratifications they obtain from Facebook usage. We have measured the gratifications with the help of 16 item scale developed on the basis of review of literature. The Facebook behaviour was measured in terms of number of friends and use of privacy settings on Facebook. The personality trait of users was measured in terms of the self-schema of Separateness-connectedness. A survey questionnaire was administered to the sample of 550 students who came from all over the country to attend the admission process of a well-known communication management school in India. Study concluded that perception of real self always gets reflected in the virtual behaviour of Facebook users. This can be considered as an extension of real self in their virtual behaviour. However, the comparison of the data between real space self-schema with the Facebook friendship behaviour gives more space to understand weather it is a mere extension or a modification in their real perception about their self.

Keywords: New media, internet, facebook, users gratification, self-schema, identity, personality, online behaviour, social media.

The Internet has led the world to new ways of socializing that seem especially to attract young people. Novelty dazzles us. What is new is so striking and unexpected that the old, from which the new springs, is obscured from view. A page from Facebook can strike us a completely novel way of picturing oneself. With the path breaking penetration of the new media, social networking sites have ushered a new era in individual perception about life and society. Social media or web 2.0 technologies is an evolution in the development of social connectivity and is the new buzz word among the youngsters in society. From international friendship to regional

Correspondence to: Santosh K. Patra, Faculty, Mudra Institute of Communications Ahmedabad(MICA), Shela, Ahmedabad 380058, Gujarat, India. E-mail: *santosh@micamail.in.* All rights reserved with Media Watch. For permissions and reprint, please e-mail: *mediawatchjournal@gmail.com*

conversation, the web is moving from a static collection of pages to a more social communication of platform where the word of mouth counts. Social media has become an integral part of online world. Around 82 percent of the world's Internet population age 15 and older that accessed the Internet. One out of every 5 minutes spent online is on a social networking sites (comScore Media Metrix, 2011).

The report of comScore Media Matrix (2010) on the growth of social networking market and respective shares of players in Indian market revealed that more than 33 million internet users who form 84 per cent of the total internet audience, visits social networking sites. The Indian social networking audience grew to 43 per cent in 2010, more than tripling the rate of growth of total internet audience. This report also revealed that among other social networking sites Facebook.com grabbed the number one ranking in the category for the first time in July 2010 with 20.9 million visitors. Face book grew rapidly at 179 per cent in July 2010 and India becomes the fourth fastest growing market for face book.

While providing an alternative space, the social networking sites like face book has given a new nomenclature to the understanding of individual satisfaction in presenting the self. Presentation of self through the user-generated content on the internet, civic engagement and psychological empowerment has received significant interest in recent years due to the phenomenal growth of the social networking sites like face book. While there have been studies which have examined online civic participation and political empowerment the way in which civic engagement offline and content generation online are related to psychological empowerment and presentation of self has not been thoroughly explored (Leung, 2009). This paper is an attempt to explore some of the underlying questions of user's gratifications and presentation of self in online social networking sites. Does user-generated content on the internet facilitate or impede psychological empowerment and presentation of self? In explaining media behaviour and its consequences, examining the objectives and underlying assumptions of uses and gratifications perspectives seems to constitute a good approach for the study of presentation of self in social networking sites. What motivates users to present themselves online by adopting different approaches viz. generating content, sharing pictures and interacting with fellow members and how the gratifications of generating internet content, psychological empowerment and civic engagement affect internet content-generation activities are important research topics.

With the underlying motives to present the self and gratifications derived from the presentation, sites like Facebook provides a platform where young people hang out together, and thus, where much identity work is done. In all identity work, the presentation of self is important. It is by mirroring themselves in the gaze of others that individuals develop a sense of who they are and who they wish to be (Harris, 1998).

"Aspects of self that are accentuated will typically correspond to norms, conventions and ideals that are embraced in the group that the actor belongs to, or wishes to belong to. Thus young people's presentations of self at Facebook have something to say about what norms and ideals look like among young people today (even if it is impossible to talk about young people as one specific and homogenous group). It also has something to say about what norms and ideals prevail at the specific Internet arena, Facebook (Elm, 2007)."

Background and Theoretical Understanding

Wimmer and Dominick (1994) proposed that uses and gratifications began when researchers became interested in why audiences engage in various forms of media behaviour, such as

watching television (Rubin, 1983). Use sand gratifications theory assumes that audience members actively seek out the mass media, fulfil expectations and actively select media and media content to satisfy individual needs. The most important assumption of this approach is that the audience is active and media use is goal-directed. As early as themid-1970s, Rosengren (1974) suggested that certain basic needs interact with personal characteristics, and that the social environment of the individual would produce different motives and gratifications behaviours which could come from using a particular media or other activities (Leung, 2009).

Previous studies of uses and gratifications on computer-mediated communication (CMC) tools include such devices as email, the internet, Short Message Service (SMS, 'texting') and ICQ ('I Seek You'). So far, only a few studies have examined the gratifications or motives associated with user-generated content online. For example, Papacharissi (2003) in his paper presented in Toronto analyzed the content of 150 English-language bloggers and revealed that blog posts were intended for friends or family to fulfil a social utility motivation. In the content analysis of 358 randomly selected front pages of Polish language blogs, researchers explored six major motivations for blogging (ibid): self-expression, social interaction, entertainment, passing the time, information, and professional advancement (Trammell, et al., 2004).

Palmgreen and Rayburn (1979) argued that the primary task facing media research was to integrate the roles played by gratifications and other factors into a general theory of media consumption. To understand the relationship between the motives for internet content generation and the types and amount of content generated online, the concepts of psychological empowerment can be applied to describe how individuals present their 'self and identity' in online social engagements. This media participation may subsequently affect psychological empowerment. However, few of the available published studies on psychological empowerment have examined civic engagement in relation to activities in user-generated internet content.

User Gratifications and Presentation of Self and Identity

Computer mediated identity as with that of real life is socially constructed. However, the 'presence' of identity within virtual spaces is experienced through the technological mediation of the screen. This is a homogenising influence which emphasises particular methods of interaction and, in turn, impacts upon the interpretation and ascription of identities that can be 'virtually' achieved. The construction of computer mediated identity is a fraught position found between the interposed detachment of the screen and the immersive qualities found 'in' virtual space. The articulation of this relationship is an environment of exotic otherness in which interaction is experienced as a distant interchange anchored by the screen (Argyle 1969: 75 as cited in Greenhill, 2009). This is a simulacrum in which layers of meaning electronically overlay, and 'interlay', the 'presence' of space. This exotic configuration apparently provides a disassociation from real life experience which, in turn, enables a rethinking of the social influences that contribute to the construction of identities in both real and virtual lives. Post-structural approaches to interpreting society are particularly suited to the examination of computer mediated identity. The human/machine polarisations claimed for this space imitate the heavily trodden terrain of the mind/body. This dualistic reduction, in turn, produces considerations of power relations as a facet of this single dimension of concern (ibid).

Cyberspace is, through the 'vision' of the Information Superhighway, viewed especially by the mainstream media as a new frontier. Many images have become available in the light of Al Gore's use of the term 'Information Superhighway'. Images such as roads, bridges, networks and areas under construction all suggest a masculinised domain. However, it is difficult to

discern just what sort or scale of gender bias these representations portray. The importance of the use of the mind/body dichotomy in maintaining structural inequalities is evident here. While women are seen to hold a heavily gendered association with the body they will continue to be marginalised in cyberspace and more generally. Equally while it is assumed that masculine attributes provide advantages for the acquisition of knowledge, and by implication the mind, a hierarchical order of male hegemony will be maintained (Farganis 1986, 157). As Greenhill (2009) asserted that cyberspace allows a rethinking of the mind/body dichotomy because the processes of identity formation and sociality move beyond simple ascriptions. The shifting nature and ability to alter one's 'self' in cyberspace forces a reconsideration of the authority and legitimacy of conceptualisation of the mind and body as separable 'things'. The complex interplay of sociality that exists between people is similar, at a generalised level, within this space and those spaces of 'real life'. The difference of cyberspace is evidenced in the differing parameters applied to the construction of identity. The existent notions of identity construction that are associated with 'real life' have been mutually extended, reprioritised and re-crafted. Popular representations of melded mind with machine - the cyborg - even in the most extreme situations do not reflect the experience of computer mediated identity construction.

Users' gratifications and sociability in Facebook in the context of self-schema separateness-connectedness (SC)

In the context of users' gratifications in virtual communication, the present study is an attempt to connect both offline and online persona of young face book users. While many attempts were made to bring users gratifications in different online activities like email, blogging etc., present study is to bring the various aspects of sociability by highlighting major gratifications factors among face book users. To understand the dialogue on online vs. offline community and sociability in online communities, we need to understand the basic ethos that why people hang out in virtual communities. Despite the fact that virtual communities have existed in some fashion for over 25 years, little scholarly research has empirically addressed the reasons why people join virtual communities or choose to remain a patron of one. Indeed, Wellman (1997) specifically calls for research to examine whether online relationships are based on shared interests, similar social characteristics, or the need for frequent communication. Accordingly, the purpose of this exploratory research is to examine, based on first-hand accounts, what are the major gratifications derived by the users by being a member of a virtual community like face book. To bring the offline persona in online social interaction, the concept of self-schema separateness-connectedness would be analysed in the context of users' gratifications in face book. According to Wang and Mowen (1997),

"Self-schema separateness-connectedness (SC) reflects and individual's self-perception in relation to others. A "separated" person has a sense of independence and perceives him/herself as an individual who is distinct from others ("I am me"). The separated person also tends to distinguish himself/herself by making clear boundaries between himself/herself and others as a part of his/her self-identity. A "connected" person has a sense of interdependence and sees himself/herself as continuation of others ("I am a part of others"), or sees others as an extension of the self. The connected person has a greater empathy towards others and view important others as "part" of the self."

The offline separateness-connected persona will be analysed in the context of users' gratifications in virtual social communication. Three major questions will be answered to

understand different gratifications factors among Facebook users in the context of sociability and presentation of self will be derived from the Wang and Mown scale of SC. Following research question will bring the major connection between gratifications factors and presentation of self-schema separateness-connectedness online.

Research Questions

Specifically this paper responds to following research questions:
RQ 1 – What are the gratifications users obtain from using face book?
RQ 2 – What are the personality traits of these users in terms of the self-schema of Separateness-connectedness?
RQ 3 - How self-schema of Separateness-connectedness is related to gratifications?
RQ 4.1 – What is the relationship between self-schema of Separateness-connectedness and use of privacy settings?
RQ 4.2 – How face book behaviour is related to self-schema of Separateness-connectedness?

Method

A major part (53 per cent) of the face book user population of India is consists of youth within the age group of 18 to 25 years (Datta, 2011). Therefore we decided to focus on this age group. The sample of the study consisted of the candidates who were attending the admission process of the one of the top communication and management institutes in India, in the year 2011. These candidates came for the admission process from different parts of the country. Total 550 candidates, who constituted the universe of the study, were administered a survey questionnaire.

A clear announcement regarding the survey study having no relation with the admission process was made at the very beginning of the administration of the questionnaire. Responding to the questionnaire was kept optional. No names and contact details of the students were recorded on the questionnaire. Candidates who are the Facebook users only were asked to fill the questionnaire. After scrutiny, 455 questionnaires were selected for the study.

We measure the gratifications obtained from Facebook use with a 16 item scale, which were derived from review of literature. Each of these items explained a reason of using Facebook. Students were asked to mark their agreement to these reasons on the five point scale of strongly agree to strongly disagree. To study the self-schema of connectedness and separateness, we adopted the nine item scale developed by Wang and Mowen (1997). Student-respondents were asked to rate the nine statements on a 5-point scale collectively describing traits of connectedness and separateness. Higher score on the scale indicated separateness.

We measure the Facebook behaviour of respondents in terms of whether they use privacy settings or not, type of privacy settings used, number of friends on Facebook, number of friends they are regularly are in touch with and number of friends request ignored. Questions asking above information were asked in the administered questionnaire.

Analysis and Findings

RQ. 1 – *What are the gratifications users obtain from using Facebook?*

To find out the gratifications students seek from using Facebook, as part of the questionnaire we administered a gratifications scale containing 16 items. These items described various reasons of using Facebook. Students were asked to mark their responses to each of the item on a five point scale. Factor analysis of student responses revealed foure major gratifications that are obtained from using Facebook: Relationship maintenance, User-friendliness, Relaxation, and Connecting with old friends.

Table 1. Gratifications of using Facebook

Factors	Factor loadings
Factor I Relationship maintenance	
Enable me to see people's status	.795
Allows me to see what my friends are doing	.715
Helps me connect to friends' friends	.639
Helps me share photos and videos	.563
Provides continuous updates on people, news and events	.521
Allows me in expressing opinions	.416
Factor II User-friendliness	
Easy to use	.881
Interface is clean and uncluttered	.845
No extra effort to learn, use	.725
Factor III Relaxation	
Helps me relax	.905
Helps me relieve stress	.889
Provides hours of leisure	.631
Factor IV Connecting with old friends	
Helps me connecting friends far away	.843
Helps me in getting in touch with old friends and colleagues	.787

The most obtained gratifications factor from Facebook use is 'relationship maintenance.' It includes the reasons such as sharing photos with friends, get to know what others are doing and what status message they have put on their profile. Through such activities they maintain their relationship. 'User-friendliness' is the second most obtained gratifications factor. This connotes use-friendliness of the Facebook application. It describes that these students use Facebook because it is very convenient for them to do all the functions on the application, it has very clean and uncluttered interface and they do not feel any difficulty and can use it very easily. This gratifications factor is very similar to what Urista, Dong and Day (2009) have found and called 'Convenient communication.'

The third gratifications factor is 'relaxation.' It explains that using Facebook also serves as a mean to get relief from stress and be relaxed. This factor matches the findings of Krishnatray et al (2009) regarding the gratifications of the Internet use. Fourth factor 'Connecting with friends,' explains that getting connected with friends who are away from home and contact those friends and relatives who were lost or not in touch for a long time, are the most popular reasons why these student users use Facebook.

RQ 2 – *What are the personality traits of these users in terms of the self-schema of Separateness-connectedness?*

We used Wang and Mowen's self-schema separateness-connectedness scale to find out Facebook users' self-perception in relation to others. This scale has nine items describing the Separateness-connectedness in the personality. Respondents were asked to mark their

responses to each of these items on a likert scale of strongly agree to strongly disagree. The descriptive inquiry of all of these personality traits of connectedness and separateness revealed that 67 per cent users prefer to remain cool and do not get excited even when they are surrounded by the excited people. These users (85 per cent) prefer to be like the way they are and are not bothered about what others want them to be alike. 76 per cent stick to their opinions if they think they are right, no matter even if their stand affects their popularity. This shows their independent thinking about themselves. 53 per cent of them feel that they are adult and that means they are independent and distinct of others, whereas 30 per cent prefer to be neutral on this issue. Only 25 per cent users prefer to rely on someone else to solve their problems whereas 46 per cent prefer to solve it on their own rather than relying on someone else. 53 per cent users don't share their private things with others. There is no clear cut pattern in the views of these users regarding statements such as solving problems on their own, keeping clear cut boundary between them and others and getting involved into other people's problems. All these traits indicate that there is a tilt of separateness in the personality of these youth.

RQ 3 – *How self-schema of separateness-connectedness is related to gratifications?*

Using percentiles of 33.33 and 66.66, we divided the respondents in the study according to their perceptions about self-schema in to three categories: low separateness, moderate separateness and high separateness. We compared the two extreme categories of low separateness and high separateness with respect to the gratifications these users obtain from using Facebook. T test revealed significant difference between the respondents with self-perception of low separateness and high separateness with regard to the gratifications factor of relaxation, it was found out that users having low separateness (M = 09.53, SD = 8.79) seek more gratifications than users with high separateness. There is no such significant difference between the two groups with regard to the gratifications of relationship maintenance, user-friendliness of Facebook, and connecting with old friends.

RQ 4.1 – *What is the relationship between self-schema of Separateness-connectedness and use of privacy settings?*

Though not significant, but the data indicate that more users (88.5 per cent) with high separateness use privacy settings on Facebook than the users with moderate separateness (85 per cent) and low separateness (84 per cent).

Table 2. Use of privacy settings

Self-schema	Use privacy settings	Do not use privacy settings	Total
Low Separateness	136 (84.0%)	26 (16.0%)	162 (100.0%)
Moderate Separateness	101 (84.9%)	18 (15.1%)	119 (100.0%)
High Separateness	154 (88.5%)	20 (11.5%)	174 (100.0%)

Most of the users prefer to use customized privacy setting rather than depending upon recommended by the Facebook. The data shows that as the level of separateness increases more users tend to use customized privacy settings (low separateness 78 per cent, moderate

separateness 81 per cent and high separateness 82 per cent). But this change is statistically insignificant.

Table 3. Type of privacy setting used

Self-schema	Recommended	Customised	Total
Low Separateness	30 (21.9%)	107 (78.1%)	137 (100 %)
Moderate Separateness	20 (19.2%)	84 (80.8%)	104 (100%)

RQ.4.2 – *How Facebook behavior is related to self-schema of Separateness-connectedness?*

There is no significant difference between the users of low and high separateness with respect to the number of friends they have on Facebook, number of friends they are in touch with regularly and the number of friends' requests they have ignored. But the descriptive statistics found out some differences between these two groups. It was found out that on average, users with low separateness have 285 friends on Facebook whereas users with high separateness have 291 friends.

Students with low separateness (M = 64.66, SD = 66.92) are regularly in touch with more number of friends than the students with high separateness (M = 61.04, SD = 64.98). In the case of ignoring friends requests on Facebook it was found out that, users with low separateness (M = 63.95, SD = 77.09) ignored more friends' requests than that users with high separateness (M = 51.15, SD = 74.70), on Facebook.

Discussion

Present study is aimed at to understand real and virtual space in the context of Facebook user's behaviour. To understand users behaviour in the virtual space we have consider two major dimensions and attempted to establish the link between virtual behaviour and real self. For the purpose of analysis we would like to compare self-schema of Separateness-connectedness in real space with the virtual behaviour in terms of factors of gratifications. This study attempts to bring real space self-schema and virtual behaviour gratifications of the Facebook users to understand weather there is a real life extension in virtual space with the content and discontent between the real and virtual space.

The virtual space behaviour is majored in terms of gratifications. The factor analysis revealed five major gratifications users obtain from using Facebook: Relationship maintenance, User-friendliness, Relaxation, Connecting with old friends. The most obtained gratifications factor from Facebook use is 'relationship maintenance.' Relationship maintenance in real space is a real space phenomenon and often people judge others in terms of the nature of relationship maintenance. Individual character always gets reflected in the way he/she maintain the social relationship. In the context of the virtual behaviour it is found that relationship maintenance is the most obtained gratifications. It includes the reasons such as sharing photos with friends, get to know what others are doing and what status message they have put on their profile. Relationship maintenance as a factor of gratifications among the Facebook users is followed by user friendliness, relaxation and connecting with old friends. Out of these four factors of gratifications relationship maintenance, relaxation and connecting with old friends can be discussed in the

context of individual's self and personality. These factors bring the relation aspects of an individual in the context of others. We considered these three gratifications factors to discuss in the context of self-schema of an individual in real space. While other gratifications represent the technical aspects of Facebook use. User friendliness as a gratifications factor is relative to individuals own expertise of use.

In the RQ 2 the attempt was made to understand the self-schema of users in real space to understand the spiritedness and connectedness. A descriptive inquiry of the users' personality traits of connectedness and separateness revealed that 67 per cent users prefer to remain cool and do not get excited even when they are surrounded by the excited people. These users (85 per cent) prefer to be like the way they are and are not bothered about what others want them to be alike. 76 per cent stick to their opinions if they think they are right, no matter even if their stand affects their popularity. This shows their independent thinking about themselves. 53 per cent of them feel that they are adult and that means they are independent and distinct of others, whereas 30 per cent prefer to be neutral on this issue. Only 25 per cent users prefer to rely on someone else to solve their problems whereas 46 per cent prefer to solve it on their own rather than relying on someone else. 53 per cent users don't share their private things with others. Using percentiles of 33.33 and 66.66, we divided the respondents in the study according to their perceptions about self-schema in to three categories: low separateness, moderate separateness and high separateness.

However, as per the major objective of the research paper and RQ 3, the relationship between self-schema and gratifications obtained from using Facebook, privacy setting in Facebook and virtual friendship behaviour brings the major question of extension of self in the context of real vs. virtual. The data suggests that the respondents who consider themselves as low separated seek more gratifications of relationship maintenance while using Facebook than users who perceive themselves as high separated. Major findings of the comparison between real self-schema and virtual gratifications also indicates significant difference between the respondents with self-perception of low separateness and high separateness with regard to the gratifications factor of relaxation, it was found out that users having low separateness seek more gratifications than users with high separateness. However this is also important to notice that in other two gratifications cases of relationship maintenance and connecting with old friends it is found that users' perception in real space reflected in their virtual behaviour and also supports the theoretical observation of real space behaviour reflected and get an extension in virtual space.

Similarly in case of privacy settings also we have found that more users (88.5 per cent) with high separateness use privacy settings on Facebook than the users with moderate separateness (85 per cent) and low separateness (84 per cent). Level of separateness increases more users tend to use customized privacy settings (low separateness 78 per cent, moderate separateness 81 per cent and high separateness 82 per cent). Facebook friendship behaviour of users also suggests that users with low separateness have 285 friends on Facebook whereas users with high separateness have 291 friends. Users with low separateness are regularly in touch with more number of friends than the students with high separateness and users with low separateness in the self-schema scale ignored more friends' requests than that user with high separateness in Facebook. It indicates that though the users perceive themselves as highly separated persons than others, their behaviour is no significantly different than low separated users on virtual space of the Facebook. They don't keep themselves away from making friends and getting in touch with them regularly on Facebook. That means though users perceive

themselves as high separated in material world, they make more friends on virtual world of Facebook than the low separateness users.

Conclusion

Findings of the RQ 1, 2 & 3 leads to the RQ 4 of this study on users' perception of self in real space and their behaviour in virtual space or Facebook. The answers of RQ 3 which gives the comparison between users perception of their self in real space with gratifications factors, Facebook friendship behaviour and privacy setting indicates that perception of real self always gets reflected in the virtual behaviour of Facebook users. This can be considered as an extension of real self in their virtual behaviour. However, the comparison of the data between real space self-schema with the Facebook friendship behaviour gives more space to understand weather it is a mere extension or a modification in their real perception about their self. Going back to the theoretical orientation of this present study this is also to note that while providing an alternative space, the social networking sites like Facebook has given a new nomenclature to the understanding of individual satisfaction in presenting the self.

References

ComScore Media Metrix. (2011). It's a Social World: Top 10 Need-to-Knows About Social Networking and Where It's Headed. Accessed from http://www.comscore.com/Press_Events/Presentations_Whitepapers/2011/it_is_a_social_world_top_10_need-to-knows_about_social_networking, on October 18, 2012

Datta, p. (Ed.) (2011). *The Marketing Whitebook 2011-2012*. New Delhi: Businessworld.

Elm, M. S. (2007). 'Young people's presentations of relationships in a Swedish Internet community. *Young, 15*: 145- 167.

Farganis, S. (1986). Feminism and the Reconstruction of Social Science. In Alison Jaggar & Susan Bordo (eds.): *Gender/ Body/ Knowledge,* New Brunswick: Rutgers University Press.

Greenhill, A. (2009). The Social Construction of Computer Mediated Identity. Accessed from www.Spacelessspace.com, on October 18, 2012

Harris, J. R. (1998). *The Nurture Assumption: Why Children Turn Out the Way They Do*. New York: Free Press.

Krishnatray, P., Singh, P., Raghavan, S. & Varma, V. (2009). Gratifications from New Media: Gender Differences in Internet Use in Cybercafes. *Journal of Creative Communications, 4*(1): 19-31.

Leung, L. (2009). User-generated content on the internet: an examination of gratifications, civic engagement and psychological empowerment. *New Media & Society*, *11*(8): 1327-1347.

Palmgreen, P. & Rayburn, J. D. (1979). Uses and Gratifications and Exposure to Public Television: A Discrepancy Approach. *Communication Research, 6*(2): 155–80.

Papacharissi, Z. (2003). The Blogger Revolution: A Uses and Gratifications Study. Paper presented at the Association of Internet Researchers Annual Conference, Toronto, October.

Ridings, C. M. & David G. D. (2004). Virtual Community Attraction: Why People Hang Out Online. *Journal of computer mediated communication (JCMC)*, *10*(1).

Rosengren, K. E. (1974). Uses and gratifications: A paradigm outlined. In J. G. Blumler & E. Katz (Eds.), *The uses of mass communications: Current perspectives on gratifications research.*. Beverly Hills, CA: Sage. pp. 269–286.

Rubin, A. M. (1983). Television uses and gratifications: The interactions of viewing patterns and motivations. *Journal of Broadcasting*, *27*: 37–51.

Trammell, K. D., A. Tarkowski, A. & Hofmokl, J. (2004). 'Republic of Blog' ['Rzeczpospolita blogów']. Paper presented at the 5th Annual Meeting of the Association of Internet Researchers, Brighton, 19–22 September.

Urista, M. A., Dong, Q & Day, K. D. (2009). Explaining Why Young Adults Use MySpace and Facebook Through Uses and Gratifications Theory. *Human Communication*. *12*(2): 215 - 229.

Wang, C. L. & Mowen, J. C. (1997). The separateness-connectedness self-schema: Scale development and application to message construction. *Psychology & Marketing, 14*(2): 185-207.

Wellman, B. (1997). An electronic Group is virtually a social network (g. f. D. library, Trans.). In S. Kiesler (Ed.), Culture of the Internet. Mahawah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates. pp 179-205.

Wimmer, R. D. & Dominick, J. R. (1994). *Mass media research: An introduction*. Belmont, CA: Wadsworth.

Santosh K. Patra is a Faculty in Media area at Mudra Institute of Communications Ahmedbad (MICA), Ahmedbad, Gujarat, India. He holds a Ph.D. from the School of Social Sciences, Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi, India in the areas of Media Sociology. Dr. Patra's research and teaching interests include media and society, new media and social change, governance and development. He has contributed many papers in the areas of media, development and society, governance and public policy, ICT and development communication. E-mail: *santosh@micamail.in*

Rahul Gadekar is Research Associate at Mudra Institute of Communications Ahmedabad, Ahmedbad, Gujarat, India. E-mail: *rahul.micore@micamail.in*

Pradeep Krishnatray is Dean in the School of Media and Communication at Pondicherry University, Pondicheery, India. E-mail: *pradeepkrishnatray@gmail.com*

© *Media Watch* 4 (1) 95- 105, 2013
ISSN 0976-0911 e-ISSN 2249-8818

Developing Media Literacy Practice among Secondary School Students in Malaysia: Case Studies of Video Making on Environmental Issues

N. V. PRASAD
Universiti Sains Malaysia, Malaysia
SHANTHI BALRAJ
Universiti Sains Malaysia, Malaysia

In the present new media world, it is essential for the students to develop a sense of media awareness and activism to facilitate social learning in relation to the surrounding world. In building a productive learning culture among the students, media literacy is a necessary intervention in developing critical understandings, creative abilities, and active participations. Developing media literacy practices among secondary school students on environment is important as the world is becoming less green and the environment is declining. The aim of this study was to examine secondary school students' media literacy practices in Malaysia using the case of video making on environmental issues with a focus on three core components of media literacy practice namely process, text and inquiry developed by Thoman & Jolls (2004). On the whole, the study has revealed that despite difficulties in understanding the environment and critical media inquiry, students are quick to learn and are able to engage in video making on environment in a productive way. However, the results of the study present a cause for concern, optimism and the need for inculcating active media participation of the students' voices on the environmental issues facing the country.

Keywords: Media literacy, video making, environmental issues, secondary students, creativity

The media undoubtedly plays a significant role in conveying and shaping information that people receive and hear (Livingstone, 2002). Information and news about lifestyle, business, education, and government, are made available from almost an infinite amount of sources and with the existence of the internet, access to those information is worldwide. However, problems arise when the credibility of any particular information is questioned. This is increasingly true in the context of the media. For example, the source of information that could be trusted, to understand the difference between news and propaganda, to know the producer of the message and his intended purpose and finally to understand the effect of ownership of media companies on the

Correspondence to*:* N. V. Prasad, Associate Professor, Film & Broadcasting Section, School of Communication, Universiti Sains Malaysia, Penang, Malaysia 11800. E-mail: *prasad@usm.my.* All rights reserved with Media Watch. For permissions and reprint, please e-mail: *mediawatchjournal@gmail.com*

information it produces or relays (Thoman & Jolls, 2005). These few questions, apart from many, all fall under the umbrella term of 'media literacy'.

Students need to understand how to critically assess media content so that they can derive maximum benefit and minimize chances of misinformation (Lim & Nekmat, 2008). If students do not develop a good understanding of the media and their messages then the biggest concern as expressed by Potter (2004, p. 24):

> "Youth may develop misunderstandings and misperceptions about their world. Media is leaving young people to faulty beliefs; either they will accept the beliefs presented to them in the media or they will construct their own beliefs which may be faulty."

Thoman & Jolls (2005) argue that education in new media literacy should cover key questions about the media such as what, where, when, who, and how within the context of media creation, presentation, distribution, and control. Buckingham (2002a) considers media production as an important component of developing new media literacy skills among students. Among the various forms of digital media production available for the students such as still pictures, music, multimedia, web pages and so on, digital video production is considered to be a valuable option as it develops both creative and critical thinking among the students (Buckingham, 2002). For making digital videos, students need production skills such as acting, scripting, directing, audio mixing, editing, graphics and so on which has become an essential skill in this present new media world where students are uploading and downloading various kinds of digital media. Therefore, students should learn production skills not only to appreciate and create media works but also to critically evaluate the messages encountered by them in the new media (Buckingham, 2002). Altogether, it is essential that the present generation of students need to develop their new media literacy skills in the present world.

In Malaysia, the schools have given attention mostly to the curriculum issues rather than on learning skills that are required for the students in this 21st century. Malaysian students without proper training and knowledge in media literacy lacked the critical competency skills to sieve through the enormous information overload in the mass media and Internet (Shanthi & Khoo, 2006). A thorough search of information related to the nation's statements and policies about media literacy in Malaysia reveals that most of the efforts taken by the government so far are in the form of information and language literacy rather than on media literacy.

Commenting on media literacy in Malaysian schools, Shanthi & Khoo (2006, p.1) argue:

> Learning in Malaysia however continues to render visual media study invisible within the formal primary and secondary school settings and there is a clear case for media literacy to be developed in ways that enable young people to comprehend daily life and media experiences critically as well as to engage actively and creatively in the various spheres.

As such, it is apparent that not much effort has been put by either government, media institutions or schools in Malaysia in addressing this issue faced by the student community. Another issue would be, how to develop media literacy skills among the students in Malaysia, where there is hardly any room for introducing media education in the school curriculum. Media scholars such as Potter (2004), Buckingham (2002) & Silverblatt (2007) have developed frameworks for developing new media literacy among the students, however, one of the simplest

and more viable framework comes from Thoman & Jolls (2004) who argue that the characteristics of media literacy practice depends on three core components namely process, text and inquiry.

1. Process- explores the questions that arise when one engages critically with the media.
2. Text- includes any message form – verbal, aural or visual. The basic assumption behind this component is that understanding of a text involves not just deconstruction activities i.e. analysing a message that already exists but also construction activities.
3. Inquiry- is learning to ask important questions about whatever we see, watch or read.

This study was interested in examining new media literacy practices of secondary school students in Malaysia using the case of video making on environment. In the present times, one of the areas that require the immediate attention of the present generation of students is the environment, especially with the world getting less green and the quality of environment declining.

Methodology

The following discussion presents the methodology employed to pursue the objectives of this study. It highlights the various methods employed to collect the data and analysis to examine secondary school students' environment media literacy practices in Malaysia. The methodology applied is a form of action research in that it involves students' doing short video productions on the theme of environment. For this study, both qualitative and quantitative research methods were utilised to collect the data for exploring the core concepts of process, text and inquiry in media literacy practice (Thoman & Jolls, 2004).

Given below are the details of various stages of the research, data collected and measures employed.

1. First, to collect data on how secondary school students approached the concept of 'process' in their media literacy practice, a questionnaire survey and focus group interviews were conducted to understand students views on television programmes in particular environment TV programmes, their media consumption patterns, level of environmental awareness, their views on the influence of television and its representation of environment and their knowledge, attitude and practice towards global environmental issues in Malaysia. Students from selected secondary schools in the states of Penang, Selangor and Sarawak, Malaysia participated in the surveys. Overall, six hundred and sixty two (662) respondents' participated in the survey from various regions of Malaysia.

2. Second, to examine how students approached the concept of 'text', students were asked to make short videos on the topic of the environment. This video production activity provided data to understand students' media literacy skills, their concerns towards environment through the issues raised in their videos and also their level of environmental awareness. The measures applied here were content analysis, focus group interviews and participant observation. A total of twelve (12) short videos on the topic of the environment were produced by groups of students from various secondary schools located in various regions of Malaysia namely Penang, Sarawak and Selangor. New

Media literacy training and production workshops were conducted in the selected schools situated in the above mentioned three states of Malaysia.

3. Thirdly, to collect data on how students approached the concept of 'inquiry' in their media literacy practice, students were asked to show their videos to their peers, teachers and family members and also share it online. Later, data was collected through post-production focus group interviews on students environment video making experience and about sharing the videos with others, which provided data on how they approached the concept of 'Inquiry' in their media literacy practice.

Some conclusions can be drawn from the study on how secondary school students' in Malaysia approached the three core components of media literacy practice. Discussed below are the salient findings related to the components of process, text and inquiry in students' media literacy practices.

Summary of findings related to the component of 'Process' in students' new media literacy practices on environment

'Process' in media literacy refers to the ways one engages with mediated messages (Thoman & Jolls, 2004). It is helpful to note the study focus falls on television and Internet. In this study, 'process' is examined by the following elements such as students' media consumption practices, students' views on television programmes, students' views on television and the environment and students' awareness on environmental issues.

On the whole, the data collected from both survey and focus group interviews indicates that students use television and Internet more for entertainment than for acquiring knowledge and information. Results show that students use internet more for watching videos, downloading and networking, however, it is concerning to note that majority of students don't have any experience in video production activity which has become an essential skill in this 21st century. In addition, the analysis of their views on television during focus group discussions indicates that many of them are viewing television passively without critically analysing the messages, which was quite evident as students were unable to quote any examples of inaccurate or biased representation of the culture or subject matter in any of the programmes. Furthermore, majority of students think news is real and are unable to read the inherent bias in reporting, accuracy of information, any missing viewpoints in the stories and so forth. On the other hand, the positive element noticed was students have faith in the television medium, majority of them think it provides inspiration for learning, understanding and change. And also data analysis reveals that when they identify with the characters and its plots, they are able to learn about themselves and get inspiration from the characters actions.

At the same time, most of the students agree that they learn more about the environment through television and they feel television is a good source for learning about environment and it improves their environmental awareness. In general, the students prefer watching environmental programmes on the global channels rather than the local channels as they find local television programmes on science and environment are monotonous and stereotypical in their presentation. Furthermore, the survey results on environmental awareness reveal that a

large number of students seem to have no opinion or uncertain about their role towards building better and safer environments, but are interested in some of the ways suggested in protecting the environment.

Summary of findings related to the component of 'Text' in students' new media literacy practices on environment

The concept of 'text' refers to deconstruction and construction activities where students present opinions and ideas with multimedia tools (Thoman & Jolls, 2004). To explore how students approached the concept of 'text', data collected in the form of short videos, focus group interviews and participant observation have been analysed to arrive at the findings.

Overall, research participants in their videos emphasised on the responsibility of student community to take care of the environment by practicing pro environmental activities such as water conservation, recycling, energy conservation, no littering and so forth. There are certain common aspects in all the themes, such as the belief that students together can make a difference to the environment, they should be environmentally responsible and students in general are wasting resources like water, energy, paper and so on. On the whole, the students need to change their practices, attitude and behaviour towards environment and there by contribute to the improvement of the environment.

The two main conflicts identified in the videos were both centered on responsibilities. One is being environmentally responsible versus having an easy time and the second is feeling responsible to change their practices towards improving the environment versus not feeling responsible to change. If the narratives are analysed in terms of how the story was told; students seemed to appeal that our environment is in a bad shape and young people are not showing responsibility towards environment and together they need to change and improve the environment.

Some common elements or patterns that were found in their narrative style were students had an intention to demonstrate what is wrong and right with regard to student's behavior towards environment, which was dominant in all their videos. And also text played an important role in their videos; students used text to drive the story forward and used it creatively to attract the attention of the audience to the subject matter. Furthermore, glimpses of creativity could be seen in camera composition, angles, editing and choice of music.

Summary of findings related to the component of 'Inquiry' in Students' new media literacy

Practices on environment

The third core component of quality media literacy practice is 'Inquiry' – "that is learning to ask important questions about whatever you see, watch or read" (Thoman & Jolls, p.24, 2004). 'Inquiry' is an important component; it builds on the understanding of the role of new media in various contexts like caring for the environment as well as developing self-expression necessary for citizenry. 'Inquiry' here involves the understanding that all media messages are constructed with a purpose or motive. 'Inquiry' also involves the understanding of the use of creative languages and production techniques to present points of view about life surrounding us. The following discussion highlights the key findings related to students' views on 'Inquiry' in terms of constructed message, motive of video clips, role of new media and developing self-expression.

Constructed message

Discussing the key benefits of the project, majority of participants said through this training they have learnt that media messages are constructed. In addition, they learnt that making a digital video includes tasks such as operating the camera, shooting, editing, directing, acting and most importantly learnt how to critically analyse a video.

Understanding the constructed nature of the videos, Zen Waei, a research participant From Penang shares:

> "My perception of watching television completely changed after this production, now I can differentiate between the good and bad and whether it is fake or real. What is the purpose of the programme and what they are trying to tell? Overall, I am able to judge the quality of the programmes better now."

A few other responses were like " Last time, I do not know how people produce a video, and now, I know, how they took different shots for making a video, "and, " I thought TV programmes are made at one time in one shot. But after the workshop, I realised that there are lots of shots in the movie."

Similarly, Durga, a research participant expanded by saying:

> "After doing this project, when I watch television now, I know how a video is really taken. They don't shoot continuously and it is made of bits and pieces. They just edit it together later. I learnt about direction, editing, sound mixing and many more. Now, I also know how different camera angles make things more interesting. Things look more familiar to me when I watch now".

Overall, students expressed that the production experience has increased their understanding of the video that the messages are constructed and it is mediated reality. They also expressed that it has developed in them a sense of respect for producers and filmmakers. Most students stated that the workshop has certainly created a sense of better appreciation of the media. They responded like "After doing the production, I have learnt how to appreciate a film better. It needs a lot of hard work and team work," and, "after this project, I see advertisements or movies in a different perspective because I know the way they make it."

Analysis also reveals that students have constructed the messages keeping in mind their target audience for the programme. Most of them said their target audiences for their videos are more specifically younger generation like their fellow community of students.

Motive of video clips

Students expressed that the motive of their videos was to increase the awareness on the environment among the students. The main purpose of their videos is to demonstrate to the audience, how they can make a difference to the environment by saving energy, water and practicing recycling. Most of them said after the project experience they themselves are now curious to know more about the environment by reading books, watching videos and so on. A few of them mentioned that initially, their attitude and commitment towards environment was low, eventually as the project moved on, their interest, attitude and practices towards the environment improved greatly.

As Suvika, a Form IV student from Penang describes:

> "Ever since the project started, there is a strong feeling in us that we have to protect our environment; also we have realized that our planet is now going through a terrible time."

Role of new media

The following student's responses asserted their faith in new media and its influence "media is the fastest and the easiest way to communicate about the importance of the environment to the people", and, "I think the media plays a very important role in changing us. For example, while watching movies if I see someone spoiling or polluting the environment, I feel strongly about it and consider them as bad people". Most of them believe that by using video we can initiate change in people, for example "Yes, I think we can make a difference with the video because it attracts more people than other media like magazines or newspapers".

Bee Chien, a research participant shared her personal experience of the influence of the video in inducing change in oneself:

> "I had watched this Chinese film revolving around three sons and a mother. It shows the family rising from simple to a successful life and then to a downfall. I cried watching the movie as it was very emotional, it really changed my attitude towards my mother and I started to take more care of her."

The process of making the short video taught them media literacy perspectives for example, how the simplest edits in film making can substantially change the meaning and emotional impact of a scene and how the choice of music can make a huge difference in how the audience experiences a character and so on. The editing process, in particular, thought them how constructed all media messages are by learning the choices made by them in selecting the shots and structuring them. In addition, as noticed by Goodman (2010) the process of video production is similar to writing an essay, where students learnt in this project too that making a short video calls for a guiding theme, research, argumentation, editing and revision. Moreover, the video making process enabled the students to collaboratively construct deeper understanding of each other's shared perspectives on global environmental issues of our time (Gauntlett, 1996). On the whole, the process of making the video transformed the students into active users of media rather than passive receivers (Potter, 2005).

When questioned during focus group interviews, whether they will be interested in making such videos again that help heal our planet and our communities, most of them, if given a chance were willing to produce a video on the environment in spite of realising the amount of work involved in producing a video. For example, the following responses convey their views "I think if I have the energy and time, I would do another video because I believe people will receive the message and take it seriously", "I would like to make a video like that again because when younger generation like us make a video like that, the older generation will be attracted and will follow". However, two participants answered negatively like "I think I will not do it again, because my interest is in other field", "I won't be interested in production again, I don't have time and I am busy in studies."

Thoman & Jolls (2005) argue that media production activity provides students new learning environment as opposed to traditional learning environment by making it student centered, collaborative, multimedia based, inquiry based, exploratory, proactive action, authentic and

providing real world context. The learning by doing in this study helped the students to explore the different ways to support sustainability. Overall, students expressed that new media is a good channel for communicating messages about the environment. They strongly believe that through video change can be brought about in student's behaviour and attitude towards the environment.

Developing self-expression

The environment media literacy project experience helped students to say what they mean or want to say about the environmental issues to their community of students. They were able to speak out their minds and express their inner feelings through performance, text, visuals, creative techniques and music. In that way, the experience provided students to develop their self – expression as discussed below.

Developing performance skills among students

It was noticed that students' developed performance skills before the camera while filming the video. Besides gathering understanding of the technicalities of a video shooting and the role of the actors and crew, students acting before the camera in the study had the opportunity to watch themselves on screen and reflect on their performance. Talking about their performance, one of the participants expressed that 'acting before the camera helped me overcome my fear and shyness'. Similarly, it was noticed during the shooting, students viewed their acting in playback and observed any facial or physical action needing correction. In that way, the experience provided scope for nurturing their performance skills and interaction among the students.

Through action rehearsal, recording and playback, students developed crucial skills for working before the camera. Although acting before the camera was a difficult process for young students, the participants in the study slowly accustomed to facing the camera and contributed their part. Many of them told they were excited and eager to act before the camera. Like, it was expressed by this student "When people are looking at our production, I feel very happy and proud because I acted in that video". In short, the study apart from engaging the students truly with the topic also provided scope for them to develop performance skills.

Builds understanding on creative techniques

Students in this project boost their creative self-expression by understanding and learning creative production techniques employed in the video making. The study promoted students' creativity by involving their mental and emotional aspects of their personality (Buckingham, 2002). The media making experience enabled students to combine their creative impulses and thoughts based on their own real world experience to produce a short video that combines visual, sound, music, graphics and text in a creative way (Gauntlett, 1996). If we examine the videos produced by the students in this project, audience are able to sense the element of novelty and worthiness in their works. Especially, creative elements were found in camera angles, designing text, editing, make up, costume and combining music.

In this project, the creation of narrative for their short video itself is a creative design process as it involved particular way of telling a story by representing events, people and objects (Mulholland & Collins, 2002). Likewise, Becta (2002) argues that digital video significantly improves the motivation and interest of the students and encourages self-expression and creativity. Some of the aspects of creativity noticed in student videos are breaking away from conventional practice with regard to visual composition, structure of the story, generating

the concepts and so on. Even the process of generating an idea for students' video involves creative element, especially the visualisation of the action demanded creative thinking among the students. According to Goodman (2010) students' exploration of the subject matter for making the video, which involves the skills of assessing, examining and interpreting, is also part of a creative process. Even finding solutions to the problems highlighted on environmental issues could be considered as an aspect of creativity.

Builds empowerment among students

Empowerment is another aspect, which boosts students' self-expression in this project. Students being able to create their own media messages about the theme of environment in this study is empowering to them. In addition, the development of new media literacy skills among students also paved the way for empowerment. According to Page & Czuba (1999, p.1) empowerment is "… multidimensional social process that helps people gain control over their own lives. It is a process that fosters power in people for use in their own lives, their communities and in their society, by acting on issues they define as important…" In this case study, students talked about environmental issues that are relevant to them and expressed through their videos on how student community can change their attitudes, beliefs and practices towards environmental issues. In that way, the study empowered them to decide on the topic they would like to talk about and discuss freely regarding the issues relevant to them.

Scholars (Potter, 2005 & Buckingham, 2002) of media literacy argue that to achieve empowerment in media, students need to develop their critical thinking skills. Students in this study questioned themselves critically about their practices towards the environment, their environment media consumption and put into action their thoughts and ideas on environment through digital videos to their community of students. In that way, students tried to influence change in their peer group and felt a sense of empowerment.

Conclusion

Altogether, the study's findings on process, text and inquiry suggest that students in Malaysia need to improve their media literacy practices especially on the components of process and inquiry. Even though, students did reasonably well on the component of text, it is still essential to develop their media literacy practices in the present media world, which is diverse, complex and rapidly changing. As pointed out earlier, considerable level of media literacy is essential for students in this 21st century, where literacy means more than basic reading, writing, and computing skills, rather it means knowing how to use knowledge and skills in the context of modern life (Partnership for 21st Century Skills, 2003).

A more meaningful and productive awareness on our daily practices and the environment was established when the students made short video programmes and shared them with others. More critically, this also marks a change in the students' media cultures where they progress from a 'sit-back-and-be-told culture' to more of a 'making-and-doing culture' (Gauntlett, 1996). This can be seen in the shift from television-watching to the more creative uses of interactive media, and also more broadly and in growing calls for change in the school education system (from a learning-for-tests culture to one which emphasizes creativity, questioning and exploration). Indeed bigger policies and government action on a big scale are critical in developing creative learning cultures anchored in media literacy. But government need to be persuaded that the students are willing to be flexible and make lifestyle changes in order to save the planet, which is also a challenge to be solved creatively. Creating and making media programmes can open up new perspectives, and reflecting upon things that we take for granted in our simple everyday lives and suggesting new ideas and ways of doing things.

Most importantly, the study has demonstrated that secondary schools can apply new media literacy practices such as this on other issues students face such as drugs, violence and children's rights and so on; which will provide learning opportunities and foster active community engagement (Buckingham ,2002). The study has shown how media literacy on environment could help in producing groups of student communities who share similar thoughts, information and values with regard to the theme of environment. These student groups in turn may inspire other students from their class to participate and produce knowledge and share among their community. There are many frameworks available for developing new media literacy among students; in this case study, one such possibility is explored. Hope this research, inspires other educators, researchers to take up similar action-research projects in the future.

References

Abu Bakar, R (2010). Country Report on Information Access and Media and Information Literacy: Malaysia. Publisher: National Library of Malaysia.

Becta, (2002). Becta (British Educational Communications Agency)

Buckingham, D (2002). *The Electronic Generation? Children and New Media*. Manchester: Manchester University Press.

Buckingham, D (2007). Media Literacy Goes Digital: An Introduction to Learning, Media and Technology, Vol 32, No.2, pp. 111-119, Taylor & Francis – Routledge.

Centre for Media Literacy (2008). Literacy for the 21st Century: An Overview & Orientation Guide to Media Literacy Education. Retrieved on April 12, 2008 from http:// www.medialit.org/pdf/mlk/01a_mlkorientation_rev2.pdf.

Considine, D.M (2002). Media Literacy Across the Curriculum, Retrieved August 23 , 2009 from http:// www. medialit.org/ reading_room/pdf/ 551_cicmlconsidine.pdf.

Gauntlett, David (1996). Video *Critical: Children, the Environment and Media Power*, John Libbey Media, Luton.

Gauntlett, David (1998). Losing Sight of the Ball? : Children, Media and the Environment in a Video Research Project, International Broadcasting Symposium, University of Manchester.

Gauntlett, David (2000) *Web. Studies: Rewiring Media Studies for the Digital Age*, Arnold Edward.

Goodman, S (2010). High- Needs School: Preparing Teachers for Today's World, toward 21st-Century Literacy and Civic Engagement: Facilitating Student Documentary Projects, Bank Street College of Education.

Hobbs, R (1998). The Seven Great Debates in the Media Literacy Movement, *Journal of Communication,* 48(1), 16-32.

Lee, K (2008). Making Environmental Communications Meaningful to Female Adolescents. A Study in Hong kong, *Science Communication*, Vol 30, No 2, pp 147-176, Sage Publications.

Lim, S.S & Nekmat, E (2008). Learning Through 'Promising': Insights from Media Literacy Programmes in Asia, Science Technology & Society. Retrieved on July 23, 2009 from http://sts, sagepub.com/content/13/2/259.

Livingstone, S (2002). *Young People and New Media.* Thousand Oaks: Sage.

Masterman, L (1985). *Teaching the Media*, London: Comedia.

Mulholland, P & Collins T., (2002) Using Digital Narratives to Support the Collaborative Learning and Exploration of Cultural Heritage. Proceedings of the 13th International Workshop on Database and Expert Systems Applications. (Dexa'02)

Page, N & Czuba, C, E (1999). Empowerment: What Is It? *Journal of Extension*, October 1999 Vol. 37 No. 5 www.joe.org

Partnership for 21st Century Skills (2003). Learning for the 21st century: A report and mile guide for 21st century skills. Washington, DC: Author. Retrieved on March 14, 2011 from http://www.21stcenturyskills.org.

Potter, W.J (2004). *Theory of Media Literacy: A cognitive Approach*. Thousand Oaks: Sage.

Potter, W.J (2005). *Media Literacy*. (Third Edition) Thousand Oaks: Sage.

Shanthi, B & Khoo Seok Wah (2006). Voices for Change: Media Literacy and a Case Study on Designing of Opportunities for Learning Internet Radio in Malaysia. *Media Asia* Vol 33 No.1&2, pp 87-98.

Shanthi, B and Prasad N.V (2007) Young People and Media Making - Engaging Secondary School Students in Critical Media Literacy, *Wacana Seni*, *Journal of Arts Discourse*.Jil/ Vol.6.2007

Silverblatt, A (2007). Media Literacy: A Survival Skill, St Loius Journalism Review.

Singer, D.G., & Singer, J. L. (2001) *Handbook of Children and the Media*. Thousand Oaks: Sage Publications.

Thoman, E & Jolls, T. (2004). Media literacy - A National Priority for a Changing World. *American Behavioral Scientist, 48*, pp 18-29.

Thoman, E & Jolls,T (2005). Literacy for the 21st Century: An Overview & Orientation Guide To Media Literacy Education. California: Center for Media Literacy Publications.

N. V. Prasad is Associate Professor and Chairperson in the School of Communication at Universiti Sains, Penang, Malaysia. He teaches courses in film and broadcasting. His current areas of interest and research are media literacy, television production, audience studies and environment communication. E-mail: *prasad@usm.my*

Shanthi Balraj is Associate Professor in the School of Arts at Universiti Sains Malaysia, Penang, Malaysia. She has conducted numerous workshops on media literacy and the reporting of news on children and women for both national and international broadcasters. She is currently working on several projects, which include Enhancing science literacy among secondary school students in Malaysia; Malaysian children, television and environment literacy; Young people and new media–Social uses, social shaping and social consequences. E-mail: *shanty@usm.my*

© *Media Watch* 4 (1) 106- 116, 2013
ISSN 0976-0911 e-ISSN 2249-8818

Newspaper Supplements of Metropolitan City Publications: A Case Study of two Indian News Dailies

JYOTI RAGHAVAN
Kamala Nehru College, Delhi University, India

This article seeks to explore the narratives on metropolitan cities that appear in the supplements of the English language newspapers of India. The positioning of the city in these newspaper supplements predominantly projects the lifestyles of the rich and the famous, with an overt emphasis on a culture of conspicuous consumption. This is being thrust upon the public day after day. These supplements with their emphasis on gloss, glamour, gossip, and entertainment are predominantly projecting a high-end lifestyle, aiding and abetting the quest for affluence in the minds of the readers. Commercial interests are influencing the way news about the city is selected and written about in these daily supplements, resulting increasingly in the focus on issues considered by some to be of little worth culturally or socially. It is argued that there is a disconnect between the narratives on the city in newspaper supplements and public perceptions of the same.

Keywords: Newspaper supplements, political economy of news, agenda-setting

Following economic liberalization in the eighties, newspapers in India have not only witnessed phenomenal growth but they are covering more subjects and have added more pages to various sections. They have brought in supplements because the main paper cannot carry too many advertisements. Added to this has been the changing readership interest and demand for news on more subjects which the main paper cannot accommodate due to lack of column space, which has resulted in publishing of the supplements. According to Mukund Padmanabhan, City Editor, *Metroplus*, 'In 1990s with the opening up of the economy in India, new lifestyles and work cultures emerged. This was akin to what had happened a decade ago in the West when the yuppie culture emerged. Sunday supplements gathered huge popularity as the weekend was the only leisure time after a week's worth of hard work for these new age businessmen. A similar trend was on in India'.

Symbolic Cultural Representation of the City

Urban sociological studies examine the city through several characteristics such as density of population, occupation, environment, stratification, mobility, social differentiation, size of the community et al. These studies, besides focusing upon the material development of the urban built environment of cities are also highlighting the city through cultural symbols and themes

Correspondence to: Jyoti Raghavan, Department of Journalism, Kamala Nehru College, University of Delhi, India. E-mail: *jyoti_raghavan@hotmail.com.* All rights reserved with Media Watch. For permissions and reprint, please e-mail: *mediawatchjournal@gmail.com*

that inundate the modern city. The city is looked at in terms of several themes, motifs, floating signifiers and spectacles like events, leisure and cultural activities which have come to play a significant part in urban life. Symbols, images and other forms of verbal and visual representations define the city in a particular way in the newspaper supplements. 'Lifestyle magazines and consumer columns of the daily newspapers open a window to a rarified view of the city, that of boutiques, restaurants and other specialized sites of consumption, making ordinary people more aware of the elites' cultural consumption. The high visibility of spokespersons, stars and stylists for culture industries underlines the up-market quality of culture as a motor of economic growth' (Zukin, 2005, p. 285).

We now turn to the symbolic narratives of the city which are published in these newspaper supplements. Writing about the city, these supplements can ideally provide the readers with a vast array of subjects, ranging from the city's infrastructure, to its development, to a range of social and civic issues, to its places of interest, its cultural vibrancy and last but not the least, the people who make up the city. "The newspaper particularly is tied functionally and symbolically to conceptions of place and describes characteristic inflections of the narrative of city life" (Parisi & Holcomb, 1994). An important attribute of urbanization is that the culture and values of the city become dominant in the entire society. "Culture is the constant process of producing meanings of and from our social experience" (Fiske, 2011, p.1). Cities are landscapes of cultural diversity and sub-cultural differentiation, what Robert Park (1925) called a 'mosaic of social worlds'.

This brings on the main question of what narratives of the city do we get to see in the newspaper supplements today. A study of the city-based newspaper supplements that accompany some of the largest circulating English language national dailies of the country, reveal a one-sided image of the city. The article seeks to examine the news content of these supplements. It seeks to explore what image of the city these supplements want to create in the public's mind. It also tries to examine if journalists covering the city supplements face any pressures that force them to select or construct the news content in a particular way.

Methodology

The methodology used for this study involved a qualitative analysis of the news content of the City supplements brought out by two English language newspapers in Delhi—from February, 2012 to April, 2012. Interviews were also conducted with four journalists who have worked for these publications to get insights into the way news content for these supplements is selected and represented for the readers. The serious look of the host newspapers is in sharp contrast to the flippant and garish look of the supplements brought out by the main publications, which has a bearing on the paper's credibility. Advocates of the journalism's agenda-setting role assert a direct causal relationship between journalistic content of the media and subsequent public perceptions of what are the important issues of the day. Studies by the Glasgow Media Group indicate that news productions are inevitably and normally the result of selection, interpretation and are therefore biased. There is a good deal of analysis by the Glasgow Media Group (1980) which lends support to the critical interpretation of how and why news is the way it is.

Allan Bell (1991) emphasizes that journalists and editors produce news stories not articles. These stories have a viewpoint, values and structure that can be analyzed. A good deal of critical content analysis of news interprets evidence of deviations of representation from reality in terms of ideology and manipulation by dominant social classes as is evident in both the newspapers under study -*Delhi Times* and *HT City* supplements. News, as it exists is not an

objective reality and news simply would not exist without the media. This research analysis points out that the reported events are considered important by the public only if they are presented by the media as being important news in the first place. This lends credence to the agenda-setting approach which explains that the media sets the agenda through selective framing of news and constructs a partial account of reality which then becomes the agenda for the public. Over time, the press agenda also becomes the peoples' agenda and public opinion gets formed. In depth interviews were conducted with twenty readers of the city supplements to find out what impact the symbolic cultural narratives of the city projected in these newspaper supplements had upon them. The interviews help to establish how the Press agenda impacts upon public perceptions.

Qualitative Analysis of *HT City* and *Delhi Times*

The quintessence of the city captured by newspaper supplements today is revealed from the following advertisements for *HT City* and *Delhi Times* in the *Hindustan Times* and *Times Group* websites, respectively which clearly showcase the kinds of symbolic cultural narratives of the city that these supplements seek to project. *HT City* and *Delhi Times* have been selected for this study since these two newspaper supplements are the most widely circulated in the country. The Indian Readership Survey (IRS) 2012 reveals that *HT City* has a readership of 37.67 lakhs, placing it as the second most widely read English newspaper in India after *Delhi Times* brought out by *The Times of India*.

The Hindustan Times reader wakes up to a bundle of fun, frolic, entertainment and masala everyday called *HT City* (in Delhi) and *HT Cafe* (in Mumbai). One of the strongest drivers of readership, the daily entertainment supplement enjoys almost universal salience and readership. The buzzy daily supplement has redefined lifestyle and entertainment space in newspapers, packing a punch with daily dose of Bollywood, Hollywood, Fashion, Relationship, City and Campus. (HT Media online)

In 1994, *The Times of India* took a bold step at experimenting with not just news, but something which was more. The resultant was a supplement –*Bombay Times* – which broke the mould when it came to capturing the latest about what's happening in and around the city in a package that captured the essence of the city – its people, culture, fashion, art, theatre, sports, films, and private and public social gatherings. (Times Group Website)

The positioning of the 'city' for these city-based news supplements is apparent from their above description with the emphasis being on gloss, glamour and punch predominantly projecting the lifestyles of the rich and famous and not the common man. Instead of functioning in a manner that ensures equality among the readers, these supplements have only contributed towards driving a division in the class structure of society. *The Hindu* newspaper also brings out a daily newspaper supplement called *Metro Plus*. This supplement also covers the city but its news content stands out in sharp contrast to some of the other supplements. According to Padmanabhan (2009) of *The Hindu*, "the inaugural issues and those that followed laid the foundation for this supplement by engaging their respective cities in their totality, dealing with subjects such as lifestyle, culture, heritage, fashion and food, and lending another dimension to the newspaper's overall coverage. The paper offers informative news on lighter subjects and does not contain any gossip nor Page 3 content."

This research study examined the daily news content of the supplements of *The Times of India* and *Hindustan Times* and the qualitative analysis of the news content of these two supplements shows that the print media have increasingly shifted from the serious and genuine

concerns affecting society to focus largely on the trivial. Donn (2003) has described this as 'the dumbing down effect'. Dumbing down in the case of news supplement content is reflected in the overdose of subjects pertaining to consumerism, entertainment and lifestyles – promoting materialism and false values. As Donn (2003) states, the dumbing down effect points to a variety of different things such as a decline in creativity and innovation, a degradation of artistic, cultural, and intellectual standards, and the trivialization of cultural, artistic, journalistic and academic creations. Donn (ibid) further describes dumbing down as a process where complex issues are simplified to excess, with it all boiling down to an issue or event being portrayed as either wrong or right and very little in the way of analysis being offered. It also refers to the focus on issues considered by some to be of little worth culturally or socially. As Justice Ray (2006) has pointed out: "The page 3 culture can make people live in a make-believe world and as a result, instead of journalism connecting people, it may result in the people losing touch with reality being connected through the media. Media has created its own world of glamour, gossip, sex and sensation that has played a major role in distracting attention from the real issues of our times. Tabloidization is a shift by the media away from national and international issues of importance to a more entertainment or gossipy style of journalism that focuses on "Lifestyle, celebrity, entertainment and crime/scandal."

Though the daily news supplements in this study have been examined here for a three-month period, this dumbing-down effect has been a noticeable trend throughout the period of existence of these supplements - from inception till date. The criteria deployed for news selectivity which selectively turns news into a manufactured product and thereby into a manufactured account of reality, will be discussed in the course of this article while discussing a theoretical overview of the daily news process.

The trivialization of news content has a far-reaching impact given the sheer size of the readership of these publications. Among various forms of print media, newspaper dailies are driving reach growth, which has increased by 12.8 per cent, reports exchange4media.com (2009). The growth of reach of newspaper dailies is closely related to the increase in the number of literates: from 2005 to 2008 it has increased from 277,900,000 to 313,400,000. Most of the city supplements, vying for the largest share of readership, share uniformity in terms of news presentation and coverage. In the rat-race to grab a larger share of the market, each publication is trying to out-do the other by offering a plethora of colour supplements. But this has resulted in each newspaper, dishing out the same fare, albeit with a different nomenclature. Thus these newspaper supplements look almost the same with each claiming to be the market leader. The fare offered is seven days of materialistic splash through advertisements, product allurements and entertainment news to lure the public into hedonistic pleasures. This constitutes the major chunk of newspaper supplement content today, none of which provides the reader with much food for thought. The commercial approach of the media has reduced newspapers to trivia and lowered their informational quality. The average city dweller has only a casual interest in news in general and spends only a few minutes every day perusing these dailies. His attention is further distracted from serious news stories by the colourful supplements carrying advertisements of a wide range of household goods and gadgets, designer wear and filmy gossips deliberately interspersed with pictures of scantily clad fashion models. As Veblen (1899) wrote in his book, The Theory of the Leisure Class, "advertisements and news content focuses upon promoting conspicuous consumption that is meant not to satisfy any physical need, but rather to gratify the psychological craving for status or the esteem of others."

There is an over-representation in the print media of the 'social top' or of elites both in terms of coverage and as sources of news. These daily newspaper supplements in the city

today are vying with each other in representing the nouveau riche or upper crust of society in their Page-3 sections. Nayyar (2009) explains 'celebrity ecology' to understand the Page 3 culture of India stating the celebrities are transformed by the media into consumer products that are manufactured, packaged and sold to adoring audiences that are always thirsty for spectacles that pique their imagination and dazzle their lives. He looks at the frames for interpreting celebrity page 3 people from newspapers, tabloids, gossip magazines etc. which set the reader thinking about scandals and famous bodies, fashion and spectacles involving hyper-visible and ultra recognizable faces.

The assumptions about the 'City' in both *Delhi Times* and *HT City* as showcased by the two supplements comprise fun, frolic, entertainment and *masala.* Examples of the nature of the news content in these supplements are cited below.

Celebrate Valentine's Day—The E-Way: *Electronics seem to be the number one choice as a gift item these days. By choosing swanky and useful electronic gadgets for your Valentine, you can send out a message of love and compatibility - Delhi Times* (February 12, 2012)

Holiday Videshi , but Khaana Desi: Daal makhani in Beijing or chicken tikka in Tanzania – for the desi food lover, international holiday destinations have learnt to add the tadka to woo Indians tourists who love their sabzi-roti quite a bit (*Delhi Times,* March 21, 2012)

Vikram Chatwal flaunts his tattoos for HT City. He has 12 tattoos, including daughter Safira's name, Sikh expression 'Waheguru', the cross, and a scorpion (*HT City April* 12, 2012)

'Ranbir's mother cuts his toenails' (2 Nov 2011, HT City)

The above examples of news content cited from the newspaper supplements bring us to the moot question of why the leading national dailies have trivialized and dumbed-down supplement news content.

Commercial Pressures

One of the prime causes for the trivialized representations of the city can be attributed to commercialization of the media. An aggressive marketing drive has overtaken the Indian print media making the 'fifth estate' subservient to the forces of commercialization. The post-Independence decades of Indian journalism point to the fact that the commodification of news, engendered by market forces has assumed greater propensity since the eighties and today is being carried to the point of aggressive hard sell. The last two decades post-liberalization have seen more changes in the media scene than the earlier decades immediately after Independence. Advertisers have responded more than adequately catering to both the electronic and print media. The leading dailies of the metros carry supplements devoted entirely to advertisements. The Times of India Group accounts for 30 per cent of the measured advertisement spend in the country. (Times Group website). The website states that it is 'the only media house to give advertisers maximum value for their money and minimum wastage'. The range of publications, each with its own specific target audience, helps advertising managers plan the ideal media mix, optimizing the advertising budget. *The Hindustan Times* financial performance in 2011

reveals a 27 per cent increase in advertising revenues of print segment to 3,699 million rupees from 2,908 million rupees driven by volume growth and improvement in price realization. (HT Website).

Commercialization spawns competition. In such a competitive commercial rat race between newspapers, qualitative journalism and news dissemination are bound to receive secondary attention from the owners of these publications. The political economy approach of the Western media that commercial pressure is exerted upon journalistic freedom finds its echo in the Indian news context and we see its applicability to the newspaper supplements under study here. The political economy also referred to by Chomsky as the propaganda model, operating in the Indian media context, is ratified by Chowdhry (2010) who argues that "… the everyday quotidian features and news that inscribe corporate speech, create a new imaginary of a global Indian and a global Indian middle class." The liberalization driven market economy framework upon which the media operates has resulted in the creation of the news frame of a global Indian identity for India's middle class. "The print media has undergone some revolutionary changes in style of management moving from being a family-owned enterprise to becoming a corporatized industry with its focus on profit margins" (Rodrigues, 2010).

Another factor impacting the Indian print media is the arrival of satellite technology which has resulted in the proliferation of media channels, particularly television. This has had its effect on the print media which has implemented several strategies to keep pace with the competition from television channels. With more supplements in newspapers catering to diverse readership tastes, the print media is catering to niche audiences. The print media management has implemented a number of strategies to cash in on the increasing literacy and purchasing power of the Indian consumer. The print media has continued to grow in India despite the competition from television and net users primarily because of the peoples' urge for more and reliable information. However, there are claims that the distinction between editorial and marketing departments is vanishing, resulting in downgrading and devaluing news, analysis and public affairs information provided by newspapers (Rodrigues, 2006, p.64). The Press Council of India points out that during 2008, advertisements accounted for more than 65 per cent of newspaper revenue for most of the English dailies. This has had an impact on daily news content. "There are tendencies of hyper-commercialization, which tackles the newspaper and its journalism more or less like any other commodity or 'product' and see any higher ground vision as old-fashioned, sanctimonious humbug (Rodrigues, 2006, p. 64). The aggressive strategy of selling more copies has had an impact on the quality and credibility of journalism. Some commentators are critical of the media strategy of 'dumbing down' news content to attract new readers in rural and less-educated segments of the population.' The Page 3 idea, emphasis on sports coverage, the dumbing down of stories which are covered with a lot of violence, crime, rape rather than social stories – all of these are some of the things the newspapers are doing to make them more attractive and to get new readers. It remains one powerful and effective means for advertisers to reach their audience.

A journalist interviewed for this study pointed out: The supplements aim at a target group that is young, aspirational with the idea of having access to good life or aspiring for a good life, a generation that wants to own big brands in their lifestyle. The editors of the city supplement advise their journalists never to aim at a low-end audience but to a high-end audience or those who aspire to be high-end. So even if an article is about perfumes, they will only talk about high-end stuff, expensive, luxury brands. They write content to attract advertisers. For example, an auto-beat page in the news supplement would bring in more advertisements on

cars and bikes. First the advertisement space is marked out and then the left-over space is allocated for news content. For the college crowd the articles focus on subjects like street-fashion that is funky.

Another journalist from a city supplement who was interviewed for this study said that the supplement aimed at the young target readership of 25 -27 years. In order to appeal to this group, the content of the supplement centered on 'entertainment, lifestyle and my city'. The journalist said that stories about stars and celebrities, products and services to buy and enjoy, places to hangout, habits of Delhi-ites form the staple content of these publications, all aimed at appealing to the youth. Journalists admit that advertisements often take up more space in the supplement leaving less column space for news content. Page-3 parties that are frequented by politicians, bureaucrats, film stars and the rich and famous are assiduously followed by the journalists of the publication. To a question on how the supplements were any different from a tabloid – the journalist said that these were entertainment and lifestyle supplements and refrained from calling them tabloids. However, a woman journalist in her interview said that neither *HT City* nor *Delhi Times* were tabloids as the two publications never write news in an irreverential style which is typical of tabloids. Though gossip and sensationalism are the staple diet of tabloids, the journalist admitted that some amount of such content is selected for the supplement since readers want such kinds of news.

The findings that emerge from the interviews with the journalists reinforce the propaganda model view that the media serve the interests of the state and corporate power, framing their reporting and analysis to suit the interests of the established privileged in society. Schudson (2003) Journalists construct their narratives around their own values and beliefs, but these are necessarily informed by contributions of a wide range of information sources, who thus acquire the power to become 'definers' of journalistic reality. According to Gans (1980) news sources also have the power both to supply information that makes news and to exert pressure. According to him, if a handful of factors have to be singled out for the explanation of news, then those governing choice of news sources is of prime significance. These news sources have the power both to supply information that makes news and to exert pressure. The media are structurally biased towards the very powerful and privileged sources and give access to those who enjoy accreditation. The news media representations of the city are by and large capturing and representing only the rich, the elite and the powerful and newspapers have become a class medium.

It is the Page-3 culture that is most visible in majority of the newspaper supplements. There is almost nil coverage of any other aspect of city life. As Castellis (1989) points out that the special form of a city is very much influenced by the politico-economic considerations of corporations, business houses and governments. This has also had its impact upon the way the newspaper publications are run and prove that commercial interests are largely dictating selection of content in these news publications resulting increasingly in the 'dumbing down' of news content. According to Rao (2010), marketing pressures, the tabloidization of news, and management and economic pressures are affecting journalism ethics and issues such as accountability, independence, and conflict of interests. According to P. Sainath (1996) there is very little development news in most of the media today. Most of the focus is on political events, scandals and gossip which do not in any manner contribute to educating the public.

The colour picture supplements with "Page 3" meet the requirement of both the patrons and clients. They can bring in everything - Publicity for products - without even raising an eyebrow. Exaggerated pressures from the television/satellite channels are used as a pretext by

print media for supposed felt need propelled by competition for further trivialization of news columns which, in turn, encourage crass commercialization (Ray, 2006).

Public Perceptions

'The content of circulating representations is highly controlled and monitored in these newspaper supplements. The content is absorbed by an audience, whose nature, demographics and desires cannot always be predicted.' (Nayyar, 2009, p. 181). The impact is to be studied in terms of the kind of value system being promoted by the news supplements and absorbed by the audience. The interviews with the audience revealed that the audience takes these supplements lightly and are not enticed by the kind of aspirational lifestyle of luxuries and conspicuous consumption that the supplements are trying to promote. The excerpts of the interviews are presented below:

'It functions as a mere window to the outrageous lifestyle, the common man is not aware of. However it also reflects upon the capabilities for us to indulge in luxuries at our own affordable comfort.'

'The supplements are entertaining but do encourage immense consumerism. Also, there seems to be an obsession with good looking stuff. It caters majorly to the upper class. There should be less focus on celeb controversies!'

'They give a skewed image of lifestyles that are often vulgarly ostentatious and make little sense for anyone even to aspire for them.'

On Page 3 celebrities, some of the audience reactions were:

'…… news holes are filled with celeb gossip and unverified here-say and twitter chatter.'

'It caters majorly to the upper class. There should be less focus on celeb controversies!'

'The intelligent youth sees through the falsity and pretension underlying these Page 3 celebrities and their lifestyles while for the rest the appeal is limited to idle browsing.'

'Their reportage of celebrity escapades, fashion, page 3 etc may appear to trivialize the news, but it is in that that their inherent appeal lies.'

All the persons interviewed were aware of the conspicuous consumption that the supplements endeavour to promote, that they catered to the upper class, and present lifestyles that are not in any way connected with the common man. They said that the newspaper supplements at best serve the purpose of helping to unwind but were not to be taken seriously.

Public Perception Vs. Journalists' Projection

The analysis of the news content, interviews with journalists and public reactions clearly reveal a disconnect between the symbolic cultural representations of the city as projected in Newspaper supplements and public perceptions of the same. While gloss, glamour, celebrity gossip, luxury lifestyles and a culture of conspicuous consumption form the staple symbolic cultural narratives on the city in the newspaper supplements, the public are not fooled into believing in these

symbolic representations, as revealed from the interview findings. 74 per cent of the readers' interviewed said the supplements project luxury lifestyles that were not even remotely connected to the common man.

Interviews with the journalists and the analysis of the content of the supplements showed that they are aiming to influence the young, aspirational youth who aspire for a good life, a generation that wants to own big brands in their lifestyle. However, 53 per cent of the readers interviewed said that they did not aspire for luxury lifestyles. As Pungente et al (1989) have pointed out 'Audience members bring their knowledge, experience and values to their interpretation of, and emotional responses to, media messages'. A reader said, 'There seems to be an obsession with good looking stuff. It caters majorly to the upper class.' Another reader stated: 'They give a skewed image of lifestyles that are often vulgarly ostentatious and make little sense for anyone even to aspire for them. If they are meant for youth, they fail to make any dent on that group. The intelligent youth sees through the falsity and pretension underlying these Page 3 celebrities and their lifestyles while for the rest the appeal is limited to idle browsing. A reader commented: "It would do these supplements good, if they incorporated a few intelligent features and columns on health, cinema, arts and entertainment in the city instead of only focusing on Page 3 and Bollywood gossip." Half the readers (47 per cent) enjoyed reading about Page 3 celebrities, while 47 per cent did not. 63 per cent of the readers' found these newspaper supplements to be neither interesting nor stimulating. But they all agreed that the newspaper supplements were entertaining but were not meant to be taken seriously.

Discussion

Cities are often criticized because they represent the basest instincts of human society. Culture is the quest for affluence, a powerful means of controlling cities. As a source of images and memories, it symbolizes 'who belongs' in specific places' (Lin & Mele, 2005). The typical content which emanates daily from these newspaper supplements encompasses a wide range of symbolically coded items ranging from commodities, clothes, entertainment, images, celebrity lifestyles and spectacles – all with accents on luxurious packages beyond the reach of and remotely connected to the common man. Cultural representations are purposefully used by Newspaper supplements to frame cities in a certain way to entice the youth towards a high-end lifestyle - aiding and abetting the quest for affluence in young minds. 'Discourses,' suggests Nayyar (ibid), 'morph into consumer practices, where particular kinds of bodies, objects and practices are established as the norm-safe, stylish and cosmopolitan-so that they appear natural, legitimate and desirable and lead us, consumers, to buy, practice, believe in and adopt them.' There appears to be an intentional trivialization of news content in these supplements as they focus on issues that are of little worth either intellectually or socially. The commercial attitude of the media has reduced news to trivia and lowered their informational quality. 'Today Journalism is in the threshold of a revolution in technique and production of the most modern newspaper and magazine. Vast strides have been made in gathering, style, presentation and interpretation of news.'(Parthasarathi, 1991, p.302). However, the vision of Indian journalism as a crusading vocation is being viewed with skepticism today, since 'the idea of ethics, in journalism is being challenged today by market-driven objectives' (Rajan, 2006, p.1). Newspapers are a major source of information about the outside world, but recent research also suggests that they are particularly effective at reducing the knowledge gap between the advantaged and disadvantaged, between the information-rich and the information-poor thus contributing to a more equitable pattern of citizenship. Such citizen benefits, however, only accrue if the news in question is sufficiently serious, informative and accessible to viewers.

Dumbing down and trivialization of news content about the metropolitan cities has become the trend in today's commercially-driven publications as they largely focus on encouraging immense consumerism by publishing news that is of little worth either in terms of information or education. Durkheim wrote about collective consciousness - a collective soul or conscience that guides the behavior of individuals. According to Mcquail (1987) there are certain areas where the mass media have the greatest potential for powerful societal effects by attracting and directing public attention, persuasion in matters of beliefs and opinions, influencing behavior, structuring definitions of reality. If newspapers are to serve their social responsibility role, they must provide content that informs, educates, entertains and enables the development of aesthetic sensibilities in readers. Park (1925) described cities as a mosaic of social worlds. However, the only social world that the newspaper supplements represent is the social world of the rich and the famous. In the words of city writer and Director of the Design Museum London, Sudjic (2008), "A city is a place with its dark corners and suffering. But it is precisely that edge of danger and instability that makes the city such an extraordinarily powerful force. It is in its role as an engine for change that the city is most alive." The examination of these newspaper supplements has shown that these publications have not tried to capture how ordinary people interpret and respond to the actual experience of living in cities. The findings of the research study here point to a disconnect between the commodification of urban culture that the city has come to symbolize for newspaper supplements versus the discriminating readers who are not mesmerized into adopting nor aspiring for such ostentatious lifestyles, that do not in any way epitomize the life of the common man. As for Page-3 celebrities who are flaunted daily in newspaper supplements as being the repositories of style and fashion, for the readers they constitute nothing more than a light read.

References

Castells, M. (1989). *The informational city.* Oxford: Blackwell.

Chaudhuri, M. (2010). Indian Media and its Transformed Public. In *Contributions to Indian Sociology* (Vol. 44, 1&2).

Gans, H. (1980). *More Bad News.* London: Routledge and Kegan Paul.

HT Media (online) Retrieved from http://www.htmedia.in/RightListFrame.aspx?PID=57f42c30-d699-4db8-9bab-6edd16596d50 on October 18, 2012.

Lippmann,W. (1965). *Public Opinion*. New York: Free Press.

McNair, B. (1987). *News and Journalism in the UK*. London: Routledge.

McNair, B. (1996). *News and Journalism in the UK.* London: Routledge.

McQuail, D. (1987). *Mass Communication Theory*. London: Sage.

Nayyar, P. (2009). *Packaging Life*. New Delhi: Sage Publications.

Padmanbhan,M.(2009, November 27). MetroPlus - the 10-year journey.

The Hindu e-newspaper. Retrieved from http://www.thehindu.com/arts/article55956.ece on May 5, 2012.

Parisi, P, & Holcomb,B. (1993). Symbolizing place: Journalistic narratives of the city. Journalism Quarterly, 70, 133-139. Retrieved from http://www.thefreelibrary.com on October 18, 2012.

Park,R. (1925). The City. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Parthasarathi,R. (1991).*History of Indian Journalism*.(pp.302-303). New Delhi: Sterling.

Ram, N. (2007, August 15). Newspaper futures: India and the world. The Hindu e newspaper. Retrieved from http://www.hindu.com/af/india60/stories/2007081550100300.htm on March 16, 2009.

Rajan,N. (2006). *Practising Journalism: values, constraints, implications*. (pp.1-3). New Delhi: Sage Publications.

Rodrigues, U. M., (2010). Print Media in the era of Globalization. In M. Ranganathan & U.M. Rodrigues (Eds.), *Indian media in a globalised world* (pp.52-66). CA: Thousand Oaks, Sage Publications.

Rao, S. (2010). Chindia' and Global Communication: Two media and journalisms in transition and what it means for the rest of us. Retrieved from http://web.mit.edu/comm-forum/mit7/papers/MIT7PaperRao.pdf on May 6, 2011.

Ray,J.G.N. (2006, October 27). Tabloidization of the *Media*: The *Page Three* Syndrome. Retrieved from presscouncil.nic.in/Decisions/Oct-Rew-1-239.pdf *on February 13, 2012*.

Sainath, P. (1996). *Everybody loves a good drought*. New Delhi: Penguin.

Schudson, M. (2003). *Sociology of Journalism*. (pp.150). New York: W. W. Norton.

Schlesinger,P., Scannel, P., Sparks,C.(1989). *Culture and power: a media, culture & society reader*. (pp.62-65). CA: Thousand Oaks, Sage.

Sudjic,D. (2008). Strategizing Cities. Retrieved from

www.uk.sagepub.com/.../IN%20THE%20NEWS%2... - United Kingdom on October 20, 2012.

Times Group Website. Retrieved from http://www.timesgroup.com/brands/publishing/newspapers/the-times-of-india/times-of-india-metro-Supplements-tims.html on October 10, 2012.

Zukin, S.(2005).*The Urban Sociology Reader*. (pp. 285-6). London: Routledge.

Jyoti Raghavan is Assistant Professor, Department of Journalism, Kamala Nehru College, University of Delhi, India. She did her post-graduation in Mass Communications from the University of Leicester, UK. She was awarded the British Chevening Scholarship. Earlier she had worked as journalist with United News of India and also worked with *Doordarshan* (Indian Television) and All India Radio. E-mail: *jyoti_raghavan@hotmail.com*

© *Media Watch* 4 (1) 117- 126, 2013
ISSN 0976-0911 e-ISSN 2249-8818

Embedded Health Messages in Entertainment-Education Television Programs

ROMESH CHATURVEDI
Amity School of Communication, Lucknow, India
SHRUTI MEHROTRA
Amity School of Communication, Lucknow, India

The traditional health communication strategy these days are unproductive because of their obvious aim and abundance. Entertainment education (E-E) is the format in which social messages are embedded into entertainment programming with a purpose to influence attitudes and behaviors. Television is a persuasive medium for disseminating information on a plethora of topics on health messages. Stakeholders should take advantage of television's potential for reaching audiences with health-related messages. This paper investigates youth perceptions of an HIV-AIDS message embedded in commercial television programming. The respondents were exposed to the episode of entertainment program 'Sanjivani'-A medical boon which was aired on Star Plus television channel. These data indicate that youngsters are receptive to HIV-AIDS messages within television episode. Much more research should be done in order to generalize these findings to other audiences, episodes, programs, and health-related messages. Health message was identified by majority of viewers and it was not intrusive in enjoyment of the program. The results of this study suggest that audience involvement with E-E programs is multifaceted and important to the outcome of exposure to this programming. Embedded health message entertainment education model is proposed for the cost effective dissemination of health messages.

Keywords: Entertainment education, health messages, HIV-AIDS, E-E health model, Likert scale.

Health messages can be embedded into story lines of television's most popular entertainment shows, where the marketers prominently place products such as fast-moving consumer good's and designer labels on shows. This concept has been used in developed countries but in Indian context this practice has not been explored. Global collaborations among government, public health organizations and media companies have turned the entertainment industries on several continents into one of the most powerful public health communications tools of the 21st century.

Television plays a pivotal role in disseminating health awareness among viewers. However, when messages are accurate and promote beneficial responses to health issues, entertainment media present a great opportunity to raise public awareness about important public health concerns and appropriate responses. HIV/AIDS is the worst epidemic humanity

Correspondence to: Romesh Chaturvedi, 3/288,Vinamra Khand, Gomtinagar, Lucknow-226 010, Uttar Pradesh, India, E-mail: *chaturvedi_romi@yahoo.com.* All rights reserved with Media Watch. For permissions and reprint, please e-mail: *mediawatchjournal@gmail.com*

has ever faced. It has spread further, faster and with more catastrophic long-term effects than any other disease. Its impact has become a devastating obstacle to development. Broadcast media have tremendous reach and influence, particularly with young people, who represent the future and who are the key to any successful fight against HIV/AIDS. Media organizations have an enormous influence in educating and empowering individuals to avoid contracting HIV. Doing so with maximum efficiency, however, requires a clear understanding of the challenges and the obstacles to widespread and effective HIV-prevention education.

Defining Entertainment Education

Entertainment education, also referred to as enter-educate, edutainment or infotainment, is the way of informing public about a social issue or concern. The entertainment education strategy involves incorporating an educational message into popular entertainment content in order to raise awareness, increase knowledge, create favorable attitudes, and ultimately motivate people to take socially responsible action in their own lives (Singhal & Rogers, 1999).

Over the years, the E-E strategy has been applied in a variety of ways and raised a number of social and health issues in entertainment programming, including substance abuse, immunization, teenage pregnancy, HIV/AIDS, cancer, and other diseases. (Rogers & Sabido 2003) Entertainment education, in which health-related storylines are incorporated into popular television sitcoms, dramas or soap operas, is distinct from the specific health-based programmes. More and more we see the development of television programs where health education and entertainment are combined. This E-E strategy is defined as the process of putting educational content in entertainment messages in order to increase knowledge about an issue, create favourable attitudes, and change overt behavior concerning the educational issue or topic. (Singhal & Rogers, 1990)

Entertainment media is an especially persuasive vehicle for disseminating health messages and promoting specific health behaviors. A number of studies have demonstrated that entertainment education a communication strategy in which health or social messages is embedded into entertainment programming to influence knowledge and attitudes, and promote healthy behavior among television drama audiences. In the 1970s, Miguel Sabido, a pioneer in the E-E field, designed a number of popular telenovelas that successfully promoted pro-social behaviors among Latin American audiences. (Singhal, Cody, MJ, Rogers, & Sabido, 2004) Since these early efforts, television serial dramas have been produced to address a wide range of health messages in developing countries. The strategy has been extensively used to address HIV/AIDS awareness. Embedding health messages in a popular television programs rather than starting new series based on health message allows interventions to access an existing audience.

Health in the Entertainment Media

An important facet of health communication today is to work with entertainment media to incorporate health messages in popular programs. Whether the goal is to work with grass roots or local entertainment concerns or to work with national entertainment programming, the methods and goals include a complex process of formative research to define messages, suggest storylines, and work with entertainment professionals in a consultative manner to embed programs with specific, accurate, and timely health messages. The entertainment media have a high potential to educate the public on a variety of health messages such as HIV/AIDS prevention, immunization, cancer, and family planning, maternal and child health, and others. It is one of the

few communication approaches that can be socially responsible yet commercially viable. Health communication in the mass media can be expensive. For example, *Jasoos Vijay*, the television drama broadcast in north India from 2002 to 2003, cost about US$2.2 million (Sood & Nambiar, 2006). Embedding health messages in television programs is a cost effective way of health communication. The challenge is in evaluating the cost-effectiveness of these types of initiatives and measuring the effectiveness of the program in bringing about the desired change. Like product placement for businesses, health organizations are implanting their messages into television storylines too. Both businesses and health organizations are using this similar method for the same reason: because the intent of the message is less obvious and less resistance from the viewer is aroused. According to the research, entertainment education has been shown to raise awareness and interest in health related topics. (Murphy & Hether, 2008)

Significance of Study

The study is significant in proposing the entertainment-education based model which will be effective in communicating health messages in cost effective manner. Since the message will be embedded in the storyline of popular television program, so it will cost-effective in nature as compared to producing health-based program. This model can be used by stakeholders as their corporate social responsibility initiative and this will not impose any financial liability also. This model can be applied in any form of entertainment based program like serials, reality shows, news capsule and others. Health message just needs to be embedded in storyline like product placements.

The theories addressed in the study explain how humans be given information in assorted forms and what elements needs to be incorporated to improve retention. The theories also focus on how message can be used for behavior change and awareness building which are the two integral goals of E-E.

Social Cognitive Theory

The E-E approach draws upon Albert Bandura's Social Cognitive Theory (Bandura, 1986), which posits that an individual can learn by observing and imitating the overt behaviour of others in real life or on television (vicarious learning). Bandura's Social Learning Theory also suggests that the E-E strategy of embedding health messages into storylines of popular television programs may influence modeling of health promotion behavior. Social cognitive theory focuses on the effects of entertainment education methods, such as modeling, have on individuals developing a new behavior and their self-efficacy. The theory explains that humans learn from direct observation and watching models perform a particular behavior. This element of social cognitive theory directly relates to entertainment education and specifically health messages because when an individual watches a character they relate to successfully complete a health behavior change, their self-efficacy increases. For example, if a viewer sees a character take preventative health measures and successfully complete them, they are more likely to engage in the behavior because they assume they will enjoy the same rewards for doing so that the television persona did.(Kennedy, O'Leary, Beck, Pollard, & Simpson, 2004)

Uses and Gratifications Model

In uses and gratification model, viewers actively select media products to satisfy a variety of needs like new information, entertainment, news, and more. If viewers do not *appreciate* the E&E formula they will stop watching and become less receptive to the message.

The drama must therefore be sufficiently gratifying. To entertain the audience is the aim of all program makers and even those who seek to inform and educate know that they need to be entertaining in the widest sense if the audience is to remain interested and continue viewing. To entertain and inform without alienating an audience and to keep them 'hooked on the program' is vital. (Hobson 1982) the repetition of the educational content in an E-E message is important in achieving the desired educational effect, but they warn against making the educational content too blatant or 'a hard sell'. (Singhal, Rogers & Brown, 1992)

Elaboration-Likelihood Model

This model supports the use of entertainment programming to portray pro-social messages is the elaboration likelihood model (ELM). The theory is based on the idea that motivation dictates the level of processing and amount of information received when an individual is observing a message. When an individual is motivated to receive a message's content, their elaboration is high and thus they process the information through their central route. (Dutta, 2007)

Health Belief Model

The fourth theory that sets up the framework for entertainment education is the health belief model and how its use has the ability to show individuals that a health related behavior change might be necessary. According the theory, health behavior change occurs primarily when a person perceives that they are at risk for a disease as well as the seriousness of that particular ailment. From there, they are motivated to reduce this risk and follow behavior modifications and changes suggested to them. Entertainment education, through its use of relatable characters in a television or other media program, has the ability to show audience members that preventable or active measures are needed in order to reduce their risk of a particular disease. Often, people do not feel as though they are at any type of risk for a certain ailment until a character they relate to on television is faced with the disease and then they realize the reality about their situation. (Kennedy, M.G, O'Leary, Ann, Beck, Pollard & Simpson, 2004)

Research Questions

RQ 1: How viewers identify the health message and find it effectively delivered?
RQ 2 : How viewers appreciate learning about health messages and find the information useful enough to take some action?
RQ 3 : How viewers get distract from main storyline because of embedded health message?
RQ 4 : How visual and dialogue contribute in effective message construction?
RQ 5 : How viewers appreciate integrating health message in an entertainment program and its applicability in different television Programs?

Methodology

To study the comprehensive components of EE program –'*Sanjivani - A Medical Boon*' was analyzed and it was used as a sample to be shown to the respondents. This program attempted to disseminate health message by embedding it in main storyline. It was a Hindi television serial that ran during prime time for about 3 years. It was first aired on Star Plus in 2004. *Sanjivani* tells a story about four medical interns (Juhi, Rahul, Simran, and Omi). All of them have joined

Sanjivani hospital as interns when the serial starts. The serial tells the story of how these four come into a difficult and demanding profession. They have high ideals, passion, energy; and a degree of naïveté about their work. They bring a breath of fresh air into the hospital. The story takes us through how these four doctors face the trials and tribulations in life to fight a constant battle against diseases and death of patients. The story is more like the tale of the lives of people who are regarded as miracle workers – but who are actually only human, with families, lives and emotions of their own. HIV/AIDS message integration was done through the trials and tribulations that Dr. Omi, one of the protagonists, had to go through when he got HIV infected and his status became known in the hospital. His story, spread as a sub-narrative over 7-8 episodes, dealt with his rights about disclosure of status and employment as well as discrimination in the workplace. The story ended positively with a message of hope that the hospital did not fire him. Apart from dialogues on health message on HIV/AIDS was delivered effectively by using graphical representation like signage and posters.

Study Design

To determine the effectiveness of E-E format based television programs and study research question, ten measures were employed in this research study (i) Message Identification, (ii) Message Effectiveness, (iii) Message Learning, (iv) Message Usefulness, (v) Message Persuasion, (Vi) Message Distraction, (vii) Message Construction-Visual, (viii) Message Construction-Dialogue, (ix) Entertainment-Health Message Combination, and (x) Message Replication in different television programs format. These measures will contribute to the effectiveness of embedded health messages in entertainment-education based television programs.

The first stage involved showing episode (No. 167) of *Sanjivani* to the participants in the experimental design. The second stage of the study entailed administration of a Likert scale questionnaire to those who had viewed the episode. The survey instrument consisted of 10 questions in a five-point Likert-type scale. Respondents indicated their attitude towards health-based Entertainment-Education by responding to attitudinal statements on a five point Likert-type scale of Strongly Agree, Agree, Neutral, Disagree, and Strongly Disagree. Scores of 1, 2, 3, 4, and 5 were awarded to the given statements. The data collected were summarized using descriptive statistics such as frequency, percentage, mean, standard deviation and mode.

In total 120 students were participated in the study. The mean of age of respondents was 20.05. All participants studied at the Amity University Lucknow. Their specialization varied different areas from journalism to law to advertising to engineering. Therefore the test group is a good representation of the general group of youth.

Analysis

Table-1 shows that Likert Scale results demonstrate the responses to the questions. Ordinal-level data were analyzed using descriptive statistics (Mean, standard deviation & mode). Chi-square analysis was conducted on each of these measures to determine, if there was a significant relationship between specific measures and viewers.

Table 1. Frequency distribution of the ratings on statements on Entertainment-Education by respondents (n=120)

Sl. No.	Statements	Strongly Agree	Agree	Neutral	Disagree	Strongly Disagree
1	I identified the health message shown in the TV Program.	79(65.8)	37(30.8)	3(2.5)	1(0.8)	0(0)
2	The health message in TV program was delivered effectively.	37(30.8)	61(50.8)	18(15)	3(2.5)	1(0.8)
3	I appreciate learning about health through entertainment TV Programs.	60(50)	46(38.8)	13(10.8)	0(0)	1(0.8)
4	I find health information in TV program useful.	56(46.6)	44(36.6)	14(11.6)	4(3.3)	2(1.6)
5	Information related to health awareness is sufficient to persuade me to take some action.	27(22.5)	50(41.6)	34(28.3)	9(7.5)	0(0)
6	I was distracted from the main storyline because of the embedded health message.	15(12.5)	21(17.5)	34(28.3)	35(29.1)	15(12.5)
7	Health message through a visual has a greater appeal to me.	49(40.8)	54(45)	15(12.5)	1(0.8)	1(0.8)
8	Health message through a dialogue has a greater appeal to me.	39(32.5)	51(42.5)	27(22.5)	3(2.5)	0(0)
9	Entertainment and health messages can be effectively combined.	64(53.3)	44(36.6)	11(9.1)	1(0.8)	0(0)
10	This model can be replicated in other formats of entertainment based TV programs like reality shows or news capsule.	37(30.8)	59(49.1)	19(15.8)	1(0.8)	4(3.3)

* Figures in parentheses represent percentages

Results and Discussion

Message identification

Frequency of Response: *I identified the health message shown in the TV Program*.

The responses for this measure have a mean of 1.3 (SD = 0.5). The mode for this statement is 1. The P value is less than 0.0001 (Chi square (X^2) = 70.64, Df=2, P value=0.0), this difference is considered to be extremely statistically significant. Hence health message in the serial focused on HIV-AIDS was recognized by the majority of viewers. This question was designed to test whether the viewers identified the health message embedded in the TV serials. This one had over a 95 per cent agreement rate (those who preferred agree or strongly agree).

Message effectiveness

Frequency of Response: *The health message in television program was delivered effectively.*

The responses for this measure have a mean of 1.9 (SD = 0.7). The mode for this statement is 2. The P value is less than 0.0001 (Chi square (X^2) = 62.73, Df = 3, P value = 0.0), this difference is considered to be extremely statistically significant. Hence majority of viewers opine that health message was embedded effectively in the serial. This question was designed to test the basic question that whether the health message focusing on HIV-AIDS was disseminated effectively. This one had over 80 per cent agreement rate (those who preferred agree or strongly agree). 15 per cent of the respondents were neutral about the effective delivery of the message.

Message learning

Frequency of Response: *I appreciate learning about health through entertainment TV Programs.*

The responses for this measure have a mean of 1.6 (SD = 0.74). The mode for this statement is 1. The P value is less than 0.0001 (Chi square (X^2) = 27.80, Df = 2, P value = 0.00000092), this difference is considered to be extremely statistically significant. Hence viewers appreciated learning about health information through entertainment TV programs. More than 80 per cent (agree and strongly agree) of the respondents appreciated the fact that they can learn about health related information from entertainment television programs.

Message usefulness

Frequency of Response: *I find health information in TV program useful.*

The responses for this measure have a mean of 1.7 (SD = 0.81). The mode for this statement is 1. The P value is less than 0.0001 (Chi square (X^2) = 56.79, Df = 3, P value = 0.0), this difference is considered to be extremely statistically significant. Hence health related information can be informative and useful. This research question has agreement rate of over 80 per cent of useful health message and have greater impact on viewers.

Message persuasion

Frequency of Response: *Information related to health awareness is sufficient to persuade me to take some action.*

The responses for this measure have a mean of 2.2 (SD = 0.87). The mode for this statement is 2. The P value is less than 0.0001 (Chi square (X^2) = 28.68, Df = 3, P value = 0.00000261), this difference is considered to be extremely statistically significant. Hence the health message was persuasive enough to take some further course of action. Since majority of respondents agreed with this statement (over 60 per cent), it appears that health messages embedded in entertainment programs can be used to motivate them to be health conscious and better informed.

Message distraction

Frequency of Response: *I was distracted from the main storyline because of the embedded Aids message.*

The responses for this measure have a mean of 3.1 (SD = 1.2). The mode for this statement is 4. The P value is less than 0.0001 (Chi square (X^2) = 16.31, Df = 4, P value = 0.00263), this difference is considered to be extremely statistically significant. Hence this factor has to be taken into consideration that the main plot of the serial should not be changed significantly. Embedding health message entertainment television program has an advantage of transferring the benefit of its popularity but this cannot be done at the cost of disturbing main plot of the serial. This research question was designed to find whether the viewers were distracted from the main storyline because of embedded AIDS message. Almost as many respondents were not in agreement with the statement (either disagree or strongly disagree, roughly 41 per cent) as those who were neutral (28.3 per cent). Thirty per cent of the viewers were distracted from the main storyline.

Message construction-visual

Frequency of Response: *Health message through a visual has a greater appeal to me.*

The responses for this measure have a mean of 1.7 (SD = 0.76). The mode for this statement is 2. The P value is less than 0.0001 (Chi square (X^2) = 20.14, Df = 2, P value =

0.00004233), this difference is considered to be extremely statistically significant. Hence message construction is most important and critical part of the entertainment-education format. The purpose of this question was to find the impact of visuals in the effective delivery of message. Impact of health message through visuals has greater impact had agreement rate of 85.8 per cent (those who preferred agree or strongly agree). This clearly reflects that visuals play an important role in message construction.

Message construction-dialogue

Frequency of Response: *Health message through a dialogue has a greater appeal to me.*

The responses for this measure have a mean of 2 (SD = 0.80). The mode for this statement is 2. The P value is less than 0.0001 (Chi square (X^2) = 42.00, Df = 3, P value = 0.0), this difference is considered to be statistically significant. Hence dialogue plays a important role in effective message construction. The basic purpose of message is to gain attention and to convince audience according to communicator's point of view. Seventy-five per cent of the viewers were in agreement (those who preferred agree or strongly agree) to the fact that dialogue had a significant impact in the effective delivery of the health message.

Entertainment-health message combination

Frequency of Response: *Entertainment and health messages can be effectively combined*.

The responses for this measure have a mean of 1.5 (SD = 0.69). The mode for this statement is 1. The P value is less than 0.0001 (Chi square (X^2) = 34.40, Df = 2, P value = 0.00000003), this difference is considered to be extremely statistically significant. Hence viewers are receptive about the model of health messages being combined with the entertainment program. Over 97 per cent of the respondents were in agreement (those who preferred agree or strongly agree) to the fact that entertainment and health message can be effectively combined.

Message replication in different TV programs format

Frequency of Response: *This model can be replicated in other formats of entertainment based TV programs like reality shows or news capsule*.

The responses for this measure have a mean of 1.8 (SD = 0.69). The mode for this statement is 2. The P value is less than 0.0001 (Chi square (X^2) = 54.52, Df = 3, P value = 0.0), this difference is considered to be extremely statistically significant. Hence health messages can be embedded in different television program formats like reality shows, news capsule etc.79.9 per cent of the respondents were in agreement (those who preferred agree or strongly agree) to the fact that this model can be applied in different television programs while 15.8 per cent were neutral towards the question.

Proposed Model

Based on the findings of the study we propose a model for the effective communication of health messages by embedding them in popular television Programs of different formats like serials, reality shows, and news capsule etc. Idea (health message) can be embedded in storyline of any television program. The findings suggest that respondents (viewers) are receptive about the message effectiveness and the health messages can be persuasive to motivate them to take some action.

The model suggests that health message should be embedded in storyline of different television Programme with minimum noise in form of distraction from main storyline. Health

message should be embedded in such a manner that it is easily identified in effective manner. Health message should enable learning and persuasion in form of some action. Message construction should be done effectively focusing more on visuals than on dialogues. Embedded health message entertainment-education model is proposed for the cost effective dissemination of health messages.

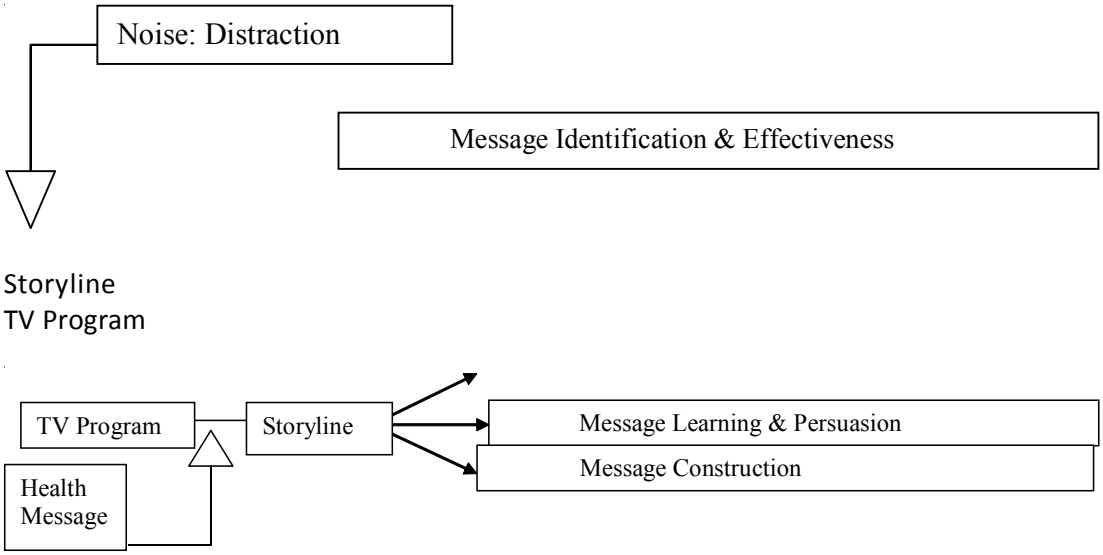


Figure 1. Embedded health message Entertainment-Education Model

Conclusion

The research study indicates the role of entertainment media in disseminating health messages among viewers. In conclusion research study supports that embedding health messages in entertainment program will effectively disseminate the health message in cost effective manner. Focusing on message construction elements like visual and dialogue are likely to increase the effectiveness of an entertainment-education program. Notably, the evaluation found that viewers of the program identified the health and appreciated learning about them through entertainment-education programs. Effectively embedded health message enabled viewers to acquire new knowledge and take some action. If the message is incorporated effectively then the viewers will not be distracted from the storyline. Furthermore, this study suggests that the model of entertainment-health education intervention can be done in different TV program format like reality shows, news capsule etc. The study concluded that youth's attitude towards the use of entertainment-education strategy for health message dissemination is favourable. Embedded health message entertainment-education model enables cost effective dissemination of health messages. It is recommended that the stakeholders should intensify efforts on the use of Entertainment- Education strategy for promoting health messages. The model holds great promise for future health promotion efforts aimed at improving the health and well-being of diverse audience.

References

Bandura, A. (1986) *Social Foundations of Thought and Action; A social cognitive theory*. Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall.

Dutta, M. (2007). Health information processing from television: the role of health orientation. Health Communication.

Hobson, D. (1982) *Crossroads: The Drama of a Soap Opera*. Methuen, London.

Kennedy, O'Leary, Beck, Pollard & Simpson(2004). Entertainment education and multicultural audiences: an action and research agenda. The Community Psychologist, 37(2), Retrieved from http://www.learcenter.org/pdf /EEconference.pdf Accessed March 10, 2012.

Murphy, S, & Hether, H. (2008). How Healthy is prime time? The Kaiser Family Foundation, Retrieved from http://www.learcenter.org/pdf/Howhealthyisprimetime.pdf. Accessed on March 15, 2012.

Rogers, and Sabido (2003) For an overview of the field and a discussion of early E-E efforts, see Arvind Singhal, Michael Cody, Everett Rogers, and Miguel Sabido (Eds), *Entertainment-Education and Social Change: History, Research and Practice*, (Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates, 2003).

Singhal, A. and Rogers, E.M. (1990) Television Soap Operas for Development in India. *Gazette*, 41: 109-126.

Singhal, A., Rogers E.M. and Brown, W.J. (1992) Entertainment Telenovelas for Development: lessons learned about creation and implementation. *A paper presented to the International Association for Mass Communication Research*, Sao Paulo, Brazil, august 16-21, 1992.

Singhal and Rogers (1999) *Entertainment-Education: A Communication Strategy for Social Change* (Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates, 1999).

Singhal, Cody, MJ, Rogers, Sabido (2004) A History of Entertainment-Education, 1958-2000. *Entertainment-Education and Social Change: history, Research and Practice*. Mahway, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates; 2004; 21-38.

Sood and Nambiar(2006) Comparative cost-effectiveness of the components of a behavior change communication campaign on HIV/AIDS in North India. Journal of Health Communication (11 Suppl. 2): 143-162. 2006.

Romesh Chaturvedi is a Sr. Lecturer, Electronic Media in Amity School of Communication, Amity University, Lucknow-226 010, Uttar Pradesh, India. E-mail: *chaturvedi_romi@yahoo.com*

Shruti Mehrotra is a Lecturer with Amity School of Communication, Amity University, Lucknow-226 010, Uttar Pradesh, India. Her areas of specialization include advertising, brand management and corporate communication. E-mail: *meet_mehrotrashruti@rediffmail.com*

Review Paper

© *Media Watch* 4 (1) 127- 128, 2013
ISSN 0976-0911 e-ISSN 2249-8818

Women as a Maker of Meaning in *No One Killed Jessica*

G. K. SAHU
Aligarh Muslim University, India
SAMEERA KHAN REHMANI
Aligarh Muslim University, India

For centuries women occupied a subordinate position in the patriarchal social order and in turn represented as a bearer rather than maker of meaning in several texts. Laura Mulvey noted that "women stand in patriarchal culture as signifier for the male other, bound by a symbolic order in which man can live out his fantasies and obsessions through linguistic command by imposing them on the silent image of woman still tied to her place as bearer of meaning, not maker of meaning" (Mulvey, 2000). This argument can be seen in countless movies across generations and cultures. Mainstream Hindi film industry churned out countless movies where women represented as bearer rather than maker of meaning. However, the film *No One Killed Jessica* seems to be a departure from this trend. Its successful run at the box office implies most of the audience identifies with the film's representation of society and individuals. As per general perception it had a strong impact on the society regarding the changing image of women.

No One Killed Jessica perhaps one of the rare films where the male gaze is absent, largely because there are no male protagonists, no song and dance sequences, and no overt sexual shots. The female lead is represented in a very masculine form. The film paved the way for newer films to represent women and their issues in a positive light by breaking the existing stereotypes. From the sociological perspective films understood as a mirror which reflects the society but produces a limited or distorted reflection because of masculine bias.

The film was purposively chosen for the study because the film was unusual in many respects. The film was based on a true story of Jessica Lal murder case that shocked the entire nation and generated a public outcry when the perpetrators were acquitted by a court. Subsequently, the media took up the case rigorously and managed to pressurize the higher courts to reopen the case and finally the guilty were put behind bars. The film showed touches of serious cinema as well. It has a combination of artistic and commercial acumen.

Construction of reality presupposes the establishment of reality. The basic premise of cinematic suspension of disbelief is the realization that all that appears real on screen is actually a construction of reality. The reality of Indian women has found its way straight into the silver screen. Since beginning, women in popular Hindi cinema have their set roles: somebody's daughter, wife, sister or mother. A modern woman has been portrayed to possess a less performative character. The film starts in a format of a hard-hitting documentary.

This movie boasts of two main characters—Sabrina Lal (Vidya Balan) and Meera Gaity (Rani Mukherjee). Sabrina is shown to be simple, calm, nerdy, and docile and appears to be contended in her own space. She takes a back-seat in all the aspects of life as compared to her sister (Jessica Lal). She is media shy and far from the glamorous personality of Meera and Jessica.

Correspondence to : G. K. Sahu, Assistant Professor, Department of Journalism & Mass Communication, Aligarh Muslim University, Aligarh-202 002, India. E-mail*: sahugk6@gmail.com*. All rights reserved with Media Watch. For permissions and reprint, please e-mail: *mediawatchjournal@gmail.com*

Meera is a fictional character, symbolizing sensational but a role model of a journalist. She has been established herself from the beginning of the film, first through her voice which delivers a monologue on Delhi's inherent complexity and its fascination with power and then her credentials are established through her coverage of important but difficult news assignments. Her character is celebrated as a woman of substance, but subliminally, it was established as a transgendered male performance, as if the lines and the role was written for a male character but the sex was changed at the last moment. Meera goes to great lengths to establish her gender performativity as male using tropes like frequent verbal abuse; dominant and emotionally detached frequent physical relationships; absence of family issues etc. Her stance of sitting and drinking tea in the office, her behavior with her colleagues and her maid furthers this establishment. The contrast lies in, the real women journalists who actually went to great lengths to solve this case and is comfortable in their gender.

Professionally, Meera comes out as a hard-hitting reporter. Her character is smart, dynamic, selfish, bitchy, successful, and manipulative. In fact, it seems as if the director of the film has a deliberate intention of creating such contrasting characters on the same platform. Jessica Lal, the omnipresent character throughout the film, even after her death, is the actual anchor of the story. Her character evolves as a young model – free-spirited and modern—an individual who is not scared to pick a fight while protecting her sister (Sabrina) against harassment. However, the stereotyping does not leave her ever.

The paradigm in the series of shots and the delicate imagery tend to establish a dangerous line of thought – those who try to move away from the patriarchal hegemonies in place will have to face the brunt one day – the audience is prepared to see Jessica get the bullet! The audience sense the danger even more closely as the first gunshot goes off and yet another. Her fall in slow motion takes its time to ensure that the moment is mimetically established and mourned in the subconscious of the viewers.

Although Meera Gaity operates on similar thoughts of rebellion and modernity, she is shown to have a different end, a victorious one. Perhaps this was done to signify, that the good has to lean on the bad to fight and win over the ugly. After she has literally broken down in her fight for justice for Jessica, Sabrina grabs the hand of Meera to fine the justice against the evil doers.

Despite the stereotype representations in the film, the characters of Meera and Sabrina are very important, especially for Hindi Cinema. Apart from the male mannerisms and extremities of the characters; both of them shown to be strong in their own right (Sabrina to start the battle of justice and Meera to finish it). In fact, Meera is projected to ultimately possess a conscience and in following that she leaves no stone unturned to get justice for Jessica's murder case. There have been very few movies that show women in such revolutionary light. Also it is noteworthy that this movie again shows two female leads and males as supporting cast. Above all, the woman in the film has been given an out of the box characteristics, making them look league apart from the rest. However, the reality is there stereotypes of images have been created and recreated consciously or unconsciously by the makers. The audience perception of the film is of applause, yet they in a way identify their stereotypical perceptions with the created reality in *No One Killed Jessica*. The film commendably made an effort to break the gender stereotypes by projecting the image of women as a maker rather than a bearer of meaning in the mainstream commercial Hindi cinema.

G. K. Sahu is Assistant Professor in the Department of Journalism & Mass Communication at Aligarh Muslim University, Aligarh-202 002, India. E-mail: *sahugk6@gmail.com*

Sameera Khan Rehmani is a Research Scholar in the Department of Journalism & Mass Communication at Aligarh Muslim University, Aligarh-202 002, India. E-mail: *skrehmani@rediffmail.com*